

Old clothes donation centres launched at 5 metro stations to boost recycling

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday launched five "Arpan Kendra" donation centres at major metro stations across the city. The initiative is a part of a new drive to collect and recycle old clothes with help from women's self-help groups. The centres opened at Shalimar Bagh, Punjabi Bagh West, Mayur Vihar Phase-I, Shahdara and Rohini West metro stations. The Chief Minister inaugurated the flagship centre at Punjabi Bagh West, where she reviewed a QR code system that lets citizens donate clothes digitally and receive a digital receipt for each contribution.

The project is a joint effort between the Delhi Government, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) and the Delhi Metro Ladies Welfare Organisation. A Memorandum of Understanding has already been signed between the three parties. Five more centres are planned as part of a wider rollout to ten major metro stations across the city.



Speaking at the launch, the Chief Minister said a developed Delhi cannot be measured only by roads, bridges and metro lines. She said responsible citizenship and respect for resources are equally important markers of progress, and that a truly developed society emerges when waste is converted into a usable resource alongside infrastructure growth.

The Chief Minister said recycling old garments helps save water, energy and natural resources, beyond simply cutting down on waste. She added that every piece of clothing donated by a resident could support environmental protection while



also improving the life of someone in need.

Madipur MLA Kailash Gangwal, DMRC Managing Director Vikas Kumar and Delhi Metro Ladies Welfare Organisation President Shalini Singh attended the launch event, along with senior officials from both organisations. Under the plan, kiosks for collecting and selling old textiles will operate at each selected metro station. Citizens can drop off garments that are still usable, and the entire process has been digitised to keep it transparent and simple for donors.

The Chief Minister highlighted the role of women's self-help groups in running

the centres. Women will handle collection, sorting, recycling and upcycling of donated clothes, creating fresh livelihood opportunities and avenues for self-employment, she said.

She described the initiative as a model that combines environmental action with women's empowerment, calling it a step toward sustainable development in Delhi. The state Government, she said, would keep supporting projects that bring together environmental protection, job creation, women's empowerment and public involvement.

The Chief Minister called the programme a strong example of India's circular economy in action, turning the idea of "waste to wealth" into a working reality on the ground. She urged Delhi residents to bring their old but usable clothes to the Arpan Kendras, saying that even small contributions from individual households could meaningfully cut the amount of textile waste sent to landfills. She added that such donations would also help conserve resources and support underprivileged communities.

Government announces free 1-year residential coaching for JEE, NEET aspirants

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Monday announced a free one-year residential coaching programme for JEE and NEET aspirants studying in Class 12 in Government and Government-aided schools under a scholarship offered by a Pune-based non-profit organisation.

The Delhi Directorate of Education (DoE) has informed Government and Government-aided schools about a free one-year residential coaching programme for students preparing for the Joint Entrance Examination (JEE) and the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) under a scholarship offered by the Dakshana Foundation.

Students will be selected through the Joint Dakshana Selection Test (JSDT) 2027, which is scheduled to be held in December this year.

According to a circular issued by the DoE, the



scholarship is open to meritorious and deserving students of Class 12 (Science) studying in Government and Government-aided schools during the current academic session.

The selected students will receive free residential coaching for one year at the foundation's campus, Dakshana Valley, located in Kadus village in Pune district of Maharashtra, it stated.

The programme will be provided at no cost to the students and will include free coaching, accommodation and food for the entire duration of the course, the department said.

Couple killed as house roof collapses in New Usmanpur, case filed against owner



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A couple died after the roof of their one-storey house collapsed in Delhi's New Usmanpur area, police said on Monday.

The incident took place at around 10 pm on Sunday in JP Nagar under the New Usmanpur police station limits. A child, who was present close to the house, escaped unhurt, they said.

According to the police, the couple was inside the rented accommodation when the roof of the house suddenly gave way, trapping them under the debris. Police, fire department personnel and rescue teams rushed to the spot after receiving information about the collapse and launched a rescue operation. The couple was pulled out from the rubble and taken to a hospital, where doctors declared them dead.

The deceased were identified as Tinku (32) and his wife Urmila (30), police said. Police said the exact cause of the collapse is yet to be ascertained. An investigation into the incident is underway. The bodies have been sent to GTB Hospital for post-mortem.

A case under Sections 290 (negligent conduct)

and 106(1) (causing death by negligence) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita has been registered against the owner of the house, Virender Kumar. Further investigation is in progress.

Soon after the roof collapsed, scores of residents gathered at the spot and joined the rescue efforts before emergency teams arrived. Balbir Singh, a local, said he was returning home when his son informed him about the incident.

"When I reached the spot, I saw a large number of residents, including men, women and youngsters, clearing the debris to rescue the trapped couple. They were pulled out and rushed to a nearby hospital, but doctors could not save them," Singh said.

He claimed the house was around 20 years old and that the landlord had recently asked the tenants to vacate it to undertake repair work. "It is a very tragic incident," he added.

Another resident, Ram Yadav, said locals immediately alerted the police and started rescue operations. He said the couple's child escaped unhurt as he was playing outside the house when the roof collapsed.

Mohammad Haroon takes charge as Delhi Minorities Commission member

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Mohammad Haroon on Monday assumed charge as the newly appointed Member of the Delhi Minorities Commission. The occasion was attended by hundreds of his supporters, well-wishers, and representatives of various social organisations, who extended their congratulations and best wishes on his new responsibility.

After assuming office,



Mohammad Haroon said that he would discharge his responsibilities as a Member of the Delhi Minorities Commission with utmost dedication, transparency,

and impartiality. He affirmed his commitment to safeguarding the rights of minority communities and working wholeheartedly for their welfare.

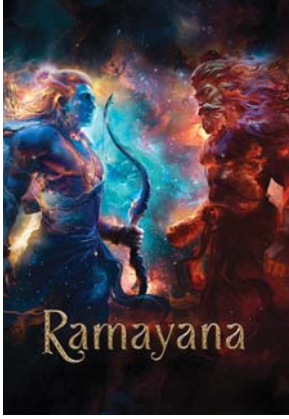
He stated that the Commission would give priority to issues related to education, employment, social justice, and public welfare. He also emphasised that effective efforts would be made to strengthen mutual harmony, brotherhood, and social cohesion among all sections of society.

Ramlila Mahasangh seeks pre-release screening of Ranbir Kapoor's Ramayana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Shri Ramlila Mahasangh has written to the makers of actor Ranbir Kapoor-starrer Ramayana, seeking a special screening of the film for its representatives before its theatrical release, claiming certain scenes could hurt the sentiments of Hindus.

The organisation's president Arjun Kumar said a letter had been sent to director Nitesh Tiwari and the film's production company,



requesting that the delegation of Shri Ramlila Mahasangh be allowed to watch the film before it is released in cinemas during Diwali.

Referring to the 2023 film Adipurush, Kumar told PTI that several scenes in that film had drawn objections from members of the Sanatan community and people associated with Ramlila performances. He claimed those objections included the depiction of Lanka and the portrayal of Ravana and his army.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, No. 15432324Y Hav/NA Pandhare Sunil Aheluba, R/o At Post- Avhana, Teh-Bhokardan, Dist- Jalna, Maharashtra- 431114, have changed my Mother's name in my service record from Kantabai to Pandhare Kantabai Aheluba, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.14859588F NK/TLR Abhinesh Kumar, R/o- Vill/PO- Nawa Mahmoodpur, Sitapur, Uttar Pradesh- 261125, have changed my son's name from Hrdyansh Partap Singh to Hridyansh Singh, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Galla V L Ganapathi, Father of No. 17018979Y NK Galla Kailash Kumar, R/o- D No. 3-289 Vill- & Po- Aganampudi, Teh- Gajuwaka, Dist- Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh- 530046, have changed my name from Galla V L Ganapathi to Galla Venkata Lakshmi Ganapathi, Vide Affidavit Dated 03/08/2026 Before Notary Public Delhi.

I, B Mallesu, Father of- No.15780425H Hav (OCC) Bongu Hema Rao, R/o- Vill/PO- Peddamurahaipuram, Teh- Vajrapukotturu, Dist- Srikakulam, Andhra Pradesh- 532218-, have changed my name from B Mallesu to Bongu Mallesh, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, B Tulasimma, Mother of- No.15780425H Hav (OCC) Bongu Hema Rao, R/o- Vill/PO- Peddamurahaipuram, Teh- Vajrapukotturu, Dist- Srikakulam, Andhra Pradesh- 532218-, have changed my name from B Tulasimma to Bongu Tulasimma, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No. 15819592X Hav Madan, R/o- VPO- Bhawar, Dist- Sonipat, Haryana- 131302, have changed my Mother's name in my Army Service record from Karishana Devi to Krishana, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Najma Bewa, Mother of- No.15786737P Hav MD ASIK SK, R/o- Vill- Chhotoina, PO- Juranpur, Teh- Krishnagar, Dist- Nadia, West Bengal- 741150, have changed my name from Najma Bewa to Nazma Bewa, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Ramjit Yadav, Father of- No.15715257F Hav Vijay Yadav, R/o- Vill- Murdi, PO- Garthma, Dist- Varanasi, U.P- 221208, have changed my name from Ramjit Yadav to Ramjeet Yadav, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Sumitra Devi, Mother of- No.15715257F Hav Vijay Yadav, R/o- Vill- Murdi, PO- Garthma, Dist- Varanasi, U.P- 221208, have changed my name from Sumitra Devi to Sumitria, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Rekha Yadav, Wife of- No.15715257F Hav Vijay Yadav, R/o- Vill- Murdi, PO- Garthma, Dist- Varanasi, U.P- 221208, have changed my name from Rekha Yadav to Rekha, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Gulesta Bibi, Mother of No.15232521X Hav Sarfaraj Alam, R/o- Vill- Porsha, PO & P.S- Itahar, Teh- Raiganj, Dist- Uttar Dinaj Pur, West Bengal- 733128, have changed my name from Gulesta Bibi to Galesta Bibi, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, T. Swaroopa, D/o JC- 781445W Nb Sub Tamada Dhanraju, R/o- Vill- Deegipur PO- Gopalpur, Dist- Ganjam, Odisha- 761002-, have changed my name from T. Swaroopa to T. Suaroopa, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Parmar Alpalben Kismat, W/o- No.15798327L L/NK (DMT) Parmar Kismat Kumar Pravin Kumar, R/o- At Post- Sudasana, Teh- Satlasana, Dist- Mehsana, Gujarat- 384340, have changed my name from Parmar Alpalben Kismat to Parmar Alpalben, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Devidas, Father of- No.6501442Y Nk Devappa Naik, R/o- Manki, Sannagunda, # 1206, Honnavar, Uttar Kannada, Karnataka- 581348, have changed my name from Devidas to Devidas Naik, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Tara, Mother of- No.6501442Y Nk Devappa Naik, R/o- Manki, Sannagunda, # 1206, Honnavar, Uttar Kannada, Karnataka- 581348, have changed my name from Tara to Tara Devidas Naik, vide affidavit dated 03/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Shubham Kumar S/o Pradeep Kumar R/o 136, Suraj Nagar, Ram Pura, Kata Bagh, Karnal, Haryana 132001 have changed my name as Shubham.

I, Baleshwar Prasad S/o Late Sh. Mahadev Prasad R/o B-9, Pocket-2, sector-16A, J.J.Colony, Dwarka, Kakrola, Delhi-110078 declare that Baleshwar Prasad and Baleshwar Prasad both are same person.

I, Rahul Singh S/o Mr. Birendra Prasad Singh R/o Tower-B7, Flat-1503, Panchsheel Greens-2, Near 1 Murti, Greater Noida West, Sector-1, Greater Noida West, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201316. Hereby declare that my name wrongly mentioned in my education Certificates is Rahul Kumar Singh and Pan Card, Aadhar Card is Rahul Singh henceforth Rahul Kumar Singh and Rahul Singh both are one and the same persons.

I, Amit Kumar S/o Ramesh Meena R/o 4/92, 3rd Floor, Ramesh Nagar, Delhi-110015 have changed my name as Ramesh Chand Meena.

I, Ramesh Meena S/o Kishan Lal Meena R/o 1B/1, Single Storey, Ramesh Nagar, Delhi-110015 have changed my name as Ramesh Chand Meena.

I, Geeta Kumar W/o Amit Meena R/o 4/92, 3rd Floor, Ramesh Nagar, Delhi-110015 have changed my name as Geeta Meena.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Be it known to all that I, DC BORA ALIAS DWIJEN CHANDRA BORA S/O MC BORA ALIAS MUHIN CH BORA R/O MP-124-B PITAMPURA DELHI-34 have disowned my son Varun Borah from all movable/immovable properties and severed all their relations both legal & social by Varun Borah due to disrespectful behavior towards me. Any person dealing or relation with varun borah shall be doing so at his/her own risk I shall not be responsible for the same.

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform to all concern that Shri Babu S/o Shri Raju R/o Village Chhaprauli Banger, Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.) who is the original owner of Residential Plot No.AS-06, Sector-145, Noida (U.P.) Shri Babu expired on 10.10.2014.

The WILL was executed in favour of Shri Naveen Chauhan S/o Shri Vikram Singh Chauhan R/o H.No.324, Sector-17, Faridabad (Haryana), which is registered in Sub Registrar-III, Noida Bahi No.3, Jild No.315, Page No.225-234, Sector.No.3642 at Dt. 21.11.2011. So it is informed to all concern that the said Property Plot No. AS-06, Sector-145, Noida (U.P.) is going to be transferred in favour of Shri Naveen Chauhan S/o Shri Vikram Singh Chauhan R/o H.No.324, Sector-17, Faridabad (Haryana) If anyone has/have any objection he/she may file his/her objection alongwith the sufficient proof in the Residential Plot Department of the Noida Authority within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice.

Sh. Naveen Chauhan

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the general public that Mr. Someen Ali is the GPA Holder of the Plot area measuring 55 Sq. Yds. Out of Khata No. 141 situated in the Village Dasna, Pargana Dasna, Tehsil & Distt. Ghaziabad U.P. through Sale Deed dated 18.07.2013 as doc. no. 4449 executed by Mrs. Rajesh Devi in favour of Mr. Harun Ali and Mr. Someen Ali in respect of said Property. Thereafter, He is possession through Regd. GPA in block registration No. 1126 executed by Mr. Harun Ali and Mr. Someen Ali in favour of Mr. Someen Ali in respect of said Property. Mr. Someen Ali intends to transfer the ownership of above said plot by way of Sale Deed to Mrs. Neelam Devi. Subsequently, Mrs. Neelam Devi are in the process of mortgaging the said plot with Aavas Financiers Limited. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. If any objections submitted after the stipulated 7-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client. If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-days period by contacting Law Veritas (Non-Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida (U.P.)-201301. Landline: +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

LOST & FOUND
The original allotment letter for my flat, Flat No. 36, 2nd Floor, Arun Vihar Sector 28, Noida, Distt Gautam Buddh Nagar, has been misplaced. Its use by others is unauthorized. Please inform us upon finding it. Ranjit Kumar Sinha, S/o- Jai Kishore Prasad and Rupam Sinha, W/o- Ranjit Kumar Sinha, R/o- 27, Flat No. 1804, Lotus Panash Sector 110, Noida, Distt Gautam Buddh Nagar, M.No. 9582805896.

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Raj Rani, D/o Shri Babul, Registrant (Allottee/Mutatee of Application No. 217670 under Rohini Residential Scheme, 1981 had submitted FDR No. 13103 Dated 31.03.81 Amounting to Rs. 750/- . It is hereby informed that the aforesaid original FDR of property Flat No. 267, Pocket C-1, Sector-35, Rohini, Delhi has been lost/misplaced by me. In this regard, an Information Report No. LR No. 500303/2026 dated 31.07.2026 has been lodged at Police Station Nand Nagari. An Indemnity Bond has also been executed regarding loss of the said FDR. If anybody has any objection/claim regarding the aforesaid FDR or finds the same, he/she may contact the undersigned within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. Address: H.No. 1081, Janta Flat, G.T.B. Enclave, Nand Nagri, Dilshad Garden, Delhi-110095 Mobile: 8826875272

Sd/-
Raj Rani

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform to all concern that Shri Manoj S/o Shri Raju R/o Village Chhaprauli Banger, Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.) who is the original owner of Residential Plot No.AS-04, Sector-145, Noida (U.P.) Shri Manoj expired on 22.01.2016. The WILL was executed in favour of Shri Vikram Singh Chauhan S/o Late Shri Srichand R/o H.No.324, Sector-17, Faridabad (Haryana), which is registered in Sub Registrar-III, Noida Bahi No.3, Jild No.310, Page No.109-122, Sector.No.3437 at Dt. 08.11.2011. So it is informed to all concern that the said Property Plot No. AS-04, Sector-145, Noida (U.P.) is going to be transferred in favour of Shri Vikram Singh Chauhan S/o Late Shri Srichand R/o H.No.324, Sector-17, Faridabad (Haryana) If anyone has/have any objection he/she may file his/her objection alongwith the sufficient proof in the Residential Plot Department of the Noida Authority within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice.

Sh. Vikram Singh Chauhan

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Smt. Sheetal, W/o Sh. Kishore Lohia, R/o 5A, DDA Flats, Gazipur, Vasundhara Enclave, East Delhi-110096, hereby inform the general public that I have disowned and severed all relations with my son Sh. Herry Lohia and his wife Smt. Kanak Gowami due to personal reasons. Henceforth, they shall have no concern with my movable or immovable properties. I shall not be responsible for any act, transaction, liability or obligation undertaken by them. Any person dealing with them shall do so at his/her own risk.

Naveen Lohia (Advocate) Ch. No. 407, 4th Floor, Chamber Block, District Court Saket, Saket, New Delhi-110017

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the general public that Mr. Vishal Nagar is the owner of the Residential House, measuring 1400 sq. yards i.e. 1370.56 sq. mtrs., of Plot No. 348, situated at Rukmanidhri Mirti urf Fafunda, Near Bank of Baroda, Tehsil and District Meerut through Gift Deed dated 28.07.2026 as doc. no. 9495 executed by Mr. Shyam Manohar Singh in favour of Mr. Vishal Nagar in respect of said property.

Mr. Vishal Nagar is in the process of mortgaging the said property with Hdfc Finance Limited. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client. If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-day period by contacting Law Veritas (Non-Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. Landline: +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

SATYENDER YADAV (Advocate)
Ch.No.561, 5th Floor, Saket Courts, New Delhi. M. 9711212421, Email: satender175@gmail.com

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Saanvi Krishnan D/o Ramakrishnan Krishnan assigned as female at the time of birth registered at B-44, second floor, Gulmohar Park, New Delhi 110049 undertake that I want to change my name to Savitr Sriniv Krishnan and gender as Male. I Saanvi Krishnan henceforth be known as Savitr Sriniv Krishnan S/o Ramakrishnan Krishnan

NORTHERN RAILWAY		
E-TENDER NOTICE		
Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/Traction Distribution, DRM's Office, State Entry Road, New Delhi for & on behalf of President of India, invites open e-tender for the under noted work:		
1. Name of Work with its location	Augmentation/ Replacement of Contact wire over Delhi Division (8th Phase).	
2. Approx. Cost of work		Rs. 1,53,06,448.56/-
3. Earnest Money Deposit		Rs. 3,06,100/-
4. E-Tender Bid Online Submission Period		11.08.2026 (00.00 Hrs.) to 25.08.2026 (15.00 Hrs.)
5. E-Tender Bid Submission End Date & E-Tender Open Date & Time		25.08.2026 (15.00 hrs.)
6. Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen		www.ireps.gov.in

E-Tender No.: 08C-TRD-NDLS-2026-27 Dated 03.08.2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 2679/26

PUBLIC NOTICE
(Regarding Loss of Original Sale Deeds)
Notice is hereby given to the general public that the original Sale Deeds pertaining to **Property No. S-138, Basement Floor, Greater Kailash-I, New Delhi-110048** have been lost. A Lost Report bearing LR No. **496681/2026** has been lodged with Delhi Police. The lost documents are:
1. Sale Deed dated **11.02.2005**, Document No. 2142, Book No. 1, Volume No. 4714, Pages 24-37.
2. Sale Deed dated **09.03.2005**, Document No. 3459, Book No. 1, Volume No. 4788, Pages 99-110.
3. Sale Deed dated **06.01.2006**, Document No. 293, Book No. 1, Volume No. 5767, Pages 63-87.
Any person having found the above documents or having any claim, right, title, interest or objection in respect thereof is requested to contact the undersigned within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which no claim shall be entertained.

Avijit Singh
Owner
Email: avijit.counselor@gmail.com
Mobile: +91 8130729886

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the public that my client Mr. Nitin Kumar Goyal intends to purchase Apartment No.W1-B 111, in Wing-B, 11th Floor, with parking Space No. 1 BO-24, (open/Covered) in Multistorey Building No.1, in Wellington Estate, DLF City Phase-V, Village Wazirabad, Tehsil Gurgaon, District Gurgaon, Haryana from Mr. Charanbir Singh Paul having acquired 1/3 rd share of the property upon demise of his father Late Shri Balbir Singh by virtue of Judgement passed on 03.08.2024 and 1/3 rd share upon demise of his mother Smt. Surjit Paul by virtue of Registered Will dated 31.10.2022 and 1/3 rd share from his sister Mrs. Gunet Bhatia by virtue of Transfer Deed dated 16.03.2026 and now my client purchasing the said property from said Mr. Charanbir Singh Paul (the present owner). If anybody including Bank, Financial Institutions, persons, relative has any claim, right, interest whatsoever in the said property shall inform within 10 days to the undersigned with documentary evidence. In the event of no response to this notice, then my clients shall presume that title of the said property is unencumbered and clear.

Karnail Singh, (Advocate)
K-8, Basement, Jungpura Extension New Delhi.
Contact No. 9811163363 & 9953683363.

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform to all concern that Mr. Navin Kukreja S/o Late Sh. Ram Kukreja R/o D-1055, New Friends Colony, Kalka Ji, South Delhi, Delhi-110026 who is the joint allottee and 85% share holder/partner of Industrial Plot/shed No. 30, Block-B, Sector-02 Noida (U.P.), my husband Mr. Navin Kukreja was so informed to all concern that after the death of my husband the above said 85% share in the above said plot/premises is going to be transferred/mutation in favour Mrs. Niti Kukreja W/o Late Navin Kukreja S/o Late Sh. Ram Kukreja R/o D-1055, New Friends Colony, Kalka Ji, South Delhi, Delhi-110026. If any one has/have any objection he/she may file his/her objection alongwith the sufficient proof in the office of Industrial Department of the Noida Authority within 30 days from the date of publication of this notice.

Niti Kukreja

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the public that my clients clients Dr. Priyadarshini Ghosh and Dr. Ritesh Debroy intends to purchase Entire First Floor of Freehold Property No. G-1356, Chittaranjan Park, New Delhi from Mrs. Rana Gill who had jointly purchased the said property alongwith her father Dr. C.M.S. Siddhu vide two separate Sale Deeds dated 02.05.1996. That Dr. C.M.S. Siddhu had expired on 13.08.2004 in the wife of Smt. Parminder Kaur Siddhu already predeceased him on 30.12.1994 leaving behind her daughter Mrs. Rana Gill as only 1st Class Legal heirs and now my clients purchasing the said property from said Mrs. Rana Gill (the present owner). If anybody including Bank, Financial Institutions, persons, relative has any claim, right, interest whatsoever in the said property shall inform within 15 days to the undersigned with documentary evidence. In the event of no response to this notice, then my clients shall presume that title of the said property is unencumbered and clear.

Karnail Singh, (Advocate)
K-8, Basement, Jungpura Extension New Delhi.
Contact No. 9811163363 & 9953683363.

Staircase inspired murder: Man held near Mathura with ₹12.75 lakh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Believing that lessons from a Hollywood crime series would help him outsmart investigators, a 53-year-old Delhi man allegedly murdered his wife over a property dispute and fled with lakhs of rupees in cash, only to be tracked down through technical surveillance, police said on Monday.

The accused, Kamal Singh, was arrested near Mathura Railway Station after a multi-state manhunt by the Shahdara district police. During interrogation, he told investigators that he had been influenced by “The Staircase” and believed that hiding the murder weapon and placing another instrument of crime at the scene would help him evade the police.

The murder came to light on the night of July 30 after the couple’s son returned home and found his mother, Komal Singh (50), lying in a pool of blood in their Gagan Vihar residence in Delhi’s Shahdara.

“The woman was found lying in



a pool of blood with a blood-stained pair of scissors placed in her hand to make it appear that she had stabbed herself. However, the victim’s son suspected that his father had murdered his mother,” a senior police officer said.

During the investigation, police discovered that the accused had also purchased a sword, which was later recovered and found to be the actual murder weapon. He had concealed it in his bag and attempted to dispose of it to destroy evidence.

Police said, however, that CCTV footage became the biggest clue in

unravelling the case. The footage established that after the couple’s two children left the house in the morning, only the accused and the victim remained inside.

Police also found footage allegedly capturing the victim’s screams, followed by the accused leaving the house after concealing the weapon, believed to be the sword, in a bag.

“Probe revealed that Singh had withdrawn around Rs 7 lakh from his bank accounts before going into hiding. Technical surveillance tracked his movement from Delhi towards Gorakhpur, where

he allegedly planned to escape to Nepal before abruptly changing course and heading towards Mathura to throw investigators off the trail,” the officer said.

He further said that he was intercepted near Mathura Railway Station, where police recovered a total of Rs 12.75 lakh in cash and a scooter allegedly used to flee after the murder.

During questioning, Singh admitted that he had planned the killing in advance because of a long-running dispute over family properties and had purchased the scissors a few days back before the planned murder. He also confessed that he intended to dispose of the weapon after watching The Staircase, believing it would frustrate the investigation. The team, however, said scientific investigation, CCTV analysis and technical surveillance dismantled the carefully planned escape strategy,” the officer said.

Further investigation, including forensic examination and additional recoveries, is underway.

28 new sewage plants, 989 km pipelines approved to clean Yamuna

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Jal Board (DJB) has approved 28 new decentralised sewage treatment plants and nearly 989 kilometres of new sewer pipelines. Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh announced on Tuesday that this is one of the largest sewer infrastructure expansions the city has seen.

Singh, who also chairs the Delhi Jal Board, briefed reporters after the board’s 179th meeting. He said the Government’s goal is to ensure every drop of sewage generated in Delhi is treated before it reaches the Yamuna. He said Delhi currently generates close to 1,000 million gallons of sewage daily, but the city had only 749 MGD of installed treatment capacity when his Government took over. Over the past year, the board has raised this capacity to

814 MGD by upgrading existing treatment plants.

The 28 new decentralised plants will add 105.5 MGD of treatment capacity at an estimated cost of nearly ₹2,000 crore, benefiting around 20 lakh residents. Singh said land has been identified, project reports prepared, consultants appointed and tenders awarded for all 28 plants, with contractors given a 21-month deadline to complete the work.

Once finished, Singh said, Delhi’s total sewage treatment capacity will reach 1,046 MGD, surpassing the city’s current sewage generation for the first time. Alongside treatment capacity, the board has awarded contracts to lay 989 kilometres of new sewer pipelines across 244 colonies and 57 villages. The project will benefit nearly 33 lakh residents and provide house sewer connections to about 8



lakh households that currently have none. Work is expected to be completed within 18 months. Singh said all new sewer contracts will now include 15 years of mandatory operation and maintenance by the same contractors, a change from earlier practice.

The board has also introduced a performance-linked payment system for sewage treatment plant operators. Contractors will be paid based on the quality of treated water, monitored through

continuous online tracking of pollution parameters at plant inlets and outlets. Payments will rise or fall depending on whether treatment standards are met.

To address pollution while new infrastructure is built, the Government has approved in-situ treatment of major drains using biological treatment systems installed directly inside the drains. The board also approved a sludge management initiative to convert sewage sludge into biogas, construction bricks and other usable products instead of treating it as waste.

In a separate governance reform, the Jal Board will conduct e-KYC verification for all 30 lakh registered water consumers over the next six months. Singh said many consumer records are nearly two decades old, causing some households to receive bills only after several years.

Ghazipur poultry market to be ready by December; CM reviews mandi projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday reviewed the redevelopment of the capital’s agricultural markets. The Chief Minister was informed that the modern poultry market being built across nearly 15 acres in Ghazipur at a cost of ₹193.29 crore is 85 percent complete and targeted for completion by December 31, 2026, while also reviewing plans for a modern flower market at the Integrated Freight Complex in Ghazipur and two new steel sheds at the Narela Grain Market at a cost of ₹11 crore.

The meeting assessed development projects across Ghazipur, Narela, and IFC Ghazipur, reviewing both ongoing and proposed

works and examining the status of basic infrastructure strengthening across these markets.

On the Ghazipur poultry market, officials informed the CM that construction began in March 2019 and 85 percent of the work has been completed. The market, spread across nearly 15 acres, will house shops for 100 wholesale traders and 120 processing units. The December 31, 2026 completion deadline means the project, which has been under construction for over seven years, is now in its final phase.

On the Ghazipur Fruit, Vegetable and Flower Market, the meeting was informed that work is underway on a 200-metre bypass drainage pipeline to address waterlogging at the site, at an approved cost of ₹17 lakh. The department is also conducting



regular drives to remove stray animals from the market to maintain cleanliness.

On the Narela Grain Market, the review covered a proposal to develop two additional steel sheds to meet traders’ storage and operational requirements. The project is estimated at approximately ₹11 crore and

is expected to be completed by July 2027.

On the proposed modern flower market at IFC Ghazipur, officials said 10 acres of land had been acquired from DDA in 2001, and the modern flower market is planned to be developed in phases within the IFC Ghazipur complex. A

phased development approach for a project on land acquired 25 years ago suggests that the flower market plan has had a long gestation and is now being revived as part of the broader mandi modernisation push.

The Chief Minister said Delhi’s agricultural markets serve as a crucial link between farmers, traders, and consumers, and developing them in line with present-day requirements is a Government priority. She said well-planned markets with modern facilities and stronger infrastructure will make trade more efficient and strengthen the entire agricultural marketing system. She said the Government is regularly reviewing all projects to ensure development works progress according to stipulated timelines.

Delhi’s agricultural market

network, which includes the Azadpur Mandi, one of Asia’s largest wholesale fruit and vegetable markets, the Ghazipur complex, and the Narela grain market, forms a critical part of the food supply chain for the capital and the broader NCR region. The markets handle enormous daily volumes of perishable and non-perishable agricultural produce moving between farmers, commission agents, wholesalers, and retailers.

The Ghazipur poultry market project, which has been under construction since 2019 and is now approaching its eighth year, reflects the pace at which large-scale mandi infrastructure projects have historically moved in Delhi. The 85 percent completion figure and the December 2026 deadline suggest the project is now genuinely close to delivery.

Govt issues show-cause notice to Rohini School over fire safety lapses, fee fraud



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Directorate of Education has issued a show-cause notice to Private Global School in Rohini. The authority asked the school management to explain why the Delhi Government should not take over the school’s administration. The notice follows a joint surprise inspection conducted by senior officers from the Directorate of Education, the Revenue Department, and other Delhi Government agencies. Officials reviewed the school’s initial explanations and found them evasive and unsatisfactory, pointing to a repeated pattern of non-compliance. Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood said schools are places of learning, not commercial enterprises, and the Government would not compromise on student safety. He said management that breaks the law or exploits students and parents would face strict action.

Sood added that financial irregularities, commercial misuse of school premises and any risk to student safety would not be tolerated under any circumstances. He said the Government remains committed to full accountability and to protecting the rights of both parents and children. The inspection uncovered a wide range of violations. The school management allegedly obstructed the inspection team, refused to share basic documents such as land deeds and building safety approvals, and did not allow officials to speak privately with students.

Inspectors also found serious fire and safety lapses. The school was operating without a valid fire safety certificate, had expired fire extinguishers, and stored sulphuric acid without safeguards in its chemistry lab. First-aid supplies at the school had also expired. The report flagged illegal structural changes at the school, including the unauthorised conversion of underground parking basements into 18 academic rooms, music and dance classes, STEM and robotics labs, and a CBSE examination centre.

On finances, the notice pointed to suspicious high-value payments made to unverified firms, despite the school reporting cumulative losses of over ₹15.60 crore. It said the school diverted development reserve funds to buy luxury mobile phones worth ₹22.23 lakh and cleared unverified unsecured loans worth ₹3.25 crore. Investigators also found the school was running a commercial swimming pool open to outside members without fire safety clearance, along with an illegal rooftop commercial kitchen connected to a piped gas line. The notice further cited an unauthorised 15 percent fee hike and said the school collected illegal advance and capitation fees totalling ₹1,98,30,470 as of March 31, 2025.

On staffing, the report said nearly half the teaching staff, 80 out of 170 teachers, were employed on a contractual basis, bypassing statutory recruitment rules and fair selection procedures. The inspection also noted poor student facilities, including weak sports infrastructure, a neglected library, unhygienic washrooms, salty drinking water, and no accessibility features for children with special needs.

17 Namo Bharat stations to close entry-exit gates from August 4-12

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Several entry and exit gates of 17 Namo Bharat stations between Ghaziabad and Modipuram will remain closed from August 4 to 12 in view of the ongoing Kanwar Yatra, the NCRTC said on Monday, adding that the space for parking will also be limited at these stations.

The temporary restrictions have been imposed in accordance with administrative directions to facilitate security and traffic management during the annual pilgrimage, said the National Capital Region Transport Corporation (NCRTC), the implementing and operating agency for Namo Bharat.

The affected stations are Modipuram, Meerut North, MES Colony, Begumpul, Bhaissali, Meerut Central, Brahampuri, Shatabdi Nagar, Rithani, Partapur, Meerut South, Modinagar North, Modinagar South, Muradnagar, Duhai, Guldhar



and Ghaziabad, the corporation said.

At most stations, Gate No. 2 will remain closed during the period. At Begumpul, Gates 2 and 3 will remain shut, while at Duhai, Gates 3 and 4 will be closed.

At Ghaziabad station, Gates 3 and 5 will remain closed. Parking facilities on the affected side of these stations will also remain unavailable, it stated.

The NCRTC advised pas-

sengers to use the alternate entry and exit gates available at the respective stations to access Namo Bharat services and expressed regret for the inconvenience caused.

It said Namo Bharat train services will continue to operate normally across the entire Sarai Kale Khan-Modipuram corridor. Trains will run every eight minutes from 6 am to 10 pm daily until August 14.

Police warned CJP about crowd management a day before Parliament march turned violent

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A video purportedly recorded at Jantar Mantar a day before the CJP’s ‘Sansad Chalo’ protest march on July 20 has surfaced online, showing senior Delhi Police officers asking the organisers to implement adequate crowd-management measures before the gathering swelled.

The viral video captures an interaction involving New Delhi Deputy Commissioner of Police Sachin Sharma, Joint Commissioner of Police Deepak Purohit and Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) representatives Saurav Das and other members.

During the conversation, the officers are seen expressing concern over the lack of preparations for the protest and cautioning organisers about potential security risks. One officer is heard advising the organisers to deploy volunteers to regulate the crowd.

According to police, they repeatedly cautioned the organisers that inadequate crowd-management arrange-



ments could make the situation difficult to handle as attendance increased.

They tell the organisers that there were not enough volunteers deployed to regulate the crowd, despite repeated requests from the police. DCP Sachin Sharma is heard telling the organisers that they should deploy at least a minimum number of volunteers to help manage the gathering and prevent any untoward situation.

“I have been requesting you for quite some time,” Sharma says in the video while speaking to the organisers. The DCP also warns that there are “criminal elements” present among the

crowd, making effective crowd management even more important.

The officers stress that without volunteers on the ground, the police alone would find it difficult to control the gathering if the situation escalated.

A senior police officer, on the condition of anonymity, said they had contacted the CJP and had asked them to control the crowd and maintain law and order. The CJP’s ‘Sansad Chalo’ protest march in New Delhi turned violent, injuring 118 police personnel, including senior officers and several women officers and approximately 60 protesters.

IN FOCUS



Rashtriya Rajput Karri Sena supporters during a protest march demanding the rollback of UGC Regulations 2026, and other demands concerning the upper caste community, in Jaipur, Rajasthan on Monday

Delhi schools, Mayor's office receive bomb threats

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Multiple schools across Delhi received bomb threat emails on Monday morning. The incident prompted Delhi Police, bomb disposal squads, dog squads, and Delhi Fire Services to rush to campuses, evacuate students and staff, and conduct anti-sabotage searches, while the Mayor's Office simultaneously received its eighth bomb threat, sent via anonymous email at 9:07 am, warning of an explosion at 2:11 pm. Police said nothing suspicious was found during searches at any of the affected school premises.

Investigations have been initiated to trace the origin of the threat emails. At Sardar Patel Vidyalaya, school authorities sent parents an official message at 10:25 am stating: "Dear parents, the school has received a security threat. All students have been evacuated safely. The police have been informed and are doing the needful. Once the school is declared safe by the police, classes will resume."

Emergency response teams followed standard operating procedure across all affected campuses, securing the premises, evacuating students and staff, and conducting detailed searches of classrooms, administrative blocks, and surrounding areas. Police urged parents and the public to remain calm and avoid



A Delhi Police Bomb Disposal Squad vehicle parked as multiple schools received bomb threats via emails in New Delhi on Monday

spreading unverified information on social media.

The Mayor's Office threat arrived via anonymous email at 9:07 am, stating that a bomb would explode at 2:11 pm. The office immediately alerted security agencies and Delhi Police, who conducted a comprehensive search operation across the premises, inspecting every sensitive area including entry and exit points and other critical locations. Nothing suspicious was found.

Significantly, Monday's threat was not the first. The Mayor's Office has now received bomb threats on eight separate occasions. Following the

previous seven threats, the Mayor's Office had formally written to the Delhi Police Commissioner requesting a detailed investigation to identify those responsible and ensure strict legal action. Despite that formal request, the threats have continued, and the perpetrators remain unidentified.

The Mayor's Office said on Monday that repeated threats targeting public institutions and offices associated with constitutional authorities are a matter of serious concern, and that those responsible must be identified at the earliest and dealt with firmly under law.

Anti-drug lessons to be introduced in school curriculum: Fadnavis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Maharashtra continues to rank among the country's leading States in school education and is strengthening its pupil-centric system by balancing quality, promotion of Marathi, preservation of history and modern facilities, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said on Monday.

Chairing a review meeting of the School Education Department, he directed officials to initiate the process of incorporating lessons on drug de-addiction into the school curriculum. Maharashtra has retained the second position in the national Performance Grading Index (PGI) 2.0 for school education and stressed the need to implement innovative initiatives across all schools, including PM SHRI schools, an official release quoted Fadnavis as saying at the meet.

He reviewed the implementation of key initiatives, including Aadhaar authentication of school students, educational benefits provided to 35 lakh students under



the Right to Education (RTE) Act, the 'Pavitra' teacher recruitment portal and the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020. The CM noted the State Government has decided to set up anti-drug guidance and counselling committees in schools and launch a "Drug-Free School" campaign.

He directed officials to implement stringent measures to strengthen school safety and prevent cyber fraud and drug abuse among students. According to a presentation made at the meeting, Maharashtra accounts for 9.34 per cent of the country's schools, 8.84 per cent of its teachers and 7.69 per cent of its students.

Delhi zoo to add 109 new wildlife species

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

After its collection declined from 99 wildlife species to 92 over the past three years, the Delhi zoo is set to acquire 109 new species and 2,943 animals under its proposed modernisation plan, with cheetahs, New World monkeys, mouse deer and butterflies among the species identified for acquisition. With the fresh acquisitions, the National Zoological Park will sport a vibrant collection of 201 wildlife species.

Among these, mouse deer are being reintroduced to the Delhi zoo after almost 30

years, according to Delhi zoo official. The proposed acquisition forms a key component of the zoo's modernisation project, for which the Centre has earmarked ₹3.78 crore.

The animals will be brought primarily through exchange programmes with other zoos, with a tentative mapping of partner zoos prepared to facilitate the process, the official said.

The acquisition plan covers mammals, birds, reptiles, insects and other wildlife that are either absent or under-represented at the National Zoological Park. Prominent species proposed for acquisition are cheetahs, New World monkeys, mouse deer and butterflies, aimed at enriching the zoo's biodiversity, he said.



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The proposed expansion comes against the backdrop of a shrinking animal collection at the zoo. The National Zoological Park, which

CM Yogi hits back at Opposition on Ram temple donation theft issue

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Gorakhpur (UP)

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Monday said those raising questions on the handling of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya had earlier attempted to obstruct the temple's construction, and slammed their "double standards".

Talking to reporters before the commencement of the Monsoon Session of the State legislature, Adityanath also appealed to all MLAs to ensure a constructive discussion in the House and said the government had brought a supplementary Budget aimed at strengthening welfare measures for various categories of frontline workers.

"The Ayodhya issue is being raised by those who had fired bullets at Ram devotees. They are the same people who used to resort to lathi-charge and firing when people raised the slogan of 'Jai Shri Ram'," the chief minister said without naming any party.

He alleged that those criticising the handling of donations for the Ram temple had earlier tried to stall the temple's construction by "deploying an army of lawyers" in courts.

"They (Opposition) talk about theft of donations meant for the Ram temple, but not a single penny for the temple's construction came from their pockets. The country and the world



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath speaking during the Monsoon session of the Uttar Pradesh Legislative Assembly in Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh

are watching their double standards," Adityanath said.

His remarks came amid opposition protests over the Ram temple donation issue during the opening day of the Monsoon session of the State legislature.

The CM said the Government expects meaningful deliberations in the legislature and called upon members across party lines to contribute positively to the proceedings. "I appeal to all honourable public representatives to maintain healthy discussion and debate in the House," he said.

Referring to the supplementary Budget, Adityanath said it included provisions to enhance financial support for Anganwadi workers, ASHA workers, cooks engaged in Government programmes and village chowkidars.

"The supplementary budget has been brought to ensure these workers receive a handsome honorarium and continue

serving the interests of the State," he said. Expressing confidence that the legislature would function smoothly, the chief minister urged the opposition to move beyond "negative politics" and work together for the welfare of the State's 25 crore people.

"I hope our Opposition colleagues will give up negative politics, adopt a positive approach and contribute to Uttar Pradesh's changed perception, development and prosperity," he said.

Adityanath said the legislature serves as an important platform for conveying the concerns of the people to the Government and administration, enabling elected representatives to raise issues affecting their constituencies and seek their resolution.

"The effective utilisation of this forum has always been a priority for the BJP-led Government," he said.

No permission granted for Kejriwal's proposed march to PM residence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Delhi Police on Monday said no permission has been granted for Aam Aadmi Party national convener Arvind Kejriwal's proposed march to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's residence on Tuesday with 100 volunteers. Earlier, Kejriwal announced his march to submit petitions against E20 ethanol-blended fuel. However, Delhi police said that security arrangements are being made to prevent any unauthorised procession.

Kejriwal announced the march at a press conference on Monday, saying he would personally hand over petitions signed by over two lakh people to the Prime Minister after receiving no response to a letter he had sent last month seeking an appointment to discuss concerns over E20 petrol.

"I will go to the PM's residence tomorrow along with 100 people to personally hand over the petitions signed by the public and discuss issues related to ethanol-blended petrol. People are facing several problems in their vehicles, and despite all that, the government is continuing with this, which means there is a hidden agenda," he said.

Kejriwal also alleged that India had yielded to US President Donald Trump to buy ethanol from the United States and that this was why the government was pushing E20 blended fuel. He said

the AAP's National Town Hall Against E20 held last week was a huge success, with a large number of people joining virtually.

He said he had sought in his letter to the Prime Minister that petrol stations offer both pure petrol and E20 fuel as options, and that the price of ethanol-blended petrol be reduced. Since no response was received, the march was announced to deliver the petition directly.



Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra dismissed Kejriwal's announcement as political theatre. He said Kejriwal's plan to march to the Prime Minister's residence is part of an ongoing competition between him and the Congress over who can emerge as the country's leading anarchist.

"Ever since the Congress staged a protest at the Prime Minister's residence, Kejriwal appeared to be falling behind in this politics of disruption," Malhotra said. He added that creating disorder first and then playing the victim card has long been Kejriwal's political style. "Tomorrow, when the police prevent him from

entering the Prime Minister's residence without permission, Kejriwal will once again play the victim card and claim that the government refused even to hold talks with him," Malhotra said.

The E20 fuel protest movement has been building across multiple groups simultaneously. On Saturday, Team Bharat founder Teheen Poonawalla undertook a solo walk from APJ Abdul Kalam

BJP's Bankipur fortress falls to Kishor

For the BJP, as this is the first electoral test in the State after BJP's Samrat Choudhary took over as the Chief Minister of Bihar, becoming the first CM of the State from the saffron party.

"BJP humbly accepts the mandate of the Bankipur by-election and respects the people's decision. In a democratic process, the verdict of the people is above everything!" Unlike Opposition parties, we do not blame constitutional institutions, EVMs, or the Election Commission for our defeat," Bihar BJP State President Sanjay Saraogi said in a statement.

In Gujarat's Manjalpur assembly constituency, BJP's Satendrabhai Patel won and defeated Congress' Bhikhabhai Rabari by a margin of over 30,000 votes.

Delhi court clears Brij Bhushan in wrestlers...

The controversy prompted Singh to step down from the WFI following the completion of his tenure.

The Supreme Court had taken note of the plea of seven wrestlers, following which Delhi Police registered two FIRs against Singh.

Senior advocate Rebecca John, who appeared for four of the women, voiced surprise at his comment and said, "How can he come to the conclusion that the court acquitted Brij Bhushan Singh based on inconsistencies by the complainant victims when the order is not available... and we are all waiting for the order? Secondly, detailed arguments had taken place where I had contradicted the defence argu-

ments to show that the inconsistencies were minor in nature and did not affect the credibility of witnesses." John described the judgment of acquittal as "deeply, deeply disturbing". The police filed a chargesheet against Singh and Tomar in June 2023 under sections 354 (assault or criminal force to a woman with intent to outrage her modesty), 354A (sexual harassment), 354D (stalking) and 506 (criminal intimidation) of the Indian Penal Code.

A separate FIR lodged by a minor wrestler was later closed following a police investigation. A Delhi court framed charges of sexual harassment, intimidation and outraging the modesty of women against Singh in May 2024 and criminal intimidation against Tomar. The court discharged Singh in a complaint filed by one of the six women wrestlers, citing lack of sufficient evidence to back her claim. The trial began the following month. In May 2025, the court accepted the police closure report in the minor wrestler's case.

School teacher killed days after she alleged...

Police said the video shows that even after Sandhya fell, the accused continued to stab her. When people heard the noise, school administrator Tejpal ran to help and tried to stop the attacker, but the accused threatened him with the knife, so he had to back away. The attacker kept others from helping and continued until Sandhya collapsed. The accused then ran away.

"There was only one attacker. He had a bike without a number plate, which was parked outside. After the incident, I informed police and immediately took Sandhya to hospital, where the

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doctor declared her dead," Tejpal said. Police said the accused is being questioned and will be produced before a local court on Tuesday.

Shivakumar urges patience as Congress...

Sagara MLA Belur Gopalakrishna also expressed his displeasure and his intention to resign. "It looks like only the influential and children of ex-CMs and senior leaders get prominence, not common legislators. I feel that... I'm hurt, I'm going to resign tomorrow from the MLA post," he said. In Mysuru, supporters of senior MLA Tanveer Sait staged a road blockade on the Mysuru-Bengaluru road, protesting against their leader being denied a ministerial position. The protesters sat on the road, demanding justice. The demonstration caused traffic jam. Police detained the protesters.

Speaking to reporters, Sait questioned the basis on which this Cabinet has been expanded. He said he will call a meeting of his supporters and well-wishers soon and decide on the future course of action. Alleging that the party has failed him, he said that those who openly engaged in anti-party activities and challenged the party have been rewarded.

In Bengaluru, supporters of Govindarajanagar MLA Priya Krishna staged protests, shouting slogans demanding justice.

Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot administered the oath of office and secrecy to new Ministers in a ceremony held at the Lok Bhavan premises here.

The Congress legislators, who were sworn-in as ministers, are P M Narendraswamy (Malavalli), Shivaraj Tangadagi (Kanakagiri),

Rudrappa Lamani (Haveri), K S Basavanthappa (Mayakonda), B Nagendra (Ballari rural), T Raghunurthy (Challakere), B Z Zameer Ahmed Khan (Chamarajpet), Rizwan Arshad (Shivajinagar), Santosh Lad (Kalaghatagi), Madhu Bangarappa (Soraba), Putturangashetty (Chamarajanagara), and S S Mallikarjun (Davangere North).

Ajay Singh (Jevargi), N Chaluvaraya Swamy (Nagamangala), K M Shivalinge Gowda (Arasikere), H C Balakrishna (Magadi), Basvaraj Rayareddi (Yelaburga), Vijayanand Kashappanavar (Bagalakote), and Laxman Savadi (Athani) also took oath.

However, Gayathri Shanthegowda, whose name was on the final list cleared by the Congress high command, was not sworn in on Monday, leaving the Karnataka Cabinet without a woman minister.

Interestingly, several senior legislators who were part of Siddaramaiah's Cabinet, including H C Mahadevappa, H K Patil, Dinesh Gundu Rao, K Venkatesh, M C Sudhakar, Laxmi Hebbalkar have been left out.

Ghaziabad psychiatrist dies after fall

Dr Agrawal's family said she had been struggling with emotional distress and depression since her divorce about a year and a half ago. Her father, Dr R Chandra, a respected psychiatrist in Ghaziabad, told the police about her medical history and how the separation affected her mental health. She was living alone in the apartment. Dr Hemika specialised in treating depression, anxiety, and related conditions, and also offered psychotherapy and counselling. The case

has received attention because, as her family shared, she faced the same challenges she helped her patients with. Police investigation has not reached any conclusions. Statements from relatives and others are being recorded, and evidence from the scene continues to be scrutinised. Authorities are still investigating, and more updates will come after the post-mortem examination report is available and further evidence is reviewed.

Govt opens LIC stake sale to meet public...

"Government offers to disinvest 2.5 per cent equity with an additional 4 per cent as a green shoe option," Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM) Secretary Arunish Chawla said in a post on X.

The stake sale will help LIC achieve the minimum public shareholding requirement mandated by market regulator Sebi ahead of schedule. Sebi had given LIC time till May 16, 2027, to achieve a minimum 10 per cent public shareholding. At present, the Government holds a 96.5 per cent stake in LIC.

It had earlier sold 3.5 per cent through an Initial Public Offering (IPO) in May 2022 at a price band of ₹902-949 per share, raising about ₹21,000 crore. LIC currently has a market capitalisation of over ₹5.36 lakh crore. LIC shares settled at ₹424.35 on Monday, down 0.12 per cent over the previous close on BSE.

So far in the current fiscal, the Government has mopped up ₹21,082 crore through stake sale in seven Public Sector Undertakings and remittances from SUUTI (Specified Undertaking of the Unit Trust of India).

Opposition leaders attack BJP after Brij Bhushan’s acquittal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Opposition leaders on Monday attacked the ruling BJP over the acquittal of former Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh in a sexual harassment case filed by six women wrestlers, alleging that empowerment of youth and women is just “lip service” for its Government.

A Delhi court on Monday acquitted former BJP MP Singh and co-accused Vinod Tomar in the case that dates back to 2023, when women wrestlers protested at Delhi’s Jantar Mantar for 36 days, demanding action against Singh, then WFI chief.

Reacting to Singh’s acquittal, Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra said, “On one hand they say that they are with the youth, there is talk of women’s empowerment and women’s reservation, and on the other hand there is this.”

Maharashtra Congress chief Harshvardhan Sapkal said the real character of the BJP has been exposed.

“It is our misfortune that a deaf, mute and blind Government sits in power. The true face of the BJP is unfortunately right before all of us.

“As a citizen of India, I am deeply hurt by this decision, and I stand firmly with all our sisters and athletes.... Instead of justice, the perpetrator has been given a medal of acquittal around his neck. This country will never forgive you.”

Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Arvind Sawant said when the distraught women wrestlers were “protesting and crying”, not even women BJP members went to sympathise with them. He dismissed Singh’s claim that the case was foisted on him as part of a conspiracy.

Congress MP Shashi Tharoor said the law should be



allowed to take its course.

“I don’t want to comment on court judgments... The important thing is that the process of justice should be allowed to function. Accusations are made, and consequences follow, but

justice must be seen doing its course.

“If an appeal is filed, we will have to see what the next stage produces. If there is no appeal, then certainly he should be treated as someone who has been honourably

discharged. I don’t think we should right now pass judgments on an ongoing judicial matter,” he said.

Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh’s son and BJP MP Karan Bhushan Singh described the court verdict as a “victory of truth”

while thanking those who stood by his family during the controversy.

“This is a victory of truth. It is a victory for the young wrestlers. I would like to thank everyone who stood by us and reposed their faith in us. Today, we are standing strong before the entire country,” he said.

“There was a time when people were forcing us and saying at Jantar Mantar that my father should be hanged, that he should be burnt, and all the parties had come together to say these things. What will they say today?” he said.

“When you label a man a rapist, what does his daughter-in-law or daughter feel? What does his son go through?” he said.

Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, a six-time former MP, was denied a ticket in the 2024 Lok Sabha election by the BJP in the wake of the controversy. Instead, the party fielded his son from

Kaiserganj, Uttar Pradesh. Karan Bhushan Singh described the verdict as a “slap in the face” of the Congress leaders who had joined the wrestlers’ protest at Jantar Mantar, saying those who had declared his father a “rapist” at the time should either apologise or join the family in celebrating the outcome.

“At that time, you were calling someone a rapist by declaring him guilty. What answer will you give today?” he said.

“I am his son. At that time, I could not even look at my father, and my father could not look at me or face me. You had labelled him a rapist. His wife, such a simple and straightforward woman, could not show her face. His daughter could not show her face. Who will answer for this today?” he said. Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate Ashwini Panwar acquitted ex-BJP MP Singh and Tomar in the

sexual harassment case filed by six women wrestlers, including World Championships medallist Vinesh Phogat, on the grounds of lack of evidence and inconsistent and contradictory testimonies of witnesses, according to the defence counsel.

Speaking to reporters outside the court, Singh said the court had “honourably” acquitted him and Tomar.

“On the first day, I had said that if any allegation against me was proved, I would hang myself. The court has now honourably acquitted me. I am happy and grateful to my lawyers,” he said.

“For now, this is all I can say. I will comment further after going through the court’s reasoned order,” the ex-BJP MP added.

Phogat said that the women wrestlers who had filed a sexual harassment case against Singh will appeal against a Delhi court’s decision to acquit him.

Bill to increase SC judges passed in LS without debate

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Lok Sabha on Monday passed a bill to replace an ordinance that increased the number of Supreme Court judges from 34 to 38 without a debate as Opposition members persisted with slogan-shouting over the issues of NEET paper leak and alleged theft of Ram temple donations.

Last week, a bill to amend the law on birth and death registration was also passed without any debate in the Lok Sabha under similar circumstances.

A statutory resolution moved by the Opposition members denouncing the promulgation of the ordi-



Opposition MPs stage a protest in the Lok Sabha during the ongoing Monsoon session of Parliament in New Delhi on Monday

PTI

nance was also rejected by a voice vote.

After brief introductory remarks by Union Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal, the Chair urged the members to speak on the statutory resolution, but as sloganeering continued, the bill was put to vote and sub-

sequently cleared. After the passage of the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026, the House was adjourned for the day.

The bill was listed in the agenda almost every day since its introduction on July 20 but could not come up for

consideration and passage. The Government has maintained that an enhanced strength is one of the most exigent and viable solutions for tackling pendency in the top court.

In May, the Union Cabinet had cleared the bill to increase the sanctioned strength of the top court, but soon thereafter the Government brought an ordinance.

After the ordinance, five judges were appointed to the apex court based on the upgraded sanctioned strength.

After the ordinance was issued, the sanctioned strength of the apex court went up to 38 from 34, including the Chief Justice of India.

India, Uzbekistan can expand rare earth ties: Murmu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu on Monday said there is immense potential for cooperation between India and Uzbekistan in the mining sector, particularly in rare earth minerals, agriculture, pharmaceuticals, and information technology.

During a meeting with Saidov Bakhtiyor Odilovich, Minister of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Uzbekistan, who had called on the president at the Rashtrapati Bhavan here, Murmu said that the two nations share deep historical, cultural, and civilisational ties, rooted in ancient trade routes. She said that the shared heritage in architecture, language, cuisine, music, and religious traditions has further strengthened bilateral partnership.

The president said that the presence of high-level leaders in the visiting



President Droupadi Murmu meets Republic of Uzbekistan Foreign Affairs Minister Saidov Bakhtiyor at Rashtrapati Bhavan

PTI

Uzbek delegation and the organisation of an India-Uzbekistan Business Forum on the sidelines of the visit reflect the growing confidence of businesses of both sides in each other’s markets.

She also highlighted the immense potential for cooperation between India and Uzbekistan in the mining

sector, particularly in rare earth minerals, agriculture, pharmaceuticals, and information technology, according to a statement issued by the President’s office.

Murmu was happy to note that more than 3,000 officials, professionals and students from Uzbekistan have benefited from our ITEC (Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation) training courses and other scholarship programs.

At the same time over 16,000 Indian students are pursuing higher studies in Uzbekistan, the president said.

She underlined that they act as a bridge between the two countries and foster mutual understanding and strong people-to-people ties. The two leaders agreed that discussions held during this visit will further strengthen the bonds of friendship, trust, and cooperation between our two nations, the statement said.

RS passes Bill to tackle payment delays faced by MSMEs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Rajya Sabha on Monday passed a bill that seeks to tackle the issue of delayed payments to MSMEs by prescribing timelines to ensure faster adjudication of disputes, provide recovery of the settlement agreement, and address their liquidity issues, even as Opposition members continued to disrupt the House.

The Upper House was adjourned for the day soon after the passage of the Micro Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026, that seeks to empower courts to order payment of at least 50 per cent of the awarded amount to MSME suppliers, if the application to set aside an order is pending for more than six months.



India appoints Vishwesh Negi as new Ambassador to Iran amid regional tensions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government of India has appointed Vishwesh Negi as the next Ambassador to the Islamic Republic of Iran, placing an experienced diplomat at the helm of one of New Delhi’s most strategically significant missions in West Asia.

Negi, a 2002-batch Indian Foreign Service (IFS) officer, currently serves as Joint Secretary in the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA). While the Government has not announced a date for him to assume charge in Tehran, the official appointment order stated that he is “expected to take up the assignment shortly.”

He will succeed Rudra Gaurav Shresth, who has been appointed as India’s next Ambassador to Türkiye.

Negi’s appointment comes at a sensitive time for the region, with tensions between Iran and the United States continuing to shape the geopolitical landscape. The evolving security environment has also heightened concerns over energy markets and maritime trade,



particularly around the Strait of Hormuz, a critical global oil transit route.

Iran is also navigating a period of political uncertainty, with international attention focused on its evolving leadership dynamics and the growing influence of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) in key decision-making. These developments are expected to feature prominently in India’s diplomatic engagement with Tehran.

Negi brings extensive diplomatic and administrative experience to the role. As Joint Secretary heading the Oceania Division in the MEA, he led high-level diplomatic

engagements, including the India-Papua New Guinea Foreign Office Consultations. He also served on central deputation in the Department of Defence, where he handled strategic international defence cooperation and partnerships after being appointed at the Joint Secretary level in late 2022.

Earlier in his career, Negi managed policy and desk responsibilities relating to India’s bilateral relations with Pakistan. With Islamabad playing an increasingly significant diplomatic role in regional discussions involving Washington and Tehran, his understanding of Pakistan’s strategic

outlook could prove valuable in navigating the broader regional dynamics.

He has also served as Director in the United Nations Political Division, overseeing multilateral diplomacy and India’s engagement on key international political issues.

India and Iran share long-standing strategic ties, with cooperation extending across connectivity, energy security, trade and regional development. The two countries continue to collaborate on the development of Chabahar Port, a key project that enhances India’s access to Afghanistan and Central Asia while strengthening regional connectivity.

Negi’s appointment is expected to reinforce bilateral engagement at a time of heightened regional uncertainty. His experience across multilateral diplomacy, defence cooperation and neighbourhood policy is likely to support India’s efforts to deepen cooperation with Tehran while advancing shared interests in regional stability, economic connectivity and strategic dialogue.

Datia bypoll: Congress’ Ghanshyam Singh beats BJP by 6,000 votes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

The Congress scored a crucial victory in the Datia Assembly by-election on Monday, with its candidate Ghanshyam Singh defeating the Bharatiya Janata Party’s (BJP) Ashutosh Tiwari by 6,016 votes, dealing a setback to the ruling party in Madhya Pradesh.

According to the final results declared by the Election Commission, Ghanshyam Singh secured 66,757 votes, while Ashutosh Tiwari polled 60,741 votes. A total of 21 candidates contested the by-election, which recorded a voter turnout of 71.44 per cent on July 30.

The Congress candidate established a commanding lead during the initial rounds of counting, at one stage opening a margin of more than 12,600 votes. Although the BJP narrowed the gap in the later rounds, it failed to overturn the deficit, allowing Ghanshyam Singh to register a comfortable victory.

The bypoll was necessitated after former Congress MLA Rajendra Bharti was disqualified following his



conviction in a bank fraud case. In a dramatic development ahead of the results, the Congress suspended Bharti from the party’s primary membership after Ghanshyam Singh accused him of attempting to sabotage his campaign and colluding with the BJP.

The BJP had fielded first-time candidate Ashutosh Tiwari after denying a ticket to former State Home Minister Narottam Mishra, who represented the Datia constituency for three consecutive terms before losing to Rajendra Bharti in the 2023 Assembly elections.

Reacting to his victory, Ghanshyam Singh termed the verdict a strong message from the people against the BJP. He expressed confi-

dence that the Congress would form the next Government in Madhya Pradesh in 2028 and said the party was also working towards seeing Rahul Gandhi become the next Prime Minister.

Outlining his priorities for the constituency, the newly elected MLA said he would work to strengthen communal harmony, end political vendetta and take strict action against gambling and betting rackets in Datia.

Celebrations broke out at the Pradesh Congress Committee headquarters in Bhopal, where party workers distributed sweets and raised slogans in support of the party leadership.

State Congress President Jitu Patwari described the verdict as a victory for the people of Datia and said it reflected public anger against the BJP Government’s alleged corruption, intimidation and arrogance.

He said the result marked the beginning of political change in the State and would boost the Congress ahead of the 2028 Assembly elections.

Meta ready to apologise for brief restriction of PM Modi’s Facebook post

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Social media giant Meta told a parliamentary committee on Monday that it is ready to apologise for the brief restriction of a post by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Facebook, even as several members pressed for legal action and clear fixing of accountability.

The Standing Committee on Information Technology, led by BJP MP Nishikant Dubey, met to discuss how social and digital platforms are regulated. Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan, MeitY Secretary S. Krishnan, and representatives from Meta (Facebook, WhatsApp, Instagram), Google, X (formerly Twitter), Snapchat, and YouTube attended the meeting.

Sources said members asked if Meta is following Indian laws, especially since the company makes a lot of money in India. Officials faced questions about algorithmic bias, and some

members were concerned that objectionable content, like pornography, stays online while ‘genuine’ content is taken down. One MP wanted to know why Prime Minister Modi’s video was restricted when other harmful material was still available, and also asked who is ultimately responsible.

Earlier, the Government had summoned Meta’s top executives. On July 23, Prime Minister Modi posted a selfie video, first on Instagram and then shared on Facebook, where he spoke to India’s youth and promised strict action against exam paper leaks. The post was briefly restricted on Facebook in late July. Users in India saw notices saying the content was unavailable in the region after a legal request. Meta said the incident was due to a technical glitch or an error in its AI-powered content moderation system, restored the post, and apologised, saying the content



was removed ‘in error.’

The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) said Meta’s explanation was ‘inadequate.’ IT Secretary S. Krishnan said the ministry welcomed Meta’s admission of error but needed

more details, since the issue affects national security and public order. Meta later told the Government it had added more safeguards, such as multi-level senior reviews and more oversight for posts by the Prime Minister and other impor-

tant accounts, starting around July 28.

At Monday’s meeting, Meta officials said they regretted the incident and were ready to apologise. A BJP MP replied that an apology was not enough and stressed the need for accountability and legal action. Another member said that in a democracy, if the Prime Minister’s video is not secure, someone must be held responsible. The panel also asked how well the algorithms work to detect deepfakes of the Prime Minister.

After the meeting, Committee Chairman Nishikant Dubey asked Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg to apologise directly. He pointed out that the content was unavailable for several hours and called the incident serious, mentioning earlier statements by Zuckerberg. Dubey warned that if concerns are not addressed, the Government could remove safe-harbour protection under Section 79 of the IT Act. He also brought up other issues,

such as algorithmic bias, differences in how political parties’ content is promoted, and how the platforms handle child sexual abuse material and content about women, saying the companies have not followed Government rules well enough.

This incident has put a spotlight on how global platforms manage content moderation in India. Some panel members and Government critics pointed out that official content sometimes gets removed quickly or by mistake, while harmful posts can stay online.

These platforms are now under pressure to set up clear and effective systems that protect public order, privacy, and democracy. Still, Meta has said it will ‘ringfence’ high-profile accounts and has shared new protocols with MeitY. More discussions between Meta and Government officials about policy and technical matters are expected. The

panel’s work is part of a broader push to improve how social and digital platforms are regulated, especially amid worries about algorithms, misinformation, deepfakes, and accountability.

When the Prime Minister’s post was briefly restricted during student protests and a legislative debate, the issue moved beyond a technical error. It raised questions about trust, digital independence, and the influence of foreign tech companies in India. Panel members said that saying sorry is not enough; real steps are needed to take responsibility, stop these problems from happening again, and keep standards consistent.

“As these discussions go on, the rules and decisions that result will influence what people expect from major platforms. This is especially important for transparency, fair algorithms, and obeying the law,” sources added.



States Focus



GOVT, CITIZENS WORKING TO RESTORE PEACE: MANIPUR CM

Manipur Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh on Sunday said his Government and the people of the State were making sincere efforts to restore lasting peace and that encouraging signs of improvement were now visible.

He was speaking at the inauguration of the ₹10 crore Addition-Free Pledge Mega Campaign under the Nasha Mukta Bharat Abhiyaan and Mission SPANDAN (Spiritual Partnership Against Narcotic Drug Abuse) at Pheidinga in Imphal West district. Addressing the gathering, Singh said Prime Minister Narendra Modi has envisioned Viksit Bharat 2047 to make India one of the most developed nations in the world. He said the vision could be achieved only if the country's youth remained free from the menace of drugs. (PTI)



SIR: 93% ENUMERATION FORMS DISTRIBUTED IN MAHARASHTRA

More than 93 per cent of enumeration forms have been distributed, and nearly 73 per cent digitised under the ongoing special intensive revision of electoral rolls in Maharashtra, with the August 8 deadline just days away, the State's Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) said on Monday.

While Wardha and Hingoli districts in Marathwada recorded 100 per cent form distribution, major cities, including Pune, Thane, and Mumbai Suburban, trailed behind in both distribution and digitisation progress, according to the official bulletin.

The enumeration phase of the SIR began on June 30 and is set to culminate on August 8. (PTI)

Assam CM roll out ₹15,000 interim relief for flood victims

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

In a major move to provide an immediate financial cushion to families devastated by recent floods in Upper Assam, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Monday launched the Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) of ₹15,000 as interim relief to affected households across Sivasagar, Charaideo, Jorhat, and Golaghat districts.

Launching the initiative at the Chief Minister's Secretariat in Dibrugarh, Sarma also virtually released ₹41.67 crore as state subsidy under the Pradhan Mantri Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana for 9,289 eligible beneficiaries across the four worst-hit districts.

In the first phase of the rollout, financial assistance was directly credited to the bank accounts of 62,696 families — comprising 35,298 in Sivasagar, 19,883 in Charaideo, 4,922 in Jorhat, and 2,593 in Golaghat. The Chief Minister confirmed that remaining eligible households, taking the overall count past 75,000, will receive aid by August 5 following verification by district administration officials.



CM Himanta visiting flood affected areas of upper Assam

PIONEER PHOTO

Addressing the gathering, Sarma lauded the courage and solidarity shown by local communities during the calamity. Recognising that families returning from relief camps urgently need immediate cash to rebuild their lives, purchase essential household goods, and clear flood silt, the Government decided to bypass traditional administrative delays.

"Under the conventional system, official assessment of flood damage often takes six to nine months, with compensation reaching beneficiaries nearly a year later. We intend to break this practice," Sarma said.

He announced that field surveys for permanent flood damage will commence on August 9 or 10 and wrap up

within 10 days, enabling full compensation for permanent losses to be disbursed by late August or the first week of September.

Highlighting a series of relief measures arranged in consultation with the Centre, the Chief Minister announced an enhanced compensation of ₹9 lakh for the next of kin of those who lost their lives in Sivasagar and Charaideo districts. This ex-gratia relief comprises ₹4 lakh provided under SDRF norms and an additional ₹5 lakh drawn from the Chief Minister's Relief Fund. Furthermore, families in Sivasagar and Charaideo who remain unable to return home by August 9 due to severe flood conditions will receive an additional finan-

cial assistance of ₹10,000 on August 10.

To support community infrastructure and ease local burdens, the Government has sanctioned a grant of ₹1.5 lakh for every damaged Namghar to be disbursed before August 7, along with an immediate grant of ₹2.10 lakh for each flood-affected school. Residents in Sivasagar and Charaideo will also benefit from a complete waiver of electricity bills up to 300 units for July, as well as a one-year exemption on land revenue payments.

In addition, financial relief measures have been coordinated with banks to grant a six-month moratorium on loan repayments for affected individuals. Insurance companies have also agreed to streamline procedures, appointing district-level nodal officers and introducing video verification to process insurance claims with minimal documentation and issue interim payments.

Reaffirming the Union Government's backing, Sarma noted that Prime Minister Narendra Modi has assured necessary central funds once full damage assessments are completed.

Suwendu security tightened with bullet-proof vehicle

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

Suwendu Adhikari has started using a bulletproof vehicle following security alerts after data records of Hamim Mondal, an alleged Jaish-e-Muhammad terror mole who was arrested last week, indicated that he had been instructed by his handlers in Pakistan to follow the movements of the Bengal Chief Minister.

Adhikari started using a

white bulletproof vehicle late on Sunday evening when he travelled back from Contai, his ancestral home in East Midnapore, to Kolkata. The shift in his security protocol commenced following alerts from the Special Task Force regarding threats from ISI-backed JeM and Kashmir-based Shahjad Bhatti network. Digital data found on Mondal revealed how he had been instructed by his Pakistani handlers through high-tech devices to digitally



track Adhikari's day-to-day movements.

The STF on Friday had arrested Mondal from the Renaissance Township of East Burdwan. Leads obtained

after his arrest also led the agency to arrest two of his accomplices: Arpita Sarkar from Sahibganj in Jharkhand and Aditya Singh from Howrah. Singh was arrested on Monday.

A police officer said that though a bulletproof vehicle had been included in the Chief Minister's security protocol, he preferred not to use the same lest it would restrict his movement and interaction with the people during travels.

Ex-TMC ministers meet Kakoli, may join NCPI

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

In what is being termed as a "defection 2.0", at least three senior TMC leaders, including former heavy duty ministers were leaving the Mamata Banerjee faction of the Trinamool Congress to join the Nationalist Citizens Party of India.

According to sources, TMC leader and former high-profile Bengal Minister Dr Shashi Panja engaged in a private meeting with NCPI leader and MP Dr Kakoli Ghosh dashtidar along with another former TMC minister. "Not only Shashi Panja but also another former very powerful minister had come," a kin of Dr Ghoshdashtidar said. Dr Panja is a close relative of former Union Minister Ajit Panja.

The duo met at the clinic of Ghoshdashtidar on Sunday evening, sources said. Both are medical practitioners.

Though followers of Shashi Panja denied claims that Dr Panja was planning to join NCPI, the Mamata



Kakoli Ghosh dashtidar

Banerjee faction of the TMC said that she had not shown up at Banerjee's Kalighat residence ever since the TMC lost the Bengal Assembly elections on June 4.

Senior TMC leader and MLA of Mamata Banerjee faction Kunal Ghosh refused to comment on the issue saying he had not heard of Panja for the past two months. "She has not come after the defeat... when I called up she said that she was abroad and would come after she returns... after that she would not come... so how can I say whom she met or whom did not... I am also not sure about her plans to join any

High dropouts, teacher crunch in West Bengal schools: CAG



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

A high dropout rate, teacher shortage and poor utilisation of central funds have affected the implementation of the Samagra Shiksha scheme in West Bengal, according to a performance audit report by the CAG.

The audit, which examined scheme execution across the State between 2019-20 and 2023-24, highlighted a massive 28 to 42 per cent transition loss between upper primary and higher secondary levels.

The audit team conducted a field survey of 581 out-of-school kids across 21 high schools in six test-checked districts to ascertain the reasons behind the high dropout rate.

"The survey highlighted dropouts mainly due to financial constraints, early marriage and intentions of early earnings among students," the report said.

According to the findings, poverty and financial hardship emerged as the biggest driver, with 53 per cent of surveyed parents citing financial distress for pulling their children out of school.

Another 14 per cent reported unwillingness among students to continue studies, 13 per cent stated migration for work, and 12 per cent attributed the discontinuation of education to early marriage.

It found that over 500 schools were functional without a single teacher.

The report flagged critical

structural gaps in teacher deployment and Pupil-Teacher Ratios (PTR) across State-run schools.

"Eight per cent (5,152 schools) of schools in the state were running with only a single teacher, affecting 1,76,491 students, and 520 schools had no teachers, which impacted the education of 8,596 students," the CAG report stated.

In contrast, the audit pointed out severe administrative imbalances, where 40,530 head teachers were posted in schools with fewer than 150 students, violating Right to Education (RTE) deployment norms.

The report noted that 29 per cent of primary schools and 30 per cent of upper primary schools failed to achieve the minimum PTR norms due to a deficit of 31,684 primary and 2,058 upper primary teachers, respectively.

At the higher secondary level, 79 per cent of schools exceeded the prescribed PTR limits.

Examining public finance management, the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) observed that scheme fund utilisation in the state ranged between a low 46 and 65 per cent over the five-year period.

"Delays in release of funds by the Central and the State Governments and delay in execution of targeted interventions exhibited fiscal indiscipline, weakening the outcome in achieving the scheme's objectives," the audit remarked.

Ruckus in Punjab Assembly over paper leak issue

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chandigarh

Noisy scenes unfolded in the Punjab Assembly on Monday as opposition Congress MLAs raised the issue of alleged multiple paper leaks and sought the resignation of Education Minister Harjot Singh Bains.

Treasury benches led by Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema counter-attacked the Congress legislators, accusing them of staging a drama. Speaker Kultar Singh Sandhwan briefly adjourned the proceedings after the Congress MLAs trooped to the Well of the House on the first day of the State Assembly's Monsoon Session.

During the Question Hour, Leader of Opposition Partap Singh Bajwa raised the issue of alleged multiple examination paper leaks in the state over the last four and a half years.

Pointing to Education Minister Bains, Congress leader Bajwa said he visited the Cockroach Janta Party's protest site at Jantar Mantar



Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann speaks in the House on the opening day of the Punjab Assembly session in Chandigarh on Monday

PTI

in Delhi, where he demanded Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak controversy.

The CJP called off its 36-day agitation on July 25 after Pradhan resigned and the Government accepted its other demands.

Bajwa asked whether Education Minister Harjot Singh Bains would now accept responsibility for the alleged paper leak in Punjab and resign. The LoP alleged that six exam paper leak incidents occurred during the AAP

regime: five linked to the education department and one to the health department.

Referring to the recent cheating racket unearthed during the pharmacy officer recruitment exam, Bajwa demanded the resignation of Health Minister Balbir Singh.

Bajwa, along with other Congress MLAs wearing black scarves, continued to press for the resignation of Bains and Singh, even as the Speaker urged them to maintain order and let the House proceedings continue.

Ignoring the Speaker, the Congress MLAs rushed to the Well of the House and raised slogans against the AAP government. Responding to the allegations, Bains said he would respond after the Question Hour, stating he came fully prepared.

He dared the Congress MLAs not to leave the House. "Sit here, I came fully prepared," Bains challenged the Congress MLAs. BJP MLA Ashwani Sharma and suspended Congress MLA Sandeep Jakhar supported the issue raised by the Congress MLA, though they did not go to the Well of the House.

Leading the charge against the Congress MLAs, Finance Minister Cheema slammed them for allegedly indulging in a drama. Lauding the Mann government's work, Cheema said around 70,000 jobs were given only on merit during the four-and-a-half-year period.

The Congress MLAs continued sloganeering and demanded the resignation of both ministers.

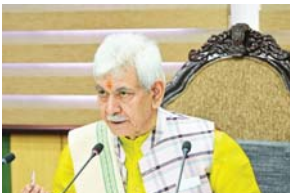
Climate change rapidly affecting Himalayas, need eco-friendly solutions, says J&K LG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Srinagar

Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Monday said climate change was taking place at an alarming pace in the Himalayas, while calling for nature-based solutions for development.

The alarming pace of climate change in the Himalayan region is highlighted by the fact that, between January and August last year, the Himalayas witnessed a natural disaster almost every day. Sinha said while addressing a climate conference at the Islamic University of Science & Technology (IUST) in Awantipora.

The LG said in Jammu and Kashmir alone, flash floods and cloudbursts have damaged public infrastructure, disrupting roads, water supply schemes, and power feeders.



J&K LG Manoj Sinha

He said that there is no dichotomy between development and conservation, and nature itself is infrastructure. "For example, constructing a watershed is also an effective flood-control system. It is infrastructure that also serves as a water purification system and forms the basis of an irrigation system.

"Similarly, a wetland is nature's vast reservoir because it absorbs excess water during the monsoon and then slowly gives life to surrounding areas during the dry months," he said.

Sinha said a dense forest-

ed mountain slope is like a strong wall that protects the entire mountain from collapsing onto the villages below.

"Therefore, I believe that when we destroy these natural systems, we are playing with the future," he said, urging the experts to put forward nature-based solutions for development.

While addressing the conference, he also suggested using technologies like remote sensing, geospatial mapping, and AI to track glacier retreat, spring flow, soil health, and forest cover.

"This data should inform every development project in the region. Nature-based solutions must be embedded into project budgeting, appraisal, and monitoring. Farmers, shepherds, orchard owners, and tribal communities must be equal stakeholders," he said.

Indian Museum, IIT Kharagpur tie up for AI artefact restoration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Indian Museum in Kolkata has joined hands with IIT-Kharagpur for the use of "AI-based restoration" of archaeological artefacts and digital preservation of its collections, the Government informed Parliament on Monday.

Union Culture Minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, in a written response to a query in the Lok Sabha, also said the Indian Museum, in collaboration with Google Art and Culture, has prepared a virtual exhibition for promotion of heritage through digital interventions.

Google Art and Culture is the cultural platform of the internet giant.

The minister was asked whether any national framework has been developed for digital archiving, collection management and virtual public access to museum



Indian Museum, Kolkata

collections in the country.

"Indian Museum, Kolkata, aligning with the vision of 'Vikas Bhi, Virasat Bhi' and in accordance with its mandate of promoting and preserving cultural heritage, has undertaken collaborative initiatives with the academic institutions to strengthen heritage conservation and digital innovation," he said.

The Indian Museum has joined hands with IIT-Kharagpur for the use of "AI-based restoration of archaeological artefacts, for digital preservation of its collec-

tions", the minister said.

Also, the Indian Museum, in collaboration with Google Art and Culture, has prepared a virtual exhibition for the promotion of heritage through digital interventions.

As part of its modernisation, AI-based interactives and AR-based visitor engagement tools have been introduced to provide an immersive gallery experience to visitors, he added.

Besides, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has launched mobile-based applications for the archaeological

museums at Hampi (Karnataka) and Nalanda (Bihar). The applications provide virtual tours of the museums and facilitate digital access to the artefacts displayed therein.

Delhi-based Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts (IGNCA) has undertaken documentation, research, publication and digital preservation of various aspects of Mithila art, traditions and manuscripts through its regular academic and archival activities, he said.

The Government also said the Ministry of Culture is taking different initiatives in digital archiving and collection management to preserve our cultural assets through digitisation with JATAN software, developed by C-DAC, Pune, for digitisation of museum collections and archival repositories.

A national digital repository has been created through the Museums of India portal,

where digitised collections of eight national-level museums, two ASI site museums and Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar Museum, Pune are available.

In tabulated data, the minister also shared the status of digitisation of museum collections available on the website through JATAN software, according to which out of the total 4,78,971 artefacts at these eight national-level museums, 3,36,359 artefacts (or 70.23 per cent) can be digitally seen on their respective websites.

The individual figures for these museums stood at — National Museum (total 2,06,169 artefacts) 51.15 per cent can be digitally seen on its website; Indian Museum (total 1,08,000 artefacts) 72.17 per cent can be digitally seen on its website; Victoria Memorial Hall (total 28,394 artefacts) 98.34 per cent can be digitally seen on its website.

BJP accuses Opposition of insulting saints

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday accused the Opposition of insulting Hindu saints and hurting religious sentiments through its protest inside the Parliament House complex over the alleged theft of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya and demanded strict action against those involved.

The remarks came after opposition MPs, including Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, protested in the Parliament House complex on Monday against the alleged theft of donations and police excesses against student protesters. Addressing reporters in the Parliament House complex, BJP National General secretary Tarun Chugh alleged that opposition leaders, by wearing saffron robes during the protest, made saffron and Hindu seers “objects of ridicule”.

“Wearing saffron robes and disguising yourselves as saints, you are standing inside the premises of the



BJP National general secretary Tarun Chugh

world's largest democratic institution and making saffron an object of ridicule. You are making India's saints a laughing stock. This is unfortunate. Strict action should be taken,” Chugh said.

He claimed that Hindus across the world are hurt and angry over the protest and asserted that there is widespread resentment against those responsible.

During their skit at the protest in Parliament on Friday, the MPs, including Gandhi, put money into donation boxes, while Independent MP Rajesh Ranjan alias Pappu Yadav,

dressed in saffron robes, slipped money into his pockets to symbolise the alleged theft at the Ram Temple. Seers and Hindu outfits allege that he insulted Sanatan Dharma.

Chugh also praised Prime Minister Narendra Modi, saying he has spent the last 12 years working to fulfil the aspirations of the country's youth and has taken a “big-hearted” decision to forgive the students and put them back on the path of progress.

BJP MP Dinesh Sharma alleged that the opposition disrupts democratic traditions instead of raising issues

inside Parliament and described its members as “agenda-driven”, “issue-less” and “frustrated”.

“They are speed breakers in the country's development journey. Every day they stage protests outside Parliament without any issue. The opposition should present its views inside the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha instead of raising slogans outside,” Sharma said.

BJP MP Nishikant Dubey alleged that the opposition has no hesitation in mocking saffron robes and Hindu deities, while no party would dare to dress up as a Muslim cleric, make a mock structure of a mosque or make remarks against the Prophet.

Dubey also said the BJP opposes all forms of violence and described the slipper-throwing incident at Pappu Yadav as “unfortunate”, though he alleged that the incident was exaggerated.

A man threw a slipper at Yadav during a press conference at his residence on Sunday after the Independent MP defended his controver-

sial skit in Parliament House complex on the alleged donation theft, leading to a scuffle between his supporters and the attacker.

Dubey also criticised the Congress over the erstwhile Haj subsidy, alleging financial irregularities, and accused previous Congress governments of discriminating against the RSS.

The Opposition MPs protested in front of Makar Dwar of Parliament with slogans such as ‘chhanda chor, gaddi chor’ and ‘Amit Shah sadan mein aao’ raised.

The MPs also kept donation boxes at the spot to symbolise the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple and lined up around them to raise slogans against the government. Some MPs also put cash in the box to symbolise the donations made and the “theft” that took place later.

Besides Priyanka Gandhi, SP's Dimple Yadav and Dharmendra Yadav, TMC's Mahua Moitra, JMM's Mahua Maji, RSP's NK Premchandran, among others, participated in the protest.



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh launches the revised vision and mission statement of the JS & CAO office during the AFHQ Civilian Services Day ceremony in New Delhi

Deep civil-military synergy key to security: Rajnath Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Monday underlined the need to deepen integration between the military and civil components of the Ministry of Defence to foster greater synergy to tackle evolving security and technological challenges, while ensuring institutional memory, stability, and the effective application of rules and regulations.

Addressing the 85th Armed Forces Headquarters (AFHQ) Civilian Services Day celebrations, he emphasised that both the uniformed and civil services share the same commitment of ‘Nation First’, and when the objective is singular, every element of the system transforms into national strength.

AFHQ Day is celebrated on the first day of August every year to recognise the role of the personnel who work shoulder-to-shoulder with Service personnel, primarily in the three Integrated

Service Headquarters, Headquarters Integrated Defence Staff and 24 Inter-Service Organisations of the Ministry of Defence.

The foundation of AFHQ cadres was laid on August 1, 1942 by organising the then decentralised civilian posts/cadre operation as distinct entities under various Service Headquarters and Secretariat of Ministry of Defence and Finance (Defence) under the control of Chief Administrative Officer. Rajnath Singh underlined that military and administrative integration cannot proceed along separate paths, adding that, as joint and integrated structures develop, there will be a need for continuity and expertise across all areas - policy, administration, human resource management, financial processes, logistics, and institutional knowledge.

He highlighted the importance of further enhancing structured cross-exposure between civilian and mili-

tary officers, suggesting joint training programmes and developmental assignments for both sides to learn from each other's experiences.

Explaining with the example of ‘cyber warfare’, the defence minister stated that if officers of the AFHQ Civilian Services develop defence-specific common cyber tools leveraging their expertise, it could prove beneficial to the Defence Forces.

Minister of state for defence Sanjay Seth, Chief of Defence Staff General N S Raja Subramani, Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Krishna Swaminathan, Chief of the Army Staff General Dhiraj Seth, Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, Secretary (Defence Production) Sanjeev Kumar, Secretary (Defence Finance) Vishvajit Sahay, Vice Chief of the Air Staff Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit, Additional Secretary Manish Tripathi, JS & CAO Amitabh Prasad and other senior officials were present on the occasion.

Monsoon session Of Gujarat Assembly scheduled September 8-10

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

The Monsoon session of Gujarat assembly will be held from September 8 to 10, Speaker Shankar Chaudhary announced on Monday.

Addressing reporters in Gandhinagar, Chaudhary said Governor Acharya Devvrat has convened the ninth session of the 15th Gujarat assembly.

The session will transact government business, including the introduction and passage of government bills, discussion on official business and other matters approved by the Business Advisory Committee, he said.

Chaudhary said MLAs will be able to raise issues concerning their respective constituencies during the session.

Legislators can submit their questions online for the Question Hour for one week from the announcement date so that they can be taken up during the session, he added.

4 dead in lightning strikes at separate places in West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Howrah

Four people died and two others were injured after lightning struck three locations in West Bengal's Howrah district on Monday, police said.

The incidents occurred in Jagatballavpur, Amta and Bagnan police station areas.

At Maju in Jagatballavpur, four people working in and around agricultural fields were struck by lightning during rain.

“Two persons died on the spot, while two others suf-



Commuters make their way amid rainfall in Kolkata

PTI

fered serious injuries and were shifted to a hospital,” a police officer said.

The two deceased farmers were identified as Manabendra Mondal (50) and Anup Kar (45). The dis-

trict administration is monitoring the situation closely, and assistance will be extended in accordance with the government norms,” an official said.

In another incident,

Sushanta Roy (35) died after being struck by lightning at Sonamui Dhakipara under Amta police station.

He was reportedly washing mud off his spade at a pond after returning from work in the fields when lightning struck. He was taken to Amta Rural Hospital, where doctors declared him dead.

In the third such incident, another peasant died after being struck by lightning while working in a field at Katapukur under Bagnan police station. His identity was yet to be ascertained, police said.

National Testing Agency floats ₹7.5 crore security tender after NEET paper leak

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Following the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak controversy, the National Testing Agency (NTA) has floated a ₹7.5 crore tender for round-the-clock security services at its headquarters at Minto Road, regional offices at Okhla, storage facilities and other notified locations.

According to the tender document, the move aims to safeguard NTA's personnel, visitors, assets, premises, records, confi-



dential examination material, server rooms, strong rooms and other critical infrastructure.

The July 25 Request for Proposal (RFP) said the estimated contract value is “₹7.5 crore plus GST (tentative) for a 2-year contract without variation”.

Bids can be submitted until 3 pm on August 17, and the printing-services tender closes on August 20, it said. The contract will initially remain valid for two years and can be extended for two additional one-year periods, subject to satis-

factory performance, mutual consent and approval of the competent authority.

The tender requires a ₹15 lakh deposit and will be evaluated under the Quality and Cost Based Selection (QCBS) model, where the technical score carries 70 per cent weightage and the financial score carries 30 per cent.

“The bidder must have provided professional security services for at least five years as of the last date for bid submission,” the document said. The RFP requires

bidders to have experience providing security services to Central Government Ministries, universities, examination agencies, IT parks, airports, hospitals, metro rail systems or other establishments requiring round-the-clock security. Bidders must also have an average annual turnover of not less than ₹10 crore during the last three financial years. The document stated that “the selected agency shall deploy professionally trained, physically fit, police-verified and experienced security

personnel.” The scope of work includes access control, premises protection, patrolling, security of confidential examination material, CCTV monitoring, visitor management, fire and emergency response and incident reporting.

The tender said security personnel must ensure the protection of “confidential examination records”, “examination logistics”, “digital storage media”, and strong rooms containing examination-related material and sensitive files entrusted by the NTA.

CBI SIT visits RG Kar hospital to revisit probe into trainee doctor rape-murder

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

A Special Investigation Team (SIT) of the CBI visited the R G Kar Medical College and Hospital here to re-examine different aspects of its investigation into the rape and murder of a trainee medico two years ago, sources said.

In May this year, the Calcutta High Court on Thursday ordered the setting up of an SIT of the CBI to probe the developments from the time the trainee doctor had dinner on the night of August 9, 2024, to her cremation. The post-graduate trainee doctor's raped and murder in the hospital had caused an uproar in the state as well as among the medical community across the country.

On Monday, the five-member probe team inspected different parts of the hospital, including the emergency department, to re-examine different aspects of the investigation, a source in the national probe agency said.

Last week, the CBI submitted a status report before a local court, informing it that the



probe was still underway and more time was required to complete the investigation.

The investigation is now being led by Sandipani Garg, who recently took charge of the SIT. He appeared before the Sealdah court on July 30 as the new investigating officer and briefly interacted with the victim's mother, urging her to have faith in the investigation.

India to host second BRICS anti-corruption meet in Hyderabad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Hyderabad

Strengthening informal cooperation to trace fugitives sought in corruption cases and supporting extradition proceedings would be among the key points of discussion at a BRICS Anti-Corruption Working Group (ACWG) meeting to be held on August 4 and 5.

The Union Government's Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) will host the second meeting of the ACWG and the second meeting of the BRICS expert network on asset recovery, during India's BRICS Presidency in 2026.

The meeting is being organised in line with the theme of India's BRICS Presidency, “Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability”, an official release said here on Monday. The event would be inaugurated by Rachna Shah, Secretary, DoPT. We expect partici-



pation from BRICS member countries, along with senior policymakers, experts, and representatives of anti-corruption and law enforcement agencies.

The Hyderabad meeting builds upon the outcomes of the First BRICS anti-corruption working group

meeting, held virtually on June 2–3, it said. BRICS members will deliberate on strengthening international cooperation for asset recovery, combating cross-border corruption, and enhancing transparency and accountability in governance.

The discussions will focus on strengthening informal cooperation for tracing fugitives, enhancing information-sharing and operational cooperation through the BRICS expert network on asset recovery.

In addition, sharing experiences in preventing and combating corruption-related risks arising from FinTech, digital assets and emerging digital financial instruments would also be discussed, it said.

A dedicated side event titled “Ethical Governance through Innovation and Tech-Driven Systems” will also be organised on August 5.

The side event will provide a plat-

form for BRICS members to exchange experiences on technology-enabled governance, including digital public procurement, citizen engagement, transparency, accountability and innovative approaches to strengthening integrity in public administration, the release said.

The Hyderabad meeting will reaffirm India's commitment to promoting practical cooperation among BRICS members through dialogue, exchange of experiences and collaborative initiatives.

As the final anti-corruption working group meeting during India's BRICS Presidency, it is expected to consolidate the progress achieved during the year and lay the foundation for sustained cooperation among BRICS members in asset recovery, prevention of cross-border corruption, technology-enabled governance and institutional capacity-building, the release added.

BRS leader hits out at Telangana Govt over unfulfilled promise of two lakh jobs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Alleging that the Congress Government has not fulfilled its promise of providing two lakh jobs in the first year of its tenure, BRS Working President KT Rama Rao on Monday said Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy should answer to the youth over the assurance.

Gandhi, who had promised two lakh jobs, is silent now, he said.

“A youth attempted suicide in Khammam district in protest against jobs not being given, though a job calendar was announced two years ago and Gandhi promised



BRS Working President KT Rama Rao

two lakh jobs in the first year (of Congress Government),” Rao told reporters here.

The senior Congress leader, who previously visited Ashok Nagar, the hub of coaching centres in Hyderabad, is not coming to the city now, he

said. “Gandhi visits different places carrying the Constitution book in his hand. But he does not come to states where the party is in power,” he said.

The youth who allegedly attempted suicide is from

Madhira, represented in the Assembly by Deputy Chief Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka, he said.

The State Government had informed in a written reply that it filled up over 16,978 vacancies, he said.

If the vacancies which were notified during the BRS regime are exempted, the Congress Government has not filled up even 10,000 vacancies, the BRS leader claimed. The suicide note of the youth is a chargesheet against the Government, he added. CM Reddy said in July that the Congress Government removed all obstacles in job recruitment and filled up 70,000 vacancies.

22 children died of deadly Chandipura virus in Gujarat this monsoon, seven under treatment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

As many as 22 children have died due to Chandipura virus (CHPV) in Gujarat this monsoon season, with 35 cases testing positive out of 184 suspected infections, State Health Minister Praful Panseriya said on Monday.

Seven patients remain under treatment across civil hospitals in Gandhinagar, Rajkot, and other districts, and government and private paediatric facilities have been instructed to immediately admit symptomatic patients to ICU beds to prevent organ failure, he said. “A total of 184 suspected cases have been regis-



tered in the state so far, out of which 35 cases have tested positive and the results of 11 samples are still pending,” Panseriya said.

Out of the cases reported so far, 22 children have died due to Chandipura virus, he said. All patients are under 15 years of age, he added.

Children who are admit-

ted to civil hospitals in Gandhinagar, Sabarkantha-Himmatnagar, Patan, Rajkot and Bhavnagar are being provided the best and super-specialist treatment and doctors are monitoring their condition, Panseriya said.

He further noted that cases are being reported from different areas and not

concentrated in a particular village. Health teams are spraying pesticides in areas where animal husbandry is practised to target sandflies, which are responsible for spreading the encephalitis virus, he said.

Government and private paediatric facilities have been instructed to admit patients with symptoms of the virus to ICU beds with oxygen and ventilator facilities and not delay treatment so that serious conditions like multiple organ failure can be prevented, he said. Chandipura encephalitis is a viral disease that spreads mainly by sandflies and other insects and causes inflammation of the brain.

Editor's TAKE

A drug-free India begins with its youth

As India aspires to become a Viksit Bharat by 2047, protecting its young from the scourge of drugs must be treated as a national priority requiring collective action

On Sunday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressed over a crore young Indians connected from more than 28,000 locations to launch the Nasha Mukh Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan-a campaign asking the country's youth to be both its target audience and its foot soldiers. The ambition matched the scale: a 100-week movement, unfolding every Sunday, woven into the larger project of a developed India by 2047. The message was blunt-a nation cannot be built on a generation numbed by addiction. The urgency is not manufactured. Government surveys already count close to ten crore Indians touched by narcotics in some form-sixteen crore users of alcohol, over three crore cannabis users, and close to two crore linked to opioids. The Narcotics Control Bureau seized 1.33 lakh kilograms of narcotics worth nearly ₹2,000 crore last year, arresting 994 traffickers as conviction rates climbed to 66.8 per cent. States along the Punjab border and the industrial belts of Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra have long topped the case count. The Supreme Court, while hearing a narco-terror case in 2024, went so far as to warn that the fallout of rising addiction leaves a "generational imprint" on public health and national security. Against that backdrop, a campaign built around the country's youngest citizens is not premature. If anything, it is overdue. What distinguishes this from the Nasha Mukh Bharat Abhiyaan, running since 2020, is its idiom. Modi leaned on identity rather than prohibition-calling recovering users "warriors" instead of casting them out, and drawing over 125 spiritual and civil society organisations into what might otherwise have read as another government notice. Tying sobriety to the Viksit Bharat vision gives young Indians a stake larger than compliance: abstinence becomes nation-building, not mere obedience to the law. Arriving days after student protests over examination reforms unsettled Delhi, the launch also reads as an attempt to re-engage a restive Gen Z on the government's own terms. Yet pledges and pageantry have been tried before. The older Abhiyaan counts over fourteen crore participants and lakhs of partner institutions-and, by most accounts, addiction levels have barely moved. Critics are right to point out that India's shortfall lies less in messaging than in infrastructure: too few de-addiction centres, a scarcity of trained counsellors, and a stigma that still keeps families from seeking help before a crisis strikes. A pledge taken at a rally offers little to a teenager with nowhere to turn the following morning. If this campaign is to outlast its own launch, the 100 Sundays ahead must build treatment capacity as visibly as they stage awareness drives. Symbolism has its place in a democracy of this size – a Prime Minister speaking directly to a crore young citizens is not nothing. But Viksit Bharat will not be won by slogans. The real test of the Nasha Mukh Yuva Abhiyan lies away from the cameras, in whether counsellors, treatment beds and second chances multiply as fast as the pledges do. Only then does a sankalp become a cure.

PIC TALK



Farmers transplant paddy saplings in a field, in Nadia district, West Bengal.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

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US-IRAN CONFLICT RESHAPES GLOBAL STRATEGIC BALANCE FOREVER

Apropos of the landmark article, "When Strength Becomes a Liability" (3 Aug), the ongoing US-Iran conflict raises profound questions about the limits of military power and the long-term consequences of prolonged warfare. The war is unlikely to end until both sides are exhausted, with no easy or immediate resolution in sight. The President of the United States is not a warlord, yet the conflict appears to have expanded beyond political control, making strategic management increasingly difficult. The prolonged confrontation has also exposed the fragility of the existing global order. Rather than reinforcing American influence, it risks weakening the United States' credibility among both allies and supporters. If uncertainty continues, global manufacturing and investment may gradually diversify away from the US.

reducing its economic leverage. Many believe this conflict could have been avoided. Years of sanctions had already placed significant economic pressure on Iran, raising the question of whether diplomacy could have achieved more than military escalation. Equally concerning is the rhetoric surrounding nuclear weapons, as any such escalation would have consequences far beyond the immediate region. The Mediterranean is not indispensable to global commerce, and the world's dependence on petroleum is steadily declining as nations invest in alternative energy sources. The US-Iran conflict is therefore likely to accelerate wider changes in global security, trade, diplomacy and strategic alliances, reshaping the international order in ways that may endure long after the guns fall silent.

VINOD JOHRI | DELHI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Gau Mutra: Science should not be ridiculed

Throughout history, many medicines originated from traditional knowledge. Aspirin evolved from willow bark, artemisinin from traditional Chinese medicine, and numerous modern drugs have their roots in indigenous medical systems



MEENAKSHI LEKHI

Priyanka Gandhi's recent reference to an IIT Director as a "gau mutra expert" has ignited a debate that extends beyond politics. The real question is not whether one personally believes in traditional remedies or not. The question is whether scientific inquiry should be encouraged or ridiculed. Science advances by testing hypotheses, not by mocking them. Throughout history, many medicines originated from traditional knowledge. Aspirin evolved from willow bark, artemisinin from traditional Chinese medicine, and numerous modern drugs have their roots in indigenous medical systems. The correct scientific approach is to investigate traditional claims objectively, accepting those supported by evidence and rejecting those that fail rigorous testing. For the sake of dispelling ignorance, I must state that more than 70 per cent of chemicals used in modern medicine are phytochemicals, which means originating from plants, and a whole lot of those plants aren't originally from the Western Hemisphere. Contrary to claims that there is "no science" behind gomutra, several peer-reviewed studies have investigated cow urine and cow urine distillate. Published research has reported antibacterial activity against certain bacteria, antifungal activity, antioxidant properties, immune-modulating effects, and potential bio-enhancer properties that may improve the effectiveness of some antibiotics in laboratory settings. Most importantly, these findings are primarily laboratory (in vitro) or animal studies, and in India, it has been practised on humans as part of traditional medicine. Therefore, they should be viewed as promising research and further establish the same with precision for medical treatments. The two patents in the United States of America, which were highlighted by Parliamentarian Sudhanshu Trivedi in the Lok Sabha, very strongly relate to cow urine distillate, involving pharmaceutical compositions using cow urine distillate as a bio-enhancer and use of bioactive fractions of cow urine distillate to enhance antimicrobial and anticancer agents. Research involving cow urine or cow urine distillate has been carried out by scientists affiliated with institutions in several countries, including India, Nepal, United States, and United Kingdom, includes collaborative research and publications. The research has largely focused on antimicrobial compounds, antioxidant activity, bio-enhancer effects, veterinary applications, and antiviral screening. Recent laboratory work has investigated whether compounds isolated from cow urine distillate demonstrate antiviral activity against viruses such as Chikungunya under laboratory conditions. This illustrates an important scientific principle that Traditional medicinal claims deserve investigation in order to identify positive



laboratory findings, and nothing stops the sceptics to research further and test the safety for human use, which may require rigorous clinical evidence. The issue becomes bigger than cow urine when parachute or hereditary politicians ridicule scientific investigation because the subject originates from traditional knowledge - knowledge of which they lack, they risk discouraging legitimate research. The scientific method requires openness, scepticism, replication, and evidence. The appropriate response is therefore not blind acceptance or blanket dismissal, but rigorous evaluation. Priyanka Gandhi's description was intended as political criticism, but it raises a deeper question: Should scientific inquiry be dismissed because its subject appears unconventional or rooted in traditional knowledge? The remark has drawn criticism from hundreds of academicians, who argued that reducing a distinguished scientist to a single label undermines academic discourse. History reminds us that many scientific ideas initially faced ridicule before they were properly evaluated. I am reminded of Galileo, who did not become famous because he was always right. He became famous because he insisted that evidence-not ridicule or authority-should decide scientific questions. When Galileo argued that the Earth revolved around the Sun, many dismissed or opposed his work because it challenged accepted beliefs. Over time, observations and evidence established the heliocentric model. If the politically driven criticism was directed at specific scientific claims, those claims should be challenged with data. If the criticism was directed simply at the fact that a scientist has researched or discussed cow urine, then it risks discouraging inquiry into traditional knowledge. Ridicule has never been part of the scientific method. The appropriate response to controversial research is not to dismiss researchers with labels, nor to accept every traditional claim uncritically. It is to let evidence decide. Whether future research validates, refines, or disproves claims about gomutra should be determined in laboratories and clinical trials and not in political speeches. What the global Scientific Community agrees is that cow urine contains biologically active compounds that merit scientific investigation. Secondly, laboratory and animal studies have reported antimicrobial, antioxidant, and immunomodulatory effects. While scientists in India such as Dr Suman Preet Singh Khanuja led research on cow urine distillate as a bio-enhancer that could improve the absorption and effectiveness of antibiotics and anticancer drugs and is also the co-inventor of US patents

THE CONTRIBUTION OF ANCIENT HINDU CIVILISATION IN THE FIELD OF SCIENCE IS UNPARALLELED. THE PEDIGREE OF RISHIS AND THEIR PARAMPARA IS SUCH THAT NONE OF THE IMPORTED OR DOGMATIC GANDHIS - VADRAS CAN EITHER COMPETE OR UNDERMINE. I HAVE MY SUSPICIONS ABOUT THEIR ABILITY TO COMPREHEND

The writer is a former Minister of State for External Affairs of India

The quiet grace that shapes our lives

have always been people who quietly appeared when I most needed guidance or reassurance-my parents, my wife, my children, my friends, my teachers, my seniors, and even strangers whose advice altered the course of my decisions. I remember one such incident from my first posting in the Railways. I wrote an official letter to the Headquarters and was pleasantly surprised to receive a personal reply from a senior officer. He welcomed my first official communication and gently suggested better wording for future correspondence. That small gesture inspired me to give a little more than what duty alone demanded. Only later did I realise that such mentoring was part of the organisational culture and was extended to officers throughout their careers. Looking back, I realise it was only the first of many such moments that shaped my understanding of these values. I have often found myself carrying that tradition into both my professional and personal life. However, when I look at the world around me now, I sometimes wonder whether younger generations receive the same reassurance. We live in an age that measures almost everything instantly. Success is counted in followers, likes, promotions, visibility and constant comparison. Many of us spend so much of our energy keeping pace with an increasingly demanding world that we naturally become more occupied with our own journeys than with quietly encouraging someone else's. Outcomes often



SANJAY CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

We often speak of the wisdom contained in our scriptures and epics, and the importance of introducing our children to them so that they may navigate life's complexities with greater clarity. I inherited these values through stories passed down by my parents, teachers, elders, and countless conversations over the years. Among them, the Mahabharata has perhaps influenced me the most. One idea stayed with me from an early age. We are taught to perform our duty to the best of our ability without becoming attached to the outcome. The results, we are told, are not entirely within our control. Somewhere beyond our limited understanding exists a larger order that ultimately looks after us. As the years passed, I began to see traces of that wisdom in ordinary human relationships. Throughout my life, there

The writer is a founder of Kala - Krazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator, and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Towards a lasting solution

The Cauvery water-sharing dispute has once again become a flashpoint in Tamil Nadu politics, with the TVK government under Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay facing criticism over its handling of the issue. Opposition parties have accused the administration of acting unilaterally, failing to build political consensus, and not responding firmly to Karnataka's reluctance to release water. Amid mounting pressure, the government abandoned its proposed visit to Karnataka for talks with Chief Minister DK Shivakumar and instead approached the Supreme Court, seeking legal intervention. The Apex Court remains the ultimate forum to resolve disputes when negotiations fail. Yet, while judicial intervention may provide immediate relief, it cannot by itself resolve a conflict rooted in competing regional interests, changing rainfall patterns, and increasing water demand. A lasting solution requires cooperative federalism, transparent reservoir management, scientific water-use planning, and sustained political dialogue between the riparian states. Moving beyond seasonal litigation towards institutional mechanisms and long-term water management is essential to ensuring equitable sharing of the Cauvery's waters while reducing recurring disputes and political confrontation.

India's winning momentum

India's fourth-place finish at the 2026 Commonwealth Games, with 39 medals, including 13 gold, marks more than a strong showing on the medals table. It reflects the steady expansion of the country's sporting ecosystem and the emergence of talent across multiple disciplines. Although the Games featured only ten sports, India excelled where it mattered most, with the quality and diversity of performances standing out. Boxing produced its best-ever Commonwealth campaign, yielding a record ten medals, including seven gold. Gulver Singh became the only Indian to win multiple medals, highlighting the country's growing strength in endurance events. Para-athletics reached a new milestone as Sharmila Dhankar became India's first Commonwealth para-athletics gold medalist, while judo and weightlifting also delivered memorable performances. Equally significant was the contribution of women athletes, who secured the majority of India's gold medals, reflecting the widening depth of Indian sport. The challenge now is to translate Commonwealth success into sustained Olympic achievement. As India prepares to host the 2030 Commonwealth Games, the focus must remain on building stronger institutions, coaching systems, and sporting infrastructure that can sustain excellence for years to come.

HARIDASAN RAJAN | KERALA

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

R NARAYANAN | MUMBAI

The six-month rule and the Constitution’s moral compass

The constitutional language is unequivocal. It does not confer discretion upon the executive or the Governor. It prescribes a mandatory constitutional consequence. A minister who has not become a member of the legislature within six consecutive months must cease to hold office.



ABHINAV NARAYAN JHA | SUDEEP CHANDRA

Constitutions are not merely legal texts; they are instruments of democratic restraint. Their enduring strength lies not only in the powers they confer but also in the limitations they impose. In a parliamentary democracy, executive authority is legitimate only when it remains accountable to the legislature, which in turn represents the will of the people. It is this constitutional philosophy that underpins Article 164 of the Constitution of India.

Recent developments in Bihar have revived a debate of profound constitutional significance. The appointment and continuance of Bihar Panchayati Raj Minister Deepak Prakash, despite not being an elected member of either House of the State Legislature, has become the subject of judicial scrutiny before the Supreme Court of India. During the mentioning of a Public Interest Litigation, the Court agreed to hear the matter. While listing the case, the Bench led by Chief Justice Surya Kant observed that the issue was a “pure legal question” and remarked, “How are you retaining a minister beyond six months when he is not elected?” The Court also indicated that it would not permit unnecessary delay in adjudicating the issue.

The controversy invites a larger inquiry that transcends personalities and political affiliations. It asks whether constitutional exceptions may be stretched beyond their intended limits and whether executive office can remain insulated from democratic accountability.

Article 164(1) empowers the Governor to appoint the Chief Minister and, on the advice of the Chief Minister, other Ministers. However, this power is immediately balanced by Article 164(4), which provides: “A Minister who, for any period of six consecutive months, is not a member of the Legislature of the State shall, at the expiration of that period, cease to be a Minister.”

The constitutional language is unequivocal. It does not confer discretion upon the executive or the Governor. It prescribes a mandatory constitutional consequence. A minister who has not become a member of the legislature within six consecutive months must cease to hold office. This provision was never intended to be a parallel route to executive authority. Rather, it is a carefully crafted constitutional exception designed to address extraordinary circumstances. A distinguished public figure, an expert, or a political leader may need to be inducted into the Council of Ministers immediately. The Constitution permits such flexibility, but only on the understanding that democratic legitimacy will follow within a defined constitutional period.

The Constituent Assembly debated this provision with remarkable foresight. BR Ambedkar defended the inclusion of the six-month window not as an exemption from democracy but as a practical necessity in exceptional situations. The framers were acutely conscious that executive authority in a parliamentary system ultimately derives its legitimacy from representative institutions.

The constitutional design therefore reflects a delicate balance between administrative convenience and democratic accountability. Temporary flexibility was permitted, but permanent exemption from legislative responsibility was never contemplated.

The Supreme Court has consistently interpreted Article 164(4) in a manner that preserves its constitutional purpose. In *SP Anand v HD Deve Gowda* (1996), the Court upheld the appointment of a Prime Minister who was not a Member of Parliament at the time of appointment. However, the Court simultaneously reaffirmed that such appointments are constitutionally temporary and subject to the mandatory requirement of obtaining legislative membership within the prescribed period.

The principle was decisively reinforced in *SR Chaudhuri v State of Punjab* (2001). The Supreme Court held that Article 164(4) cannot be manipulated through repeated appointments of a non-legislator after the expiry of six months. Such an interpretation, the Court observed, would defeat the constitutional scheme and reduce the provision to a mechanism for circumventing representative government.

The pending proceedings before the Supreme Court do not merely concern the tenure of a single minister. They



THE PENDING PROCEEDINGS BEFORE THE SUPREME COURT DO NOT MERELY CONCERN THE TENURE OF A SINGLE MINISTER. THEY RAISE AN INSTITUTIONAL QUESTION THAT LIES AT THE HEART OF INDIA'S PARLIAMENTARY DEMOCRACY. CAN CONSTITUTIONAL TIMELINES BE TREATED AS FLEXIBLE POLITICAL CONVENTIONS, OR ARE THEY BINDING COMMANDS THAT PRESERVE DEMOCRATIC LEGITIMACY?

Abhinav Narayan Jha is an advocate and columnist based at Delhi. Sudeep Chandra is an advocate based at New Delhi

raise an institutional question that lies at the heart of India's parliamentary democracy. Can constitutional timelines be treated as flexible political conventions, or are they binding commands that preserve democratic legitimacy? Whatever the eventual outcome, the Court's decision is likely to become a defining precedent on the relationship between executive power and legislative accountability.

The Republic now awaits not merely a judgment on an individual appointment, but a reaffirmation of the constitutional values that animate responsible government.

Beyond the textual interpretation of Article 164(4) lies a deeper constitutional principle-constitutional morality. The Supreme Court has, in several landmark judgments, recognised that the Constitution is sustained not merely by legal compliance but by fidelity to its democratic ethos. Constitutional morality demands that those entrusted with public power exercise it in a manner that strengthens, rather than weakens, the institutions of representative government. A minister in a parliamentary democracy occupies a unique constitutional position. Unlike civil servants, ministers are politically accountable to the legislature and collectively responsible to the elected House. Their authority is not personal; it is derived from the confidence of the people's representatives. It is this relationship between the executive and the legislature that distinguishes parliamentary democracy from other constitutional models.

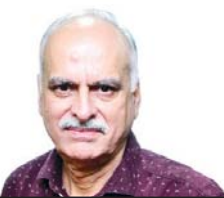
The framers of the Constitution were conscious that governance sometimes requires flexibility. They therefore permitted the appointment of a non-legislator as a minister, but only for a limited duration. The six-month period reflects a constitutional compromise between administrative necessity and democratic legitimacy. Once that period expires, the expectation is that the constitutional process will be completed through legislative membership, ensuring that executive authority remains anchored in representative government.

The broader concern is institutional rather than political. Constitutional democracies are strengthened when constitutional conventions are respected voluntarily, not merely because courts enforce them. Public confidence in governance depends upon the perception that constitutional offices are held in accordance with both the letter and the spirit of the Constitution. When constitutional questions arise, prompt legal clarification and institutional transparency reinforce that confidence. Equally important is the principle of public trust. Every constitutional office carries not only legal authority but also an ethical obligation. This debate should not be viewed through the narrow lens of partisan politics. Governments change, political majorities fluctuate, and individuals holding office come and go. Constitutional principles, however, endure.

The interpretation adopted today may govern the conduct of future governments regardless of political affiliation. The Supreme Court's eventual decision will not merely resolve an individual dispute; it will contribute to the constitutional jurisprudence governing responsible government in India.

Ultimately, the true strength of the Indian Constitution lies in its insistence that power must always remain accountable. Article 164(4) reflects that philosophy. It embodies the idea that executive office is not an independent source of authority but an office sustained by democratic legitimacy and constitutional discipline. As the Republic awaits the Supreme Court's decision, the larger lesson is clear. Constitutional democracy flourishes when institutions act within their prescribed limits, when constitutional conventions are honoured in good faith, and when public office is exercised with humility before the Constitution. The six-month rule is therefore more than a procedural timeline-it is a constitutional reminder that, in India, the legitimacy of executive power ultimately rests upon the confidence of representative institutions and the enduring supremacy of the Constitution itself.

CJP: Resilience, resistance and India’s youth



ANIL ANAND

Cockroach Janata Party (CJP), an incidental and accidental creation, came into being thanks to the Chief Justice of India's remark-whether casual, off-the-cuff or serious. Named after one of the most primitive living winged insects, with origins dating back 320 million years and comprising over 4,600 species worldwide, the cockroach has found a new meaning in the current Indian context. The long existence of this underrated insect is attributed to its resilience and instinct to survive under the most difficult circumstances.

Barely two months into existence in its new manifestation as CJP, with restive but resilient youth becoming its fulcrum, it has no leader, cadre, ideology, constitution or manifesto. It is neither a recognised, registered nor an unregistered political party, but merely a phenomenon that has shaken the powerful government and captured the imagination of society, particularly the youth, who until recently had been solidly supporting Prime Minister Narendra Modi but are now seeking his accountability. At the centre of this phenomenal success are Gen Z's drive and educationist-environmentalist Sonam Wangchuk's steely resolve, which took the short-lived agitation to a new high. That does not take away the credit from the enormous youth force of the country and their parents, who came out of their comfort zones to protest. As a field reporter in Delhi, having covered many major rallies, protests and public meetings over the last four decades, one has never witnessed such a spectacle before. A nondescript organisation, emerging from nowhere and giving a clarion call to join the protest against the government's failure to check paper leaks and its refusal to remove Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan for presiding over this mess, led to an unbelievable response.

The entirely voluntary nature of the protest, in every respect, has been its strongest point. The crowds came voluntarily, spending their own money, unlike the traditional practice of mobilising people through cash payments or by arranging their travel. Once at the venue, and faced with police action that left hundreds of young protesters injured, society swung into action. Food, water and medical aid became readily available. Even more encouraging was that this voluntary effort transcended religion, caste, creed, colour and political affiliations. Alleged intrusions by ruling party supporters, though very few in number and reportedly backed by the police, were the sordid side of this otherwise remarkable story.

From the unassailable position that the Narendra Modi dispensation had created for itself over the past decade, the CJP-mobilised youth protest posed the first serious challenge to it. Ostensibly, the high hopes that the youth, along with other sections of society, had pinned on the Prime Minister have been belied, particularly with the education system going haywire. On top of that, the BJP's heavy religion-based agenda, culminating in the alleged donation theft in Ayodhya's Ram Temple, managed by a trust packed with nominees of the ruling dispensation, led to pent-up anger erupting at the CJP congregation. Notwithstanding the fact that student outfits owing allegiance to Left groups were also at the centre of the action, with half a dozen of their young activists joining Sonam Wangchuk in an indefinite fast, the movement has so far remained aloof from political colouring or related controversies. This is simply because the youth's agenda is brief, focused, meaningful and to the point.

Strategically, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke and his core team invited all political parties to join them, but without their party flags or agendas. Many frontline political representatives came to express solidarity, but none dared impose their own agenda, probably because they were cautioned by the overwhelming presence of the protesting youth.

Sustaining the impact of this mobilisation until the final goal is achieved is certainly a serious challenge for the protesting youth. Given the nature of the current ruling dispensation and its ability to use statecraft in all its manifestations, maintaining the momentum will be crucial in countering such tendencies.

The biggest takeaway from this month-old Gen Z movement is that it has rewritten the concept of the “new normal” prevalent since 2014, with the fear factor at its core. At a time when no one dared question the government, the protesting Gen Z broke this barrier by raising slogans and posing questions directly to the Prime Minister.

However, another major achievement of CJP's revolutionary initiative is that the Jantar Mantar movement has also shaken the Opposition, particularly the Congress, into more meaningful action. The pressure built by Opposition parties in both Houses of Parliament and, finally-hopefully not for the last time-Rahul Gandhi's sit-in outside the Prime Minister's official residence, accompanied by Opposition MPs, has further strengthened the protesting youth's demand for justice. With society and the Opposition parties fully backing them, the movement has gained a kind of multi-pronged safety net. More importantly, the leadership should remain in the hands of CJP's core team and the youth on the ground. Everyone else, including Sonam Wangchuk, Rahul Gandhi and the Opposition parties, should be seen only as lending strength to the youth movement.

Rahul Gandhi has already been raising the issue of paper leaks and the corresponding decline of the education system through party-organised programmes, which have evoked a positive response. However, talking to the streets to protest outside the Prime Minister's residence in high-security Lutyens' Delhi has given a new meaning to his youth-centric agenda. The youth, under the aegis of CJP, have perhaps unknowingly registered some unique achievements. First, they have successfully challenged the systemic contempt for collective empowerment or unity that has prevailed in recent years. When young people rise collectively and awaken society, it captures the imagination of everyone, including their adversaries. This can be seen and felt in the current phase of the CJP protests. Another significant aspect of the movement is that it has overcome societal, ideological, religious, regional and class divisions that one has witnessed in most such programmes held in Delhi from time to time. Above all, it has forged a cross-class and, more importantly, an urban-rural alliance. The mobilisation of crowds for such protest rallies has traditionally come from rural areas, with negligible participation from urban populations. That dynamic has changed drastically, as people from all regions and backgrounds have united to highlight the concerns of the youth.

The CJP-driven youth protests are having a profound, multi-layered impact on the Indian psyche by transforming systemic and economic despair into a unified generational identity. What began as an online meme responding to a controversial remark from the judiciary has evolved into a historic street mobilisation that is altering how young Indians view their relationship with power.

The writer is a policy analyst specialising in national and international affairs



Manipur’s fragile peace needs more than guns



SABIR NISHAT

Peace in Manipur remains painfully fragile. More than three years after ethnic violence erupted between the Meitei and Kuki-Zo communities in May 2023, the state continues to oscillate between cautious optimism and renewed bloodshed. Although the intensity of violence has diminished in recent months, recurring incidents of killings, militant attacks, and deepening ethnic mistrust reveal that the underlying conflict remains unresolved. Manipur today stands at a decisive moment where the choice is no longer simply between peace and violence, but between genuine reconciliation and the institutionalisation of permanent division.

The recent killing of two children after an explosive projectile struck a house in Bishnupur district starkly demonstrated how quickly tensions can resurface. The incident triggered widespread protests, clashes with security forces, curfews, and internet restrictions, reviving memories of the devastating violence that has scarred the state since 2023. An equally disturbing development followed with the abduction and murder of six Naga civilians in Kangpokpi district. Their deaths have widened the scope of the crisis beyond the original Meitei-Kuki confrontation. The Nagas, who had largely remained outside the direct conflict, now

find themselves increasingly drawn into an already volatile situation. The subsequent arrests may advance the criminal investigation, but they cannot erase the larger political implication-that Manipur now faces overlapping ethnic tensions involving three major communities, each carrying distinct historical grievances, territorial concerns, and political aspirations.

The roots of the conflict stretch back decades. Competing claims over land, identity, political representation, and administrative control have long shaped relations among Manipur's communities. The Meitei demand for Scheduled Tribe status, the Kuki-Zo demand for a separate administrative arrangement, and the long-standing Naga political aspirations have created overlapping anxieties that successive governments failed to address effectively. The violence of 2023 merely exposed these unresolved contradictions with unprecedented brutality.

Its human cost has been immense. Around 260 people have lost their lives, while more than 60,000 were displaced from their homes. Entire neighbourhoods that once reflected Manipur's diversity have become ethnically segregated, with heavily guarded buffer zones separating communities that previously lived side by side. Every passing month of separation makes reconciliation more difficult, allowing mistrust to harden into permanence.

Equally damaging has been the erosion of confidence in public institutions. The previous administration faced sustained criticism over allegations of partisan governance and its handling of the violence. Whatever the eventual verdict on individ-



ual allegations, public perception itself weakened faith in the state's neutrality. President's Rule temporarily filled the political vacuum before the new government, led by Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh, assumed office in February 2026.

The new administration has attempted to signal a departure from the past. Its emphasis on dialogue and equal engagement with all communities, including the Chief Minister's symbolic visit to Kuki-majority Churachandpur, represents an important political gesture. In a state where communication between communities had virtually collapsed, even symbolic outreach carries significance.

Thousands of firearms looted from police armouries during the initial phase of the conflict continue to circulate despite sustained recovery efforts. There are, however, encouraging signs. The surrender of dozens of cadres belonging to the banned Kangleipak Communist Party (People's War

Group), along with the surrender of arms and ammunition, suggests that sustained security pressure, combined with rehabilitation, can persuade militants to return to the democratic mainstream. Such developments provide hope, but they cannot be mistaken for a comprehensive solution.

Perhaps the greatest obstacle to lasting peace is the enormous justice deficit. The Supreme Court's recent concern over the slow pace of investigations into nearly 3,000 cases arising from the 2023 violence highlights the scale of the challenge. Investigations have progressed in only a small fraction of these cases, leaving victims waiting years for accountability. Justice delayed in such circumstances does not merely prolong suffering; it reinforces perceptions that the state is either unwilling or unable to protect its citizens impartially.

For reconciliation to succeed, every community must be confident that crimes-including murder, arson, sexual violence, abduction, and intimidation-will be investigated without regard to the identity of either the victim or the perpetrator.

The Centre, too, has an indispensable role. Manipur's crisis has outgrown the limits of an ordinary law-and-order problem. A structured political dialogue involving Meitei, Kuki-Zo, and Naga representatives must become a sustained institutional process rather than an ad hoc response to every fresh outbreak of violence. Civil society organisations should all be integrated into a broader framework of reconciliation. Peace negotiated solely at the political level cannot endure unless communities themselves begin rebuilding trust. Rehabilitation of displaced families must also

become a central priority. Peace cannot be measured solely by declining casualty figures while thousands remain unable to return home. Safe resettlement, reconstruction of destroyed homes, restoration of livelihoods, reopening of schools, and revival of economic activity are equally important indicators of genuine normalcy. Manipur's strategic location along the India-Myanmar border further elevates the importance of stability. Persistent unrest not only strengthens insurgent networks and facilitates cross-border movement of weapons but also threatens India's broader security interests and its Act East Policy. Manipur's tragedy is that every community carries genuine grievances, while every new act of violence creates another generation of victims. Breaking this cycle requires far more than military deployments or temporary ceasefires. It demands a comprehensive strategy combining impartial security operations, timely justice, political dialogue, rehabilitation, and genuine reconciliation. The recent surrender of militants, renewed political engagement, and judicial scrutiny of delayed investigations offer reasons for cautious optimism. Yet these positive developments remain overshadowed by recurring violence and persistent mistrust. Lasting peace will not be achieved until displaced families return home without fear, communities interact freely across ethnic lines, victims receive justice regardless of identity, and citizens once again trust the state more than armed groups.

The writer is the Deputy Director, Assam Information Centre, New Delhi

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Order Order

SC to MEA: Trace missing Indian seafarer after Black Sea attack



The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Ministry of External Affairs to use its diplomatic channel and trace a seafarer missing after his cargo ship was struck by drones on July 25 in the Black Sea.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana asked Solicitor General Tushar Mehta to seek instruction from the Indian Embassy in Ukraine and Embassy of India, Bucharest, Romania and enquire about the whereabouts of Deepak Kumar Gupta, who was onboard cargo ship, MV AGN Ragnar.

The matter is listed for hearing on Friday.

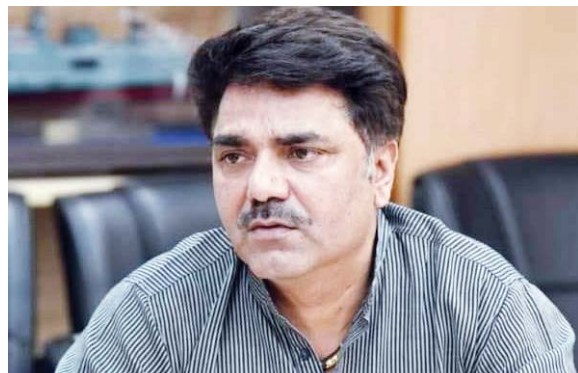
The top court was hearing a plea by Sandeep Kumar Gupta, elder brother of the missing seafarer, seeking directions to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) to coordinate with Indian embassies in Ukraine and Romania to undertake search and rescue operations.

The plea was filed by Gupta after his family's persistent requests to the Union of India and Indian embassies in the two countries went unheard.

The plea contended that the family wrote to the MEA and the Indian embassies in the two countries between July 26 and July 30 but the representations did not evoke any response or any positive assurance.

The 22-year-old seafarer went missing after a merchant vessel carrying Indian crew members came under attack near Ukraine's Odesa port. (PTI)

Delhi HC refuses bail to ex-MLA Naresh Balyan in MCOCA case



The Delhi High Court on Monday refused to grant bail to former AAP MLA Naresh Balyan in a case under the stringent law against organised crime.

"We are dismissing it," Justice Manoj Jain said while pronouncing the verdict on Balyan's bail plea.

The ex-lawmaker was arrested in the case under the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA) on December 4, 2024, the same day a trial court granted him bail in an alleged extortion case.

Seeking bail, he had contended that there was "no shred of evidence" against him and the case against him was "completely frivolous".

Balyan is accused of being a "facilitator" in an organised crime syndicate.

On January 15, 2025, a trial court had denied bail to Balyan in the case.

The prosecutor had then cited 16 FIRs lodged against the alleged syndicate members in various parts of Delhi, claiming the syndicate had created havoc in society and amassed huge illegal wealth. (PTI)

SC agrees to examine PIL seeking an alternative to Jantar Mantar as protest venue

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to examine a PIL contending that the Jantar Mantar in the heart of the national capital was no longer a suitable venue for protests as they cause inconvenience to local residents and disrupt essential services.

A bench comprising Chief Justice and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana issued notices to the Centre and others on the plea filed by Satish Chand Kaushik. It asked Solicitor General Tushar Mehta to obtain instructions from the authorities on the issues raised.

The petition seeks an alternative arrangement for holding demonstrations, saying protests at Jantar Mantar create difficulties for local residents and disrupt the supply of essential goods and medical services.



During the hearing, the CJI said that the petition raised concerns relating to access and movement in the area.

"It has been stated in the plea that Jantar Mantar is not a proper site anymore for such protests due to ingress and egress issues. Supply of medical essentials etc. I think this is important... Please take instructions, Mr Solicitor. Issue notice and list this separately," the CJI said.

During the proceedings, the counsel for the petitioner also referred to a pro-



Ensure encroachment-free walking space on all roads: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday directed the Centre to ensure that wherever there is a road, there is a properly demarcated, encroachment-free space for pedestrians.

A bench of Justices P S Narasimha and Alok Aradhe asked Additional Solicitor General KM Nararaj, appearing for the Centre, to instruct the authorities concerned to make sure that the space meant for walking is not encroached upon and is properly separated from motor vehicle lanes.

"Without any big investment and construction, just



ensure that proper demarcation is done of walkers' space. Wherever there is a road, there should be a walkers' space. Do it with a rope or anything

and ensure it is not encroached," the bench told Nataraj.

The bench gave him two weeks to instruct the authorities while emphasising

that pedestrians should have confidence that the space is meant for them and they can walk freely without any threat of moving vehicles.

The top court posted the matter for further hearing after two weeks.

On June 19, in a significant verdict, the top court had held that the right to walk on a demarcated footpath is a fundamental right.

It had held that this right shall have priority over motorised vehicles on demarcated paths and it forms part of the right to movement guaranteed under Article 19 (1) (d) and other fundamental rights including Article 21 (right to life and liberty).

SC asks Calcutta HC to hear Abhishek Banerjee's plea seeking nod to travel abroad for eye treatment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Calcutta High Court to take up within a week TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee's plea seeking permission to travel abroad for eye treatment.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was told by senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, appearing for Banerjee, that the plea seeks modification of the high court's order to allow the TMC MP to travel for medical purpose.

"Application for allowing to travel abroad for medical treatment is pending before the high court. It appears that no date has been fixed so far. We, therefore, request the high court to look into that application," the bench said.

Banerjee, in his plea



before the top court, has challenged the July 20 order passed by a single-judge bench of the high court.

The Calcutta High Court had earlier extended till October 6 Banerjee's interim protection from coercive action in a case related to alleged intimidatory statements he made during the West Bengal Assembly election campaign.

Granting relief, Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya of

the high court had directed Banerjee to cooperate with the probe and not travel abroad without the court's permission as previously ordered.

The judge extended the interim protection to Banerjee till October 6, or until further orders, whichever is earlier and said the TMC national general secretary's plea for modification of conditions for granting him interim protection will be

heard in August, but did not fix any particular date.

The Diamond Harbour MP had moved the application seeking permission to travel abroad for eye treatment.

Maintaining that the court was not inclined to allow the petitioner to travel abroad when the investigation was underway, Justice Bhattacharyya said there are several reputed eye clinics in Kolkata.

In an oral observation, Justice Bhattacharyya said the TMC MP should appear before the head of ophthalmology at the state-run SSKM Hospital, who will decide whether Banerjee's eye issue can be treated there.

The TMC leader had prayed for quashing the FIR over his alleged comments against leaders and workers of a rival party at a public meeting on April 27 in the run-up to the second phase of the West Bengal assembly polls.

Delhi HC seeks NIA stand on Aasiya Andrabi, 2 others against conviction in UAPA case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday sought the stand of the NIA on appeals by hard-line separatist Aasiya Andrabi and her two associates challenging their conviction for conspiring to wage war against India and being members of a terrorist organisation under stringent anti-terror law UAPA.

Andrabi (62), the founder of the all-women separatist group Dukhtaran-e-Millat (DeM) in 1987, and her close aides — Nahida Nasreen (58), and Sofi Fehmeeda (48) — were convicted by the special NIA court on January 14, which said the trio had orchestrated a systematic campaign to destabilise J-K.

On March 24, the trial court awarded life imprisonment to Andrabi, while Fehmeeda and Nasreen received a 30-year prison sentence.

On Monday, a bench of Justices Prathiba M Singh and Vikas Mahajan condoned the delay in filing the appeals against the trial court decision and said it would issue notice to the investigating agency in the matter.

The bench also gave time till September 15 to the National Investigation Agency (NIA) to reply to their pleas seeking suspension of sentence and listed the matter for hearing on October 6.

Andrabi and her two associates were formally charged with multiple offences under the stringent UAPA and the IPC in February 2021.

It was alleged that they plotted to wage war against the country, besides conspiring to carry out terror-related activities.

The trial court found them guilty of offences under UAPA sections 18 (punishment for conspiracy) and 38 (offence relating to membership of a



terrorist organisation).

It also convicted the three under IPC sections 153 A (promoting enmity between different groups), 153B (imputations, assertions prejudicial to national-integration), 121-A (conspiracy to wage war against Government of India), 120B (criminal conspiracy) and 505 (statements conducting to public mischief).

While sentencing the convicts, the trial judge said "no

remorse has been shown by any of the convicts in respect of their acts; rather it is submitted that they are proud of what they were doing and also that they will continue to do the same work".

Showing any leniency will amount to infusing a fresh lease of life and vigour in the spirit of convicts which aims at secession of an integral part of India, the trial judge had stated.



Disha Salian death case: Why did police not lodge FIR, asks HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court on Monday asked what stopped the police from investigating the death of former celebrity manager Disha Salian when her father raised suspicion about the circumstances in which she died in 2020.

A bench of Justices Bharti Dangre and Manjusha Deshpande also questioned how, according to the post-mortem report, the victim

Public prosecutor Shishir Hiray told the court that the case was treated as accidental death and inquiries were conducted twice, and both times the inference was that it was a case of suicide.

"This was supported by the statements given by the witnesses in the case," he said. The bench also questioned how, as per the post-mortem report, the victim did not suffer any injuries despite falling from a height. "If a person falls from a height of



showed no injuries despite falling from a height of 14 floors. Disha Salian died on June 8, 2020, after falling off the 14th floor of a residential building in Mumbai's Malad area. The city police had subsequently registered an Accidental Death Report (ADR). While the police, after conducting an inquiry, claimed that she died by suicide, her father Satish Salian filed a petition in HC last year, alleging his daughter was gang raped and murdered.

On Monday, when the plea came up for hearing before the HC bench, it sought to know from the police why no FIR had been lodged instead of treating the case as an accidental death inquiry.

"If somebody, in this case the victim's father, raises suspicion on the circumstances in which the death occurred, what stopped the police from registering an FIR and investigating it?" the HC asked.

14 floors, wouldn't there be any injuries to the body?" Justice Dangre asked.

Hiray said as per the photographs, there were head injuries to the victim's body.

Satish Salian's advocate Nilesch Ojha alleged that the initial photographs shown to him by the police indicated no such injuries.

"The police then fabricated these photos showing head injuries," he claimed.

The high court also rapped the police for not providing certain case-related documents, including the ADR, to the petitioner.

"As per the police, there is no FIR and hence no probe going on. When only an accidental death inquiry is being conducted and the police's inference is suicide, what is stopping them from giving certain innocuous documents to the petitioner?" the court asked. The bench posted the matter for further hearing on August 24.

Can some amount be released from TMC's frozen accounts for daily expenses: SC asks ED

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Enforcement Directorate (ED) whether some amount can be released from the frozen bank accounts of the Mamata Banerjee-led faction of the TMC in favour of a court-appointed special officer to meet the day-to-day expenses of the party.

Additional Solicitor General S V Raju, who was appearing for the ED, told a bench of Justices MM Sundresh and PB Varale that he would seek instructions on this.

The ED froze the three bank accounts, with balances totalling ₹440.42 crore, in connection with its money laundering probe arising out of an FIR lodged by the West Bengal Police over alleged dishonest financial transactions, unlawful collection of money and routing of suspected funds through certain party accounts.

The apex court bench was hearing a plea filed by the Mamata Banerjee-led faction of the All India Trinamool Congress challenging a July 20 order



of the Calcutta High Court.

The high court had refused interim relief to the Banerjee-led faction to operate three party bank accounts frozen by the ED.

During the hearing in the top court on Monday, senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for the petitioner, said the party can't even pay salary to its employees due to the frozen accounts.

In its order, the high court had

noted that other than the three accounts under "debit-freeze" by the ED, there were 36 other accounts in the party's name and an amount of ₹164 crore was lying there.

Referring to the high court's order, Sibal said, "What does the impugned order say - it says there are 36 separate accounts which are not seized. That is factually incorrect".

Raju opposed the submissions and said the investigation was underway and there was money laundering from those accounts.

The anti-money laundering Act "is not only for actual money laundering but for prevention of money laundering. We are preventing it," the law officer said.

When Raju said there was "continuous offence", Sibal countered the submissions and said how can the law officer make such an argument when the bank accounts were frozen. The bench was told that the high court had appointed a former judge of the Calcutta High Court as a special officer to facilitate the operation of the three bank accounts for incurring day-to-day expenditure to run the political party.

The top court suggested whether some amount could be released in favour of the special officer to meet the day-to-day expenses of the party. After Raju said he would seek instructions on this, the bench posted the matter for hearing on August 11. The Banerjee-led faction of the TMC had moved the high court challenging the initiation of ECIR (Enforcement Case Information Report), an equivalent of an FIR, proceedings by the ED.

According to the officials, the ED's preliminary investigation found that around Rs 160 crore was transferred from the TMC's bank accounts to Carewell Aviation India Pvt Ltd and its related entity between April 2023 and June 2026.

The company is alleged to have further routed ₹2.96 crore (between 2023 and 2026) to another newly incorporated entity.

It was claimed that a "significant" amount was transferred to this entity. Out of this, Rs 112 crore was used for purchasing an Embraer Legacy 600 business jet and an AgustaWestland 109SP helicopter, the officials had said.

Why India's AI mission is funding the wrong half

Compute take over 40 per cent of the IndiaAI budget. It is the one input the world was always going to make cheap for us



NISHANT SAHDEV

Think of building an artificial intelligence system as cooking a meal.

You need two things. A stove, and ingredients. The stove is computing power — the specialised chips, called GPUs, that do the arithmetic. The ingredients are data: the text, speech, images and records that the machine learns from. Without the stove, nothing cooks. Without ingredients, there is nothing to cook.

India's national AI programme, the IndiaAI Mission, was approved by the Cabinet in March 2024 with an outlay of ₹10,371.92 crore over five years. It has seven pillars. It has bought a great many stoves. More than 38,000 GPUs have been brought on board, and they are offered to Indian startups and researchers at a subsidised rate of about ₹65 an hour — a genuinely low price, and one that has already been used by Indian teams building their own models.

Now here is the number that should make us stop and think. An analysis by *Bharath Reddy of the Takshashila Institution*, using the pillar-wise split placed before the Lok Sabha in December 2024, puts compute subsidies at over 40 per cent of the mission's total allocation. The other pillars, he notes, do not appear to be getting much funding attention at all. The single largest share of India's AI money is going into the stove.

I want to make an argument that runs against almost everything written about this programme, including most of the praise and most of the criticism. The problem is not that the mission spends too little. The problem is what it spends on.

One ingredient gets cheaper on its own

Consider what has happened to the price of computing.

Chips get faster. Software gets more efficient. Competitors enter. Older equipment becomes cheap to rent. Every year, the amount of money needed to reach a given level of AI capability falls — and it falls sharply. This is not a prediction or an opinion. It is the most reliably observed trend

in the entire industry, and it has held for decades across computing generally.

Governments have a standard test for whether to subsidise something. Would this happen anyway, without public money?

If yes, the subsidy is mostly buying you a few years of speed.

Compute passes that test in the wrong direction. It is the one input in this business whose price is already collapsing without anyone's help. There is a global industry of enormous companies competing furiously to make it cheaper. They will do this whether or not India pays them.

Meanwhile the GPUs themselves age. A chip bought today is a depreciating asset. Within a few years it is outdated, within eight or so it is close to scrap. We are buying a perishable good whose replacement will cost less than the original.

The other ingredient is running out

Now look at the ingredients.

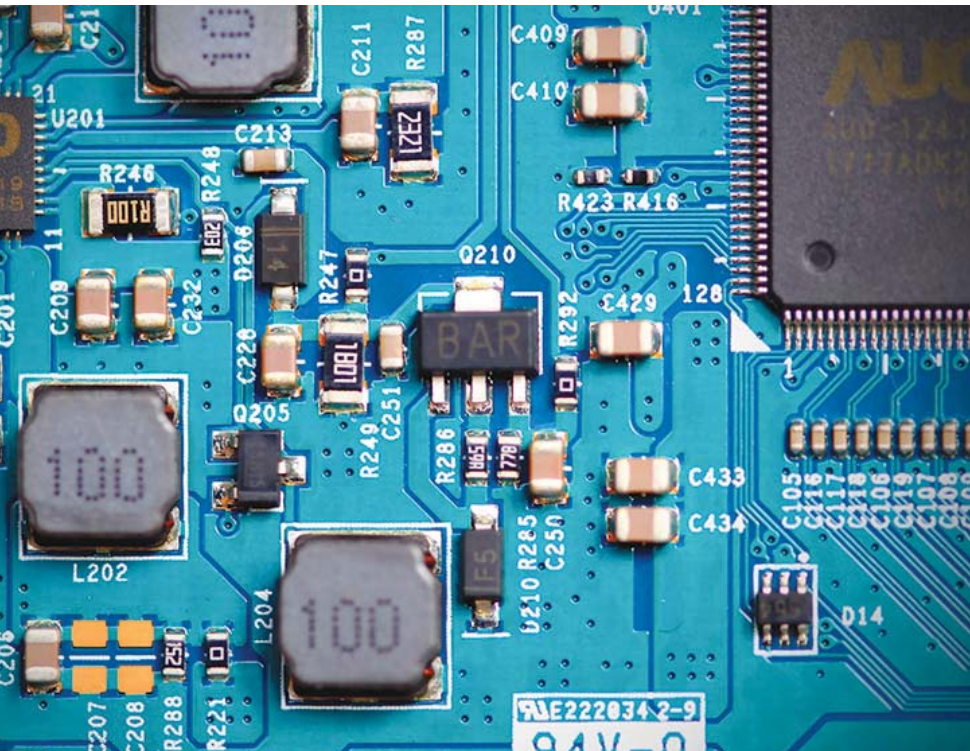
India's real advantage in this field was never chips. We do not make them. Our advantage is that we are the most linguistically rich large country on earth. Twenty-two scheduled languages. Hundreds more that are spoken but not scheduled. Dialects that change every few hundred kilometres. Centuries of legal, medical, agricultural and literary tradition in scripts most models have barely seen.

If an Indian AI is ever going to be better than a foreign one at anything, it will be here.

And this ingredient is not getting cheaper. It is getting scarcer, for three reasons, and each of them is a one-way door.

The first is the internet itself. The open web is now filling rapidly with text written by machines. That matters more than it sounds. When a model learns from text produced by other models, the unusual gets thinned out first — the rare word, the regional usage, the minority language, the local remedy known in one district. What survives is the average. So the value of scraping the web is falling at exactly the moment we are scaling up to scrape it. Human-written Indian text is becoming a smaller and smaller fraction of what is out there, and the honest way to describe this is that we are eating our seed corn.

The second is demography. A great deal of India's knowledge has never been written down at all. It lives in speech, in people who are



old, in villages where the young are switching to a bigger language. Every year some of that goes quietly out of existence. You cannot buy it back later. There is no price at which a language returns once its last fluent speakers are gone.

The third is legal. As data protection rules tighten worldwide - properly so - the cost and difficulty of assembling large collections of human material rises. What was free to gather in 2015 requires consent, contracts and compliance in 2026.

So: one input falls in price every year and will

keep falling without us. The other rises in price every year and is disappearing permanently.

We have put over 40 per cent of the mission behind the first.

What this means in practice

Let me be fair. The mission is not blind to data. It runs a datasets platform, AIKosh, meant to pool public and anonymised datasets so Indian builders do not have to scrape everything themselves. That is the right instinct, and it exists.

But instinct is not allocation. The compute pillar has the money and the headlines. The data work has neither. And the mission's yearly funding has itself been squeezed — last year's ₹2,000 crore budget saw actual utilisation nearer ₹800 crore, and the allocation for the coming year stands at around ₹1,000 crore. When the pot shrinks, the biggest line item defends itself. It is the small, slow, unglamorous work that gets postponed.

The rise of self-hosted AI: Global shift

As AI decentralises, organisations seek control, sovereignty, and efficiency beyond cloud dependence and centralised platforms



RAJESH SETH

A quiet but significant shift is underway in the world of Artificial Intelligence. After years of relying on large, cloud-based models controlled by a handful of global technology companies, businesses, Governments, and academic institutions are increasingly turning towards self-hosted Large Language Models (LLMs).

This transition is not merely technological. It is economic, strategic, and geopolitical. Concerns over data sovereignty, rising operational costs, and global supply constraints are pushing organisations to rethink where and how AI should be deployed.

For years, AI was largely accessed through the cloud. Organisations depended on powerful remote servers owned by global technology companies (like AWS, Microsoft Azure and Google Cloud). While this model made AI widely accessible, it also created a quiet but significant dependency. Today, that dependency is increasingly being questioned.

Why is the Shift Taking Place

Several forces are driving this transition towards self-hosted AI systems.

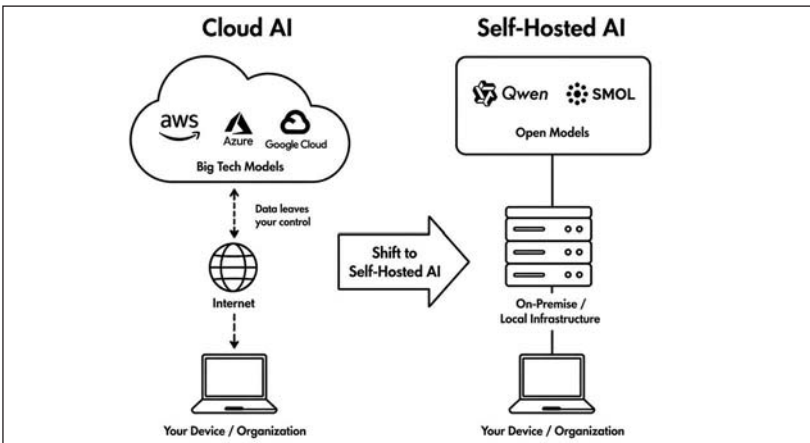
While cloud-based AI platforms initially appeared economical, their long-term usage costs, especially through API-based pricing, have steadily risen. For universities, startups and even mid-sized enterprises, these recurring expenses are becoming difficult to sustain. Running models locally, despite upfront investment, often proves more predictable and cost-efficient.

Privacy, control and data sovereignty are also becoming important. Sensitive sectors such as defence, finance, healthcare, governance, and education are increasingly uncomfortable with sending data to external servers, often located outside national boundaries. Self-hosted models allow organisations to keep their data within their own infrastructure, ensuring greater security.

Technology is Catching Up

Until recently, self-hosting LLMs was impractical. These systems demanded enormous computing power, specialised hardware, and deep technical expertise.

That reality is now changing rapidly. A new generation of models is emerging that is more efficient, modular, and adaptable. This shift is being enabled by a growing layer of open tools, shared models, and collaborative platforms. Platforms such as Hugging Face have made thousands of models accessible to developers, researchers, and organisa-



tions, turning complex AI systems into downloadable, customisable building blocks, accelerating the move from cloud dependence to self-hosted intelligence. Models like Alibaba's Qwen are demonstrating that high performance no longer requires exclusive access to hyperscale cloud infrastructure. At the same time, there is growing interest in smaller, more efficient models, often referred to as Small Language Models (SLMs), that can run on local servers or even high-end personal computers.

Closely related are advances in Vision-Language Models (VLMs), including compact variants called "Smol VLMs" which combine text and image understanding in lightweight formats. These models expand the scope of self-hosted AI beyond text, enabling document analysis, visual inspection, and multimodal applications.

The Role of Open Ecosystems

Unlike earlier phases of innovation dominated by proprietary systems, today's AI landscape is more collaborative and accessible. Model repositories, shared datasets, and open research have enabled even smaller organisations to experiment with and deploy advanced capabilities.

This shift is not merely technical but strategic. By reducing dependence on a few dominant platforms, open ecosystems foster a more competitive and innovative environment and allow countries like India to participate not just as users of AI, but as creators.

Of course, organisations must still invest in talent, infrastructure, and governance frameworks to use these tools effectively. In that sense, the barriers to entry may be lower, but the responsibilities of ownership remain.

India's Push for Sovereign AI

In India, this global shift is taking on a distinctly national character. The Government, through the IndiaAI Mission (led by MeitY), is actively supporting the

development of a sovereign and proprietary AI ecosystem. The goal is clear: reduce dependence on foreign platforms, ensure data sovereignty, and build systems that reflect India's unique linguistic and social realities.

Under this initiative, more than 20 indigenous foundational model proposals are being supported, including 12 LLMs and 8 SLMs. This represents one of the most ambitious national AI efforts globally.

Companies such as Sarvam AI have developed full-stack capabilities, including large conversational models, document-processing systems, and multilingual speech technologies.

Unlike Western models that prioritise English, Indian systems are being built to support all 22 scheduled languages. This linguistic depth is critical in India where language remains one of the biggest barriers to digital access.

Another defining feature of India's approach is its voice-first orientation. A large segment of the population prefers speaking over typing, especially in regional languages. As a result, AI systems are being optimised for low-latency voice interaction, making them more accessible and inclusive.

There is also a growing shift towards SLMs in India, driven by practical constraints. Limited access to high-end GPUs and the need for cost efficiency are encouraging organisations, especially in regulated sectors to adopt smaller, domain-specific models that can be deployed locally.

Importantly, these AI systems are being integrated with India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI), enabling applications in governance, agriculture, healthcare, and public service delivery. This integration has the potential to transform how citizens interact with the state.

The author is an alumnus of IIM Ahmedabad and Professor of Practice at IILM University, Gurugram with an interest in AI, Technology and Strategy

How cybersecurity is redefining and reshaping India's young minds rapidly?

'India is aiming to be the cybersecurity capital & hub of the globe'



DR T SENTHIL SIVA SUBRAMANIAN

Cyber domain is considered to be one of the world's prominent, interesting, inspiring, innovative and challenging coordinate systems in the current era of 5th / 6th industrial revolutions where time, speed, safety, security and scalability coordinates play a vital role in the protection systems. A nation's security is determined and diagnosed by the strength and capability of the Cyber Walls established by Cybersecurity, which India has attained peak milestones and supremacy over the past 12 years.

The launch of Digital India program and policy frameworks like DPDP-Digital Personal and Data Protection act, 2023 has boosted and pushed the Cybersecurity domain in our nation beyond limitless boundaries and created wide spectrum of skilling opportunities for young minds.

The best classical examples of India's high volume of data safeguarded are the successful UPI (Unified Payment Interface) supported by National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) across the nation and global countries and Aadhaar under the UIDAI, Unique Identification Authority of India. These are the distinguished pillars of Digital Public Infrastructure which forms the DNA and strong testament for our country's success pathway in Cybersecurity.

India has adopted the best practices of protecting, preserved the data and took proactive action against the cyber-crimes through an effective and strong comprehensive cyber mechanisms

Cybersecurity - NCERT Guided safety for Youth

India has been forefront in keeping cybersecurity of the young children as highest priority. In view of this it took several initiatives in the form of awareness program, inducting safety aspects in the academic curriculum to protect the school going children to be aware of cyber-attacks. This enables the safe use of digital education platforms. One of the key initiatives outlined under the DPDP act, 2023 for the social platforms which has to comply with taking the parental consent before admitting the personal data of children while using digital platforms. This ensures safety and security of the young students.

Central Institute of Educational Technology, a constituent of NCERT has facilitated young students and teachers



in publishing several digital hand-outs like Cyber world for both students and faculty members, Cyber Safety guidelines for students, parents, teachers that will allows the safe usage of digital platforms.

India's Cyberspace — A Viksit Case study

Ministry of Home affairs, Government of India has been playing a key role in launching several robust initiatives that bring ruggedness and rationalise the access of data through cyber protection walls which can hardly be intruded by cyber attackers.

India's cyber system is sailing through strong protective covering strategies like recently the launch of Cyber Crime Mitigation Centre which is first of its kind that caters to the need of different stakeholders in fintech, telecom service providers, IT domain which includes our emerging data centre, supercomputing infrastructures, and most importantly this could also be extended to the growing and emerging India's Space, Nuclear and Defence sectors.

Cybersecurity - An emerging domain to develop young talents

Cybersecurity — India's powerhouse has sown the seed in both academics and research thereby building a strong skilling opportunities for today's youth. The opportunities could be in space, nuclear, defence, agriculture, smart cities, automotive, manufacturing, Indian railways like the recent bullet train, quantum technologies like quantum cryptography and recently the domain of digital forensics.

● **Defence Research and Development Organisation [DRDO]:** The technology cluster wings of DRDO like SAG-Scientific Analysis Group, PXE-Proof and Experimental Evaluation, CAIR-Centre for Artificial Intelligence & Robotics are working on advanced security solutions-Block chain security, application security, cryptology like Cyber

There is a further irony worth naming. Bhashini, the Government's own language platform, covering all 22 scheduled languages, reportedly handled around 2.5 billion API calls in 2026. Every one of those calls is a human being bringing an Indian-language sentence to a machine. That is one of the largest live streams of Indian-language interaction anywhere in the world. It is being run as a service. Its most durable value is as a record.

What to do instead

I am not arguing that India should stop subsidising compute. Researchers need machines, and a startup that cannot afford a GPU cannot begin.

I am arguing about the marginal rupee — the next one we spend. Send it to the ingredient that will not be there later.

That means paying people to record: fieldwork in languages with no written corpus, with consent, with payment, with the recordings held publicly. It means digitising the archives we already own — court records, land records, agricultural extension notes, All India Radio's tapes, university theses — which cost nothing to create and are rotting for want of scanning. It means settling, clearly and fairly, who owns the data trail that public platforms generate and under what consent it may be used. And it means treating all of this as a national reserve, in the way we treat foodgrain or foreign exchange: a stock we build in good years because it cannot be conjured in bad ones.

None of this requires frontier technology. It requires clerks, microphones, scanners, lawyers and patience. It is the least exciting proposal in Indian technology policy, and that is precisely why nobody is making it.

Here is the sentence I would like to leave with the reader. A GPU bought in 2026 will be scrap by the middle of the next decade. A recording of an eighty-year-old speaking her mother tongue in 2026 will be beyond price in 2086, and there will be no way to make another one.

We are spending our largest share on the thing the world was going to hand us cheaply, and leaving to chance the one thing only India could ever have collected.

The author is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems



organisation has been creating several value-added opportunities for students and faculty

members in the field of quantum cryptography, IoT security, critical infrastructure and industrial security, privacy and data protection, cryptology and computing. The organisation provides summer internship, and short-term program in different field of cybersecurity for students.

● **C-DOT (Centre of Development of Telematics):** A Research and Development organisation wing of national and global importance working on optical technology, post quantum cryptography, security solutions. It offers diversified internship in the field of security solutions for students.

● The recent introduction of Bachelor of Technology program in Cybersecurity by **Indian Institute of Technology, IIT Kanpur** and **Indian Institute of Technology, IIT Madras** has brought a paradigm shift in the admission process which has unique selection mechanisms against the traditional selection process especially through the hackathons, solving real-time problems by applying critical thinking. This has empowered and enabled young talents to explore the ample opportunities available in the field of Cybersecurity. The program is first of its kind that the students will learn both theory and lab sessions initially for first 02 years followed by the hands-on experiential learning through internship at the Government organisation to work on real-world problem statements.

Please read the complete article online at dailypioneer.com

The author is an Assistant Professor, School of Cybersecurity and Digital Forensics, Uttar Pradesh State Institute of Forensic Science, Lucknow

Iran denies US talks, says Strait of Hormuz discussions only with Oman

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Iran on Monday categorically denied reports of direct or indirect negotiations with the United States, asserting that its current diplomatic engagement is limited to bilateral discussions with neighbouring Oman on ensuring the safe passage of shipping through the Strait of Hormuz.

Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei dismissed claims of active dialogue between Tehran and Washington, saying there are no plans to exchange delegations with the US or any other country at present.

“We do not have any negotiations with the United States at the moment,” Baghaei told reporters. “We are not going to host a delegation or be guests of a country during these days.”

According to Iran's Fars News Agency, Baghaei clarified that the ongoing talks with Oman are focused exclusively on establishing a temporary maritime route to facilitate safe navigation through the strategically important Strait of Hormuz.

He said the discussions are technical in nature and confined to maritime traffic management between the two coastal nations. While an understanding with Muscat on a temporary shipping lane



Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei

is an essential step, it alone would not be sufficient to fully restore normal operations in the waterway.

Baghaei attributed the continued disruption in the Strait of Hormuz to what he described as ongoing US military operations and Washington's naval blockade against Iran initiated earlier this year.

He maintained that no broader change in the status of the waterway would be possible as long as the United States continued its military presence and what he termed an “aggressive posture” in the region.

“Negotiations are with Oman, focused on reaching an understanding on a route that would ensure the safe passage of shipping through the Strait of Hormuz,” Baghaei said. “Therefore, these negotiations are bilateral between two coastal governments. What happens next must be decided upon.”

Commenting on the regional security situation, Baghaei argued that the US military presence in the Persian Gulf has contributed to growing instability, affecting the security of all neighbouring countries. “The fact that all countries in the region

consider themselves stakeholders in the future of the region is a positive thing,” he said. “America's war against the Islamic Republic of Iran is not just a war against one country; it is a war against the entire region and against the security of all countries in the region.”

While welcoming diplomatic efforts by regional governments to ease tensions, Baghaei stressed that Iran's own military capabilities remained the country's primary means of deterrence.

“We value these efforts, but experience has shown us that what can ultimately deter the enemy from escalating its actions against Iran is nothing but Iran's authority and deterrent power,” he said. Baghaei's remarks came after US President Donald Trump said negotiations with Iran, expected to be conducted through intermediaries, were scheduled to begin on Monday.

Speaking to reporters aboard Air Force One, Donald Trump said diplomatic channels involving Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, Qatar and Iran had remained active.

He also claimed that those diplomatic efforts had prompted him to call off what he described as a “massive attack” that had been planned for Friday.

Bangladesh urges India to stop Hasina's political activities

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Ahead of former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina's reported virtual programme on August 5, Bangladesh on Monday urged India to ensure that its territory is not used for political activities or statements that could undermine stability in Bangladesh.

The message was conveyed by Prime Minister's Foreign Affairs Adviser Humaiun Kobir during a meeting with newly appointed Indian High Commissioner to Bangladesh Dinesh Trivedi at the Prime Minister's Office in Tejgaon, according to Bangladesh's Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

Kobir said Dhaka expected New Delhi's cooperation in ensuring that “any person, including fugitive Sheikh Hasina,” is not allowed to use Indian territory to make political statements or undertake activities aimed at creating instability in Bangladesh. He added that such actions could adversely affect the positive trajectory of bilateral ties. Responding to the concerns, the Indian



High Commissioner assured that the matter would receive due consideration and that necessary inquiries would be made. The issue gained prominence amid reports in Indian media that Hasina is scheduled to make her first public appearance from India since leaving Bangladesh two years ago following a massive student-led protest.

According to multiple reports, she is expected to address a virtual event organised by the Foreign Correspondents' Club of South Asia (FCC South Asia) in New Delhi on August 5. The Bangladesh Foreign Ministry

said Hasina's proposed programme also figured in the discussions between the two sides. Both countries underscored the importance of maintaining regular dialogue and constructive engagement, expressing confidence that outstanding issues could be addressed through mutual trust and sustained discussions. The meeting also reviewed various aspects of Bangladesh-India bilateral relations and other issues of shared interest.

Both sides reiterated their commitment to strengthening ties based on mutual respect, trust and common interests. In a separate statement, the Indian High Commission in Dhaka said the discussions focused on enhancing people-centric cooperation between the two neighbours on the basis of mutual interest and mutual benefit.

The High Commissioner reaffirmed India's commitment to working constructively with the Government of Bangladesh to advance the developmental aspirations of the people of both countries.

Sudanese army drone strike kills 35

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Cairo

At least 35 people were killed in a Sudanese army drone strike on a civil court in Sudan's Darfur region, a rights group said.

Emergency Lawyers, an independent group documenting atrocities in Sudan, said on Sunday afternoon drones targeted the headquarters of the civil court in Al-Zawiya Gara village in North Darfur State, “a civilian facility that plays a judicial and social role in the region.” “Directing attacks against civilians and civilian objects constitutes a grave violation of international humanitarian law,” said the group in a statement, and demanded an investigation.

Sudan plunged into all-out war in April 2023, between the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces and the Sudanese military,



leaving at least 59,000 people killed, according to Armed Conflict Location & Event Data, a conflict monitoring group. Aid groups say the figure is an undercount and the true number could be many times higher.

Drone warfare has become a signature in the country's battle, with both sides carrying out strikes. It is now the leading cause of death in Sudan, according to the United Nations, accounting for 80 per cent of civilian deaths during the first four months of 2026.



GIC HOUSING FINANCE LTD.

CORPORATE OFFICE / HEAD OFFICE : GICHFL, National Insurance Building 6th Floor, 14, Jamsheedi Tata Road, Churchgate, Mumbai – 400020. Tel No- 022-43041900. Email: investors@gichf.com, corporate@gichf.com Website : www.gichfindia.com

● **GURGAON BRANCH AREA OFFICE :** Unit 3001-3002, MGF Metropolis Mall, M.G. Road , Gurgaon, Haryana-122002. Email : gurgaon@gichfindia.com Office Tel : Ph. 0124-4008202, 0124-4008280, 0124-4008208. Authorized Officer: Mr. Nitesh Kumar : 9876264551

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

E-AUCTION DATE : 07-09-2026 / Last Date for Bid Submission : 05-09-2026

WHEREAS the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of GIC Housing Finance Ltd. (GICHFL), under Securitization & Reconstructions of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 & in exercise of powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 had issued Demand Notice to following Borrowers/Mortgagors calling upon them to repay the outstanding due amount mentioned in the said notices. However, The Borrower/Mortgagor having failed to repay the said due amount, the undersigned has taken **PHYSICAL POSSESSION** of the following property in exercise of powers conferred U/s 13(4) and U/s 14 of the said Act read with the Rule 8 of the said Rules.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co Borrower/ Guarantor Name / Loan File No/ Branch Name	Property Address/ Property Area (built up in Sq Ft)	Demand Notice Issued Date	Date of Physical Possession	Total outstanding as on 30.07.2026 (Incl.POS, interest and other charges) (In Rupees)	Reserve Price (In Rupees)
1	UP0510610001584 DHARMENDRA KUMAR JHA	Khasra No. 266, Monalisa Residency, Flat No. S-1 1st Floor (Front Side Lig), M-1, Bhagat Enclave, Bishnoli, Dadri, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh Built Up Area: 400 Sq Ft	12-07-2021	08-04-2026	₹ 17,57,699/-	₹ 6,72,000/-
2	UP0510610001432 AMIT PRAKASH	Khasra No. 266, Monalisa Residency, Flat No. F-1 1st Floor (Front Side), M-1, Bhagat Enclave, Bishnoli, Dadri, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh, Built Up Area: 400 Sq Ft	28-06-2021	08-04-2026	₹ 16,14,803/-	₹ 6,08,000/-
3	DL0510610005417 AMIT TIWARI KUMAR / NEERU TIWARI	Khasra No. 10/1, Entire Upper Ground Floor, Without Roof Rights, Plot No- B 100 , Block B, Mansa Ram Park, Uttam Nagar, Delhi, Built Up Area: 765 Sq Ft	24-04-2025	27-04-2026	₹ 21,43,317/-	₹ 29,17,120/-
4	HR0510610006010 MITHUN DUTTA / APARNA DUTTA	* Flat No: 304, 3Rd Floor , Backside, Without Roof Rights, Plot No: 3210/31, Khewat/Khata No-1608/2265, Salam Khewat Kita No.25 & Salam Khewat Kita 1610/2280 S/O (11-16), Vishnu Garden Rajender Park , Ward 1, Gurgaon, Haryana Built Up Area: 540 Sq Ft	26-03-2024	03-12-2025	₹ 35,77,286/-	₹ 17,28,000/-

DATE OF E-AUCTION & TIME : 07-09-2026 at the Web-Portal (www.auctionbazaar.com) from 3.00 PM TO 04:00 PM, with unlimited extensions of 5 minutes each.

Last date of submission of Tender/Sealed Bid in the prescribed tender form along with EMD & KYC either through online mode or at the above mentioned GICH Office at 05-09-2026 before 5.00 PM.

Further to this **PUBLIC NOTICE** for E-Auction Sale of the above said Assets / properties (in terms and conditions of the SARFAESI, Act 2002 and rules thereunder) GICHFL invites **OFFERS EITHER** in sealed cover/s or in Online mode to purchase the said properties on **“AS IS WHERE IS BASIS”** and **“AS IS WHAT IS BASIS”**.

TERMS & CONDITIONS OF THE AUCTION SALE ARE AS FOLLOWS:-

- E-Auction is being held on ‘As is where is Basis’, ‘As is what is Basis’, ‘Whatever there is’ And ‘Without Any Recourse Basis’, and will be conducted “Online”. The E-Auction will be conducted through GICHF approved Euction service provider “ARCA EMART PRIVATE LIMITED”
- The intending bidders should register their names at portal www.auctionbazaar.com/ and get their user-id and password free of cost. Prospective bidders may avail online training on E-Auction from the service provider ARCA EMART PRIVATE LIMITED, AuctionBazaar.com, 6-3-1090/1/1, II Floor, Part 2B, Uma Hyderabad House Rajbhavan Road, Somajiguda, Hyderabad – 500082 Telangana, India. Auction Bazaar Helpline: 83709 69696 / 79970 43999 Email ID : Email IDs: contact@auctionbazaar.com / support@auctionbazaar.com, Property Enquiries CONTACT DETAILS : NITESH KUMAR : 9876264551
- The E-auction Sale is subject to the conditions prescribed in the SARFAESI Act/Rules 2002 and the terms and conditions mentioned hereunder/website also subject to conditions in the offer/bid documents to be submitted by the intending/participating bidders.
- Every bidder is required to have his/her own email address in order to participate in the online E-auction.
- Once Intending Bidder** formally registers as a qualified tenderer before authorized officer of GICHFL, will have to express his/her interest to participate through the E-auction bidding platform, by submitting document. It shall be the tenderer's/online bidder's sole responsibility to procure his/her login ID and password from the E-auction service provider.
- The aforesaid properties shall not be sold below the reserve price mentioned above.
- Intending bidders are required to deposit Earnest Money Deposit/s (EMD) @ 10% of the aforesaid respective reserve prices, by way of DD/RTGS/ NEFT favouring GIC Housing Finance Ltd. Bank details are as follows: **Bank Name: UNION BANK OF INDIA, A/c No: 0051110100000039 - A/c Name: GIC HOUSING FINANCE LTD AUCTION A/C, Branch Name : LCB, FORT Address : UBI, 239 BACKBAY RECLAMATIO NARIMAN POINT MUMBAI MAHARASHTRA PINCODE 400021. IFSC Code - UBIN00800511.**
- The said Deposit/s shall be adjusted in the case of successful bidder/s, otherwise refunded. The said earnest money deposit/s will not carry any interest.
- The offer/s along with the aforesaid Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) can be submitted either “online” through the portal www.auctionbazaar.com/ along with the EMD and scanned copy of KYC documents including PAN Card & address proof, to the service provider or through submitting sealed cover comprising bid form, EMD and KYC documents and it should reach the respective branch offices of GIC Housing Finance Ltd., mentioned above on or before EMD Submission due date.
- That, after opening the tenders, the intending bidders who have submitted their bids for not less than the reserve price will be given an opportunity at the sole discretion of the Authorized Officer to increase the bidding amount.
- The successful bidder/s shall deposit 25% of the amount of sale price, adjusting the EMD paid already, immediately on acceptance of offer by the Authorized officer in respect of the sale, failing which the earnest money deposited shall be forfeited. The balance 75% of the sale price is payable within 15 days from the date of confirmation of the sale solely at the discretion of the Authorized Officer. In case of failure to deposit the balance amount within the prescribed period, the amount deposited shall be forfeited. The Authorized Officer shall not be required to give any further notice of forfeiture to the successful bidder.
- Bidders are bound by the principle of “caveat emptor” (Buyer Beware) and advised to conduct their own due diligence to find any encumbrances, statutory liabilities, arrears of property tax, Income Tax, Excise Duty, Labour Dues, electricity and maintenance dues etc., of the firm or Secured Asset. The Successful bidders shall have to bear all outgoing i.e., municipal taxes, maintenance/society charges, electricity charges, water charges, stamp duty, registration charges, (if applicable), if any and all other incidentals charges, cost including all outgoing relating to the respective properties other than the sale price....
- The successful bidder should bear the charges/fees payable on sale certificate, such as registration fees, stamp duty, taxes, or any other duties payable for getting the secured asset transferred in his/her name.
- The Sale Certificate will be issued only in the name of the successful bidder and only after receipt of the entire /sale price.
- The notice is hereby given to the Borrowers/s, Mortgagor/s and Guarantor/s that they can bring the intending buyer/purchaser for purchasing the properties mentioned above, as per the terms and Conditions of the EAuction Sale.
- Inspection of the above said properties can be given on request and as per convenience of Authorized Officer.
- The Authorized Officer is not bound to accept the highest offer or any or all offers and reserves the right to accept or reject any or all the tenders without assigning any reason thereof.
- GICHFL is not responsible for any liability whatsoever pending upon the properties as mentioned above. The property shall be auctioned on **“As is where is”, “As is what is”, “Whatever there is” and without any recourse basis.**
- In case the borrowers/mortgagor approaches GICHFL before confirmation of sale, offering contractual dues + expenses + interest @ 15 % from date of proclamation of sale + 5 % of the purchase money (in case after sale which is to be paid to successful bidder) and requests for cancellation of the sale, GICHFL shall accept the amount and hand over the possession to mortgagor
- The highest bidder has to pay 25% (inclusive of earnest money deposited) of the bid amount in terms of the sale notice immediately and the balance 75% of the bid amount is payable in 15 days or such other extended period as agreed upon between the parties (AO and the successful bidder). However, Authorized Office is to be confirmed sale certificate after expiry of 30 days from the date of sale and in no case the sale is to be confirmed before expiry of 30 days from the date of sale. Only after receipt of full payment, sale to be confirmed and the sale certificate to be issued.
- Minimum Bid increment value is Rs.10,000/-**

STATUTORY 30 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002

For detailed terms and Conditions of the sale and full description of the properties please refer to the website of approved e-auction service provider ARCA EMART PRIVATE LIMITED and website www.auctionbazaar.com

For GIC Housing Finance Ltd.

Sd/-

Authorised Officer

Date : 04.08.2026

Place : GURGAON



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CORRIGENDUM

Please refer to the advertisement of “E-Auction Sale Notice” pertaining to SI. No.1 to SI. No.3, M/s S S ENTERPRISES, Narela Branch (scheduled to be held on 25.08.2026) published in this newspaper on 03.08.2026. In the “Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (in Rupees)” column, the Amount Dues for SI. No.1 to SI. No.3 shall be read as “Rs. 144.55 Lakh”.

All other details shall remain unchanged. Sd/- Authorised Officer, Central Bank of India

PUBLIC NOTICE

A notice of intended marriage has been received from Mr. Rahul Kumar S/o Late Mr. Raj Bihari Lal R/o Futte, Gateway Block-B2/B3, Flat No. 615, Plot No. 10, Behind Spectrum Mall, Sector-75 Noida, Gautambudh Nagar, (U.P.) and Mrs. Swati Devi D/o Late Mr. Radhe Shyam Kushwahia R/o BE-400, 1st Floor, Near Mohan Mandir/Durga Mandir, Gali No.-7, Hari Nagar, New Delhi-110064 in the office of the undersigned, any person interested therein, may file objections to it on any day upto 29-08-2026 in The office of The undersigned.

Deputy Collector/ 1/c City Magistrate/ Marriage Officer Noida Gautam Budh Nagar

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client (i.e. HDFC Bank Ltd.) that Mr. Sunesh Goyal is claiming to be the owner of Entire Second Floor, Without Roof/ Terrace Rights, of Property No. 294, admeasuring 306.29 Sq. Yds. Situated In The Layout Plot Of Bhimesh CHRS Ltd. known As Bhura Enclave, Paschim Vihar New Delhi-110087, said Property Deed Dated 12.10.2021 (vide Doc. No. 6280) executed by Mrs. Jaya Garg, Mr. Vijay Kumar Kapoor & S. Subhinder Singh Mann in favour of Mr. Sunesh Goyal & Mrs. Poonam Goyal & Sale Deed Dated 28.03.2025 (vide Doc. No. Doc. No. 2025/61/1954) executed by Mrs. Poonam Goyal in favour of Mr. Sunesh Goyal. All persons are hereby informed that above mentioned Owner (through M/s Ex Kay Stampings) wants to mortgage the said property & intends to obtain loan from our client (i.e. HDFC Bank Ltd.) against the said property, if anybody has any objections upon the ownership of above owner over the said property, its mortgage/litigation, and any other objection, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present.

Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants) 200, Ind Ftr. 23, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, New Delhi-15 Regd. In Andhra Pradesh Ph: 011-41115257-28



UNITY SMALL FINANCE BANK LIMITED

5th Floor, Tower 1, Seawoods Grand Central, Sec-40, Seawoods, above Seawoods Darave Railway Station, Navi Mumbai – 400 706

DEMAND NOTICE

UNDER THE PROVISIONS OF THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 (“the Act”) AND THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002 (“the Rules”) The undersigned being the authorized officer of Unity Small Finance Bank Limited under the Act and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13 (12) of the Act read with the Rule 3, issued Demand Notice(s) under Section 13(2) of the Act, calling upon the following borrower(s) to repay the amount mentioned in the respective notice(s) within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The undersigned reasonably believes that borrower(s) is/are avoiding the service of the demand notice(s), therefore the service of notice is being effected by affixation and publication as per Rules. The contents of demand notice(s) are extracted herein below:

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower (s)	Demand Notice Date & Amount	Description of secured assets (Immovable Property)
1	Loan A/C. No(S). : USFBDDELLOAN000005017092 1. Kamlesh S. D/o. Shompal 2. Vikas S. S/o. Shripal Singh 3. Babita R. D/o. Rajpal Add For Sr. No. 1 : Sawalatpuri Khedi, Bagpat, Up-250101. Add For Sr. No. 2 : Salawatpur Khedi, Shiv Mandir, Bagpat, Up-250101 Add For Sr. No. 3 : Salawatpur Khedi, Khakra, Bagpat, Khedi, Bagpat, Up-250101.	16.06.2026 Rs. 5,57,695/- (Rs. Five Lakh Fifty Seven Thousand Six Hundred Five Only) As On 15.05.2026 NPA Date : 05.05.2026	All Piece And Parcel Property Bearing:- All That Piece And Parcel Of Non Agriculture Land Area Measuring 0.082 Hectare, Out Of Khasra No. 127, Khata No. 283, Situated In Waka Salawatpur Khedi, Tehsil & Dist Bagpat, Up- 250615. 0.082 Hectare Surrounded By Boundaries :- North : Part Of Plot, East : Other Property, South : Plot Of Jogender, West : 15 Feet Gali
2	Loan A/C. No(S). : USFBDELMSME000006542 & USFBDDELLOAN000000515572 1. Late Sundar Sharma, S/o. Tek Chand Sharma (Through Its All Known/Unknown Legal Hirer) 2. Mrs. Savita K. W/o. Late Sundar Sharma Add For Sr. No. 1 : Luhari, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Near Toll Tax, Dadri Uttar Pradesh 203207. Add For Sr. No. 1 & 2 : Gata No. 88, Village- Tillegampur, Sikandrabad Bulandshahr, Uttar Pradesh – 203206. Add For Sr. No. 2 : House No 292, Luhari, 139 Basantpur Bangar, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Near Toll Tax, Dadri Uttar Pradesh 203207.	29.06.2026 Rs. 1,13,64,038.60 (Rs. One Crore Thirteen Lakhs Sixty-Four Thousand Thirty-Eight And Sixty Paise Only) As On 29.06.2026 NPA Date : 02.11.2025	All The Piece And Parcel Of Immovable Property Being Single Story Residential House Of Land Area Measuring 1143. 97 Sq. Yds. I. E. 966. 50 Sq. Mtrs., Part Of Gata No. 88, Situated At Village Tillegampur, Pargana And Tehsil Sikandrabad, District Bulandshahr, U.P. Boundaries (As Per Mortgage/Sale Document):- East : Plot Of Mr. Vinod, West : Plot Of Mr. Harender, North : Plot Of Mr. Rohtash, South : Road 20 Ft. Wide
3	Loan A/C. No(S). : USFBDDELLOAN000005015300 & CFSDELLOAN000005013111 1. Late Manoj Tyagi, S/O. Mangu Tyagi Alias Mangu Singh Tyagi, (Through Its All Known/Unknown Legal Hirer) 2. Mrs Preeti Alias Preeti J. W/O. Late Manoj Kumar Add For Sr. No. 1 & 2 : Khasra No. 327 Ajan Pur Mangavli Mangavli, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, 201206.	26.06.2026 Rs. 18,13,773/- (Rupees Eighteen Lakh Thirteen Thousand Seven Hundred Seventy-Three only) As On 16.06.2026 NPA Date : 05.05.2026	All The Piece And Parcel Of Vacant Plot Measuring 204.92 Sq. Yards / Sq. Meter 171.33 Bearing In Consisting Part Of Khasra No. 327/m1, Village Ajabpur Mangavli, Radha Kunj Colony, Pargana Jalalabad, Tehsil Modinagar, District Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh – 201206 Being Bound On The -Boundaries :- North : 14 Feet Wide Road 55 Feet 7 Inch, East: Plot Of Sarita Sharma 33 Feet 10 Inch, South: Plot Of Sharmaji 47 Feet 10 Inches, West: 37 Feet 6 Inches

The borrower(s) are hereby advised to comply with the demand notice(s) and to pay the demand amount mentioned therein and hereinafter within 60 days from the date of this publication together with applicable interest, additional interest, bounce charges, cost and expenses till the date of realization of payment. The borrower(s) may note that USFBL is a secured creditor and the loan facility availed by the Borrower(s) is a secured debt against the immovable property/properties being the secured asset(s) mortgaged by the borrower(s). In the event borrower(s) are failed to discharge their liabilities in full within the stipulated time, USFBL shall be entitled to exercise all the rights under Section 13(4) of the Act to take possession of the secured asset(s) including but not limited to transfer the same by way of sale or by invoking any other remedy available under the Act and the Rules thereunder and realize payment. USFBL is also empowered to ATTACH AND/OR SEAL the secured asset(s) before enforcing the right to sale or transfer. Subsequent to the Sale of the secured asset(s), USFBL also has a right to initiate separate legal proceedings to recover the balance dues, in case the value of the mortgaged properties is insufficient to cover the dues payable to the USFBL. This remedy is in addition and independent of all the other remedies available to USFBL under any other law. The attention of the borrower(s) is invited to Section 13(8) of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets and further to Section 13(13) of the Act, whereby the borrower(s) are restrained/prohibited from disposing of or dealing with the secured asset(s) or transferring by way of sale, lease or otherwise (other than in the ordinary course of business) any of the secured asset(s), without prior written consent of USFBL and non-compliance with the above is an offence punishable under Section 29 of the said Act. The copy of the demand notice is available with the undersigned and the borrower(s) may, if they so desire, can collect the same from the undersigned on any working day during normal office hours.

Sd/-
Place : Delhi
Date : 04.08.2026

Authorized Officer
Unity Small Finance Bank Limited

India brings devotional music to Fiji through Bhajan Jamming 2026



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Suva

The High Commission of India in Suva, in collaboration with the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR), organised Bhajan Jamming 2026 at the University of the South Pacific, celebrating Indian devotional music and cultural ties with Fiji. Local artists, community groups, students, and members of the Indian diaspora came together for an evening of soulful bhajans that highlighted the deep historical and cultural bonds between the two countries. High Commissioner Suneet

Mehta emphasised that devotional music transcends borders and strengthens people-to-people connections. He noted its role in preserving shared traditions and promoting mutual understanding.

The event saw enthusiastic participation from USP students, reflecting growing youth interest in Indian culture and spirituality. Performers were presented with certificates in recognition of their contributions. The programme is part of India's ongoing cultural diplomacy efforts in the Pacific region through art, music, and heritage initiatives.

Indonesian ferry fire kills five, several missing



ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Surabaya

Indonesian rescuers searched for possible missing passengers on Monday after rescuing 231 people from a ferry that caught fire the previous day off the main island of Java, leaving at least five people dead.

The Mutiara Sentosa 2 ferry was travelling from Indonesia's second-largest city of Surabaya in East Java to the city of Makassar in South Sulawesi.

Initial reports said it was carrying 271 people, including 39 crew members, based on the ship's manifest, when the fire broke out between 6 am and 7 am. However, by Monday officials said many more people were aboard than listed, and the number of people missing was unclear. Officials were relying on reports from families of victims and survivors in an attempt to determine the number of the missing.

It is common in Indonesia for the number of passengers on a boat or ferry to differ from the manifest. Such discrepancies can complicate search and rescue efforts, said Nanang Sigit, the search mission coordinator who also heads the Surabaya Search and Rescue Office.

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SBI Pension Funds AUM crosses ₹6 lakh crore

SBI Pension Funds, a pension fund manager under the National Pension System (NPS), has crossed ₹6 lakh crore in assets under management (AUM) while serving over 1.85 crore subscribers across Government, corporate and retail segments.

The milestone reflects the growing confidence of millions of subscribers and reinforces the company's leadership position, with over 34 per cent market share in India's pension fund industry, the fund house said in a statement on Monday.

The achievement marks an important milestone not just for SBI Pension Funds but for India's evolving retirement ecosystem, it added.

The company's growth has been underpinned by sustained subscriber trust over the years, it said.

From crossing ₹1 lakh crore AUM in 2018 to reaching Rs 6 lakh crore today, each milestone reflects the increasing adoption of retirement planning and the confidence placed in SBI Pension Funds by millions of subscribers across the country, it said.

Over the last 15 years, SBI Pension Funds' AUM has grown at a compounded growth rate of nearly 36 per cent, it added. (PTI)

RBI appoints Monisha Chakraborty as ED

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Monday said it has appointed Monisha Chakraborty as Executive Director (ED), who will oversee the departments of foreign exchange and financial markets regulation.

Prior to being promoted as ED, she was serving as Chief General Manager-in-Charge in the Department of Supervision. "As a career central banker, Monisha Chakraborty has experience of over three decades in the Reserve Bank, having worked in the areas of Supervision, Foreign Exchange and Government and Bank Accounts," the RBI said. She was associated with a technical committee set up to review the format of the RBI's Balance Sheet and Profit and Loss account.

Chakraborty, who has a degree in Economics and a Master's degree in Business Economics from Delhi University, has also served as Banking Ombudsman. (PTI)

Closing auction session for equity cash segment comes into effect

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Closing Auction Session (CAS) in the equity cash segment became operational on Monday, ushering in a new auction-based mechanism to determine closing prices of eligible stocks.

Introduced by markets regulator SEBI, the new framework is aimed at making the price discovery process more transparent and robust, and applies only to cash market stocks with derivative contracts, while the existing volume-weighted average

price (VWAP)-based methodology will continue for other stocks.

Before this, closing prices were determined using the VWAP of trades executed

Govt proposes to ease tax relief conditions for offshore funds

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

To strengthen India's position as a global fund management hub, the Government has proposed to substantially relax the eligibility conditions for an Eligible Investment Fund (EIF) managed from India to avail tax exemption on its global income.

As per the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, to avail tax exemption on global income, offshore funds would no longer be required to satisfy the conditions like minimum investor threshold of 25 members, maximum 10 per cent participation interest

for a single investor, restriction on investing more than 25 per cent of the corpus in a single entity, restriction on investments in associate entities and minimum monthly average corpus requirement of Rs 100 crore.

The Bill, which has been circulated by the Government among the members of Parliament, is expected to be introduced by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in the Lok Sabha soon.

The proposed amendments in the Bill also seek to remove separate exemption conditions for funds operating from the International Financial Services Centre (IFSC).

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | AUGUST 4, 2026

Goyal pushes to double India-Uzbekistan trade

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Uzbekistan should look at the possibility of a free trade agreement and aim to double their bilateral trade over the next three years, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday. Goyal said huge opportunities are there in enhancing cooperation in areas like mining, pharma, and healthcare.

The two-way commerce stood around \$1.5 billion at present. Trade will have to lead from the front to boost economic ties between the two countries, he said, adding that "let's look to double trade in

Union Minister Piyush Goyal speaking during the India-Uzbekistan Business Forum in New Delhi

PTI

Willie Walsh assumes charge as IndiGo CEO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Willie Walsh, a pilot and an aviation industry leader, on Monday took charge as the CEO of the country's largest airline IndiGo.

An Irish national, Walsh is now at the helm of IndiGo after completing his tenure as the Director General of the International Air Transport Association (IATA) on July 31. The appointment of Walsh was announced by IndiGo on March 31, less than three weeks after the sudden exit of Pieter Elbers against the backdrop of massive operational disruptions at the airline in December last year.

In a release on Monday, IndiGo said Walsh has assumed charge as the CEO to lead the airline's next era of growth and global ambition.

As CEO, IndiGo said Walsh would lead the airline's overall management and strategic direction, with a focus on accelerating its global growth trajectory, driving operational excellence, strengthening network and commercial strategy, and further enhancing customer experience.

"IndiGo has built a remarkable legacy

over the last two decades, establishing itself amongst the largest airlines in the world in a short span of time.

"With India becoming one of the world's fastest-growing aviation markets, the opportunities ahead for IndiGo are immense. There could not be a more exciting and opportune time for me to join IndiGo than now," Walsh said.

IndiGo Managing Director Rahul Bhatia said Walsh's extensive global experience in the aviation industry, combined with his operational and strategic expertise, will be instrumen-

tal as IndiGo accelerates its international expansion strategy.

Walsh has also served as the CEO of Aer Lingus, British Airways and International Airlines Group. As the head of IATA, Walsh was known for his frank and direct style of expressing his views.

He has taken over the reins at a pivotal moment for IndiGo, which commands more than 66 per cent of India's domestic market and is pursuing ambitious international expansion, with wide-body A350-900 aircraft expected to join its fleet from early 2028. IndiGo already has more than 900 planes on order.

During an interview with PTI last week, Bhatia praised Walsh and said he is "very deep operationally" and will bring significant value to the airline's operations.

"For Willie, this journey at IndiGo is not a stepping stone to something into the future," Bhatia, also IndiGo's co-founder, told PTI in an interview.

"I think he really is motivated to make a difference. And I can see that when I talk to him," Bhatia had said.

Stock markets rally for 4th straight day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Stock market benchmark indices ended higher on Monday, with the Sensex climbing 544.39 points and Nifty surging 1.60 per cent, following a sharp decline in crude oil prices amid easing geopolitical tensions.

Foreign fund inflows also added to markets' optimism.

Extending the winning momentum to the fourth day, the 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 544.39 points, or 0.70 per cent, to settle at 78,639.03. During the day, it surged 800.46 points, or 1 per cent, to 78,895.10. The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 390.70 points, or 1.60 per cent, to end at 24,774.30. From the Sensex pack, InterGlobe Aviation, Tata Consultancy Services, Infosys,

Index	Open	High	Low	Close	Change
NSE NIFTY	24,572.70	24,774.30	24,515.15	24,774.30	+1.60%
BSE SENSEX	78,883.34	78,895.10	78,497.34	78,639.03	+0.70%

Eternal, ITC, and Axis Bank were among the major winners.

Sun Pharma, Bharti Airtel, Maruti, and Tata Steel were among the laggards.

The BSE SmallCap Select

index climbed 0.87 per cent and MidCap Select index edged higher by 0.73 per cent.

Among sectors, IT jumped 2.53 per cent, Focused IT (2.49 per cent), services (1.97 per cent), industrials (1.23 per

cent), commodities (1.20 per cent), metal (1.14 per cent), FMCG (1.13 per cent), insurance (1.01 per cent) and PSU bank (1 per cent).

Hospitals, oil & gas, and healthcare were the laggards. A total of 2,837 stocks advanced, while 1,552 declined and 206 remained unchanged on the BSE.

In four trading days, the BSE benchmark jumped 1,873.11 points, or 2.44 per cent, and the Nifty climbed 788.95 points, or 3.28 per cent.

"Indian equity markets ended higher, supported by broad-based buying as easing tensions in the Middle East and a sharp decline in global crude oil prices boosted investor sentiment," Hariselman Radhakrishnan, Founder & CEO of HST Wealth, a Research Analyst firm, said.

RBI sells \$14.9b during January-May to check excess volatility in rupee

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The RBI's foreign exchange intervention during January-May 2026 amounted to a net sale of \$14.9 billion to check excess volatility of the rupee, Parliament was informed on Monday.

The value of the Indian Rupee (INR) is market-determined, with no target or specific level or band, Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary said in a written reply in the Lok Sabha.

"The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) regularly monitors the foreign exchange market and intervenes in situations of excess volatility. As per the latest data available from the RBI, the RBI's foreign

exchange intervention during January-May 2026 amounted to a net sale of \$14.9 billion," he said.

Movements in the Foreign Exchange Reserves (FER) occur on account of multiple factors, including purchase and sale of foreign exchange by the RBI, income arising out of the deployment of the FER, external aid receipts of the central government and changes on account of revaluation of the assets, he said.

The RBI has undertaken several measures to boost forex inflows, including a

concessional swap facility for Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) or FCNR(B) deposits, External Commercial Borrowings (ECB), and Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCB), which were announced on June 5, 2026.

Replying to another question, Chaudhary said recovery in written-off loans is an ongoing process, and banks continue pursuing their recovery actions initiated against borrowers under the various recovery mechanism available to them.

INDIA OPENS OMAN TRADE IMPORT WINDOW

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government on Monday invited applications for the allocation of 2026-27 import quotas for products like dates, marble, and aluminium ingots under the duty concession provisions of the India-Oman free trade agreement.

Under the comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEPA), India has granted quota-based tariff concessions to certain Omani goods such as dates, marble, copper weld wire, aluminium ingots, billets and wires, and certain petrochemical products, such as ethylene glycol, linear alkylbenzenes, and low-density polyethylene.

The pact came into force from June 1.

"New applications for TRQ (tariff rate quota) under India-Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) for FY2026-27 are invited from August 4, 2026, up to August 19, 2026," the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) said in a public notice.

PROSPECT

JSS University begins six-day orientation programme



JSS University, Noida, on Monday inaugurated, its six-day orientation and induction programme for the Academic Year 2026-27, marking the beginning of an exciting academic journey for more than 1,700 newly admitted students of B Tech, B Pharm and D Pharm programmes.

The inaugural ceremony was graced by DrAnmol M Andhare, Joint Secretary, University Grants Commission (UGC), New Delhi, as thechief guest, in the presence of Dr Lalith Verma, Special Officer, JSS Mahavidyapeetha, Dr HR Mahadevaswamy, Vice Chancellor, JSS University, Noida, along with senior university leadership.

Welcoming the students and parents, the Registrar Dr TGMamtha emphasised the University's commitment to academic excellence and holistic student development. Dr RS Jagadish, Organising Chair, presented an overview of the six-day programme, while the Dean Academics introduced the University's academic framework, interdisciplinary learning ecosystem, and industry-oriented educational approach.

ACA HAILS SUBHADEEP GHOSH AS INDIA FIELDING COACH



The Assam Cricket Association (ACA) extends its heartfelt congratulations to Subhadeep Ghosh on his appointment as the Fielding Coach of the Indian Senior Men's Cricket Team.

A former domestic cricketer from Assam, Subhadeep Ghosh represented both Assam and Railways during his playing career.

He also served as the Coach of the Assam Senior Men's Team, making significant contributions to the development of cricket in the State.

NBCC inks landmark housing agreement with Seychelles

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

NBCC (India) Limited, a Navratna CPSE under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, Government of India, has signed a landmark agreement with the Government of the Republic of Seychelles for the construction of the Ile Aurore Housing Project, comprising 1,008 affordable housing units along with associated infrastructure in Seychelles.

The agreement was signed on July 29 in the august presence of HE Sebastien Pillay, Vice President of the Republic of Seychelles, and Dr KP Mahadevaswamy, Chairman & Managing Director, NBCC (India) Limited.

The agreement was formally signed by Joseph Francois, Secretary of State, Lands, Housing and Infrastructure, Government of the Republic of Seychelles, and Pradeep Sharma, Executive Director (Engineering), NBCC (India) Limited.

The project envisages the development of 1,008 affordable housing units along with associated infrastructure, aimed at enhancing urban living standards and supporting sustainable development in Seychelles. The project will



be funded through a Line of Credit (LoC) of \$75 Million extended by the Export-Import Bank of India (EXIM Bank).

The project scope also includes the execution of essential associated infrastructure works, such as a dedicated Sewage Treatment Plant (STP), ensuring sustainable and modern community living standards on Ile Aurore. The project is expected to contribute significantly to improving housing availability while promoting sustainable

PM launches two key POWERGRID projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Visakhapatnam

Narendra Modi, Prime Minister of India, laid the foundation stone for one transmission project and dedicated two significant transmission projects of Power Grid Corporation of India Limited (POWERGRID), a Maharatna PSU under the Ministry of Power, Government of India, marking another major milestone in India's clean energy transition.

On this occasion, S Abdul Nazeer, Governor of Andhra Pradesh; Puspapati Ashok Gajapathi Raju, Governor of Goa; N Chandrababu Naidu, Chief Minister of Andhra Pradesh; K Pawan Kalyan,



Gen-Z youth: The thin line between protest and provocation



The highly objectionable language used by some Gen-Z youth during the NEET protest at Jantar Mantar not only damaged the spirit of a legitimate agitation but also crossed the boundaries of democratic decorum.

What began in June 2026 under the banner of the Cockroach Janata Party as a platform for students' genuine anger over the NEET paper leak and examination irregularities eventually delivered results — including the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Yet the same movement was stained by instances of extreme vulgarity directed at Prime Minister Narendra Modi, his late mother and the security forces — language that no civilised society can accept. Some participants crossed the *Lakshman Rekha* of democratic protest by resorting to such abuse.

She expressed deep shame, called it her first and last mistake, and sought forgiveness from the nation.

Other young people similarly admitted that they had been swept away by the moment and provoked into using such language.

Their claim deserves attention. Many of these youth now say that an atmosphere was deliberately created at the protest site in which abuse and indecency were normalised. Certain elements actively instigated them, pushing the real issues — paper leaks, examination fairness and students' futures — into the background.

Under the cover of the protest, basic linguistic dignity was completely abandoned.

The right to protest is a fundamental democratic right, but it does not include a license for insult or obscenity. When the younger generation — the future of the country — adopts such language, it reflects not merely an individual failing but an erosion of social values. Certain elements appeared more interested in political point-scoring than in addressing the genuine concerns of students.

A restrained response from the Prime Minister

In this entire episode, Prime Minister Narendra Modi responded with notable restraint and a paternal tone. In an Instagram video message, he observed that some mischievous children at Jantar Mantar had used language unbecoming of a civilised society, and that even his late mother had been targeted.

Yet he emphasised that mistakes occur in youth and that children deserve an opportunity to reform. Using a powerful analogy, he said that when the tongue is bitten by the teeth, we do not break the teeth — because both belong to us, just as these children belong to the nation.

By choosing restraint over retribution, the Prime Minister occupied the moral high ground and appealed to society to guide these misguided youth

rather than harass them or drag them through courts.

Lessons for student movements and society

This episode offers clear lessons. Student movements must remain free from political provocation and ideological capture.

Social media proved to be a double-edged sword — it helped mobilise the youth but also created a permanent digital footprint of their worst moments. Families, educational institutions and society must prioritise the teaching of linguistic civility and democratic values.

Abuses solve no problem; they only damage the credibility of the movement itself. Allowing protests to descend into abuse is akin to playing with fire — it burns the credibility of the cause.

Gen-Z is a product of the digital age — sharp, aware and eager for change. But on the path of change, maintaining dignity in language and behaviour is essential.

The young people who have now apologised have taken the first step towards accountability. Society, in turn, should offer them a second chance so they can grow into responsible citizens. Protests remain a vital strength of democracy — but only when they stay dignified, focused and civil.

In the end, the Jantar Mantar episode reminds us to remain vigilant against atmospheres that divert attention from students' real issues. Elements that provoke the youth must be identified, and democratic linguistic dignity must be protected at all costs.

A mistake was made, apologies have been offered — now is the time to move forward, learn, and build a more civilised society.

Youth power is the country's greatest asset; if given the right direction, no goal is impossible.

The author is an assistant professor at Allahabad Degree College, University of Allahabad

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING:★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (3.8.26)

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

TUESDAY | AUGUST 4, 2026

ACROSS

DOWN

SOLUTION (3.8.26)

10 How it was specified arms should be dispensed with? (4,4)

11 Favouring on account of (3)

12 He will speak at, either before or after (6)

13 Twist to the music (6)

14 Back in the same trap, which one finds puzzling (7)

15 Broaches the return fight (4)

16 Writing in prison and peddling drugs (17)

17 Said to have seen (8)

18 Having one call round on and smoothing things over (7)

19 It's a hair of the dog the morning after, doctor (4)

21 Half-turns a key, entering to get the cure for everything (7)

20 "Prerogative" is perfect (5)

22 A little music, one allows, has charms (3)

23 Can it tell you just where your golf ball has landed? (3,8)

25 Insurance for the bit player in "The Fielder"? (5,5)

26 Writing to dictation is lowering (6,4)

28 The data for the book on textiles? (8)

31 What heights the incredibility had reached? (8)

32 Swoon as you hand round? (4,3)

34 Flowing in the bar (6)

35 Ring Michael when Al has gone out (5)

39 Brand name (4)

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Sr. No.	Name of Work/Item	Period/Tentative Qty
1.	For Verka Bathinda Dairy a) Hiring of:- i. Cold Store (Deep Freezer) for storage of White Butter. Capacity Approx.400 MT to 500 MT. (extended upto three months and further three months). ii. Vehicles for Sale Depot, Bathinda & Verka Bathinda Dairy for supply of Ghee, Butter, Powder, Panjiri, Tetra Pack & others products all Punjab & other States for a period of one year. Cap.1 Ton, 2 Ton, 3 Ton, 4 Ton, 5 Ton, 7 Ton. b) Supply of equipments for 6 TPC powder plant installed at Verka Bathinda Dairy (including design, supply, installation, testing, commissioning & integration with existing setup complete in all respects). c) For Verka Hoshiarpur Dairy Rate contract of Advertisement material. d) For Verka Patiala Dairy a) Fire Wood (10,000 Quintals). b) Labour contract for providing of Unskilled, Semi skilled, Skilled, Highly skilled, A, B category workers and eligible labour for different posts through outsourcing. c) Job contract for:- i. Production, Packing of SFM bottles and Operation, Repair and Maintenance of all machines related to SFM. ii. Operation, repair and maintenance of pouch filling machine, tray washer & coding of pouches. Loading/ Unloading of different materials. d) Hiring of:- i. Insulated vehicles with different capacities for supply of Verka milk and milk products. ii. Insulated S.S Road Milk tankers for milk lifting from BMC's/ MCC's & sister dairies cap. 9,000-11,000 litres. iii. Vehicle Tata 207, Mahindra Maxi Truck etc. for transportation of milk from Societies/ Dairy (Malwa, Ghallu, Jalandhar) Capacity 10000 kgs (Double Chamber). iv. Vehicle for Procurement & Veterinary activities and extension work etc. (Swift Dezire, Honda Amaze, Verna i.e.Sedan cars with open Digger). 4. For Verka Ferozepur Dairy Supply, installations, testing and commissioning of new DG set capacity 100 KVA for MCC Tugalwal. 5. For Verka Ferozepur Dairy Hiring of:- i. Insulated vehicles for supply of packed milk and fresh milk products in Ferozepur Marketing area. ii. Mahindra pickup/ Maxi truck pickup or equivalent to lift the can milk from various Societies/ Dairy farms to MCC/ Plant. iii. Insulated road milk tankers for transportation of milk from BMC's to Verka Ferozepur Dairy (Malwa, Ghallu, Jalandhar) Capacity 10000 kgs (Double Chamber). iv. Mahindra Pickup/ Max pickup etc. to lift the cattle feed & other products from various main store or sub store of Milk Union Ferozepur to MPCSS. v. Insulated road milk tankers for transportation of milk from MCC's (Ghallu, Jalandhar) to Verka Ferozepur Dairy. Capacity 10000 kgs. 6. For Verka Sangrur Dairy Hiring of Mahindra Maxi Truck pickup, Bolero Pickup or equivalent for transportation of milk through caps to lift the milk from various societies/Dairy farms to MCC/BMC/Dairy Dock. 7. For Verka Ferozepur Dairy Hiring of:- i. Insulated road milk tanker for transportation of milk from MCC's to various Milk plants in Punjab etc. on rate contract. ii. Pick up or its equivalent vehicle for lifting the milk from MPCSS/DF to MCC. iii. Vehicles for procurement, marketing & AI activities. a) Mahindra Bolero b) Sedan car (e.g. Swift Dezire, Honda City, Hyundai Aura, or equivalent). 8. For Verka Amritsar Dairy a) Hiring of vehicle for supply of Fresh Milk and Milk products at Patti & surrounding area. b) Empanelment of insulated road milk tankers for transportation of milk from milk chilling centres to milk union Amritsar and Milk Union Amritsar to other unions & Powder Plants. c) Supply, installation, testing & commissioning of new fully automatic machine for filling & seaming of Milk Powder in Tins along with automatic nitrogen gas flushing facility.	One year/As per requirement As per requirement One Complete Job One Year Half Yearly Annual 40,000 to 50,000 bottles per day or as per demand 55,000 to 60,000 ltrs/ day or as per demand As per requirement 08 No's Single Chamber-14 No's Double Chamber-02 No's 02 No's 01 No. 01 No. Annual/ 04 MT, 07 MT, 1.7 MT-01 Vehicle (for each) Annual/ 07 No's Annual/ 02 No's 02 No's Annual/ 02 No's 11 No's Cap. 10000 kg-10 & 15000kg-02 16 No's 01 No. 02 No's One Year 15 MT, 20 MT, 25 MT, 30 MT For 1 kg & 0.5 kg Tins

NOTE:
1. For complete details regarding above tender (NIT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in
2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.

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BRIEFLY

UEFA warns FIFA of legal action against Infantino



European soccer body UEFA has threatened FIFA with legal action over Gianni Infantino's failed plan to sell a stake in future World Cup profits to private investors, and said any potential evidence should not be destroyed.

Infantino's secretive proposal to raise \$4.2 billion from investors including the New York investment firm of Joshua Kushner was dropped early Saturday, days after the revelation in media reports provoked a global furor.

UEFA led the backlash and on Thursday its 55 member federations met to agree boycotting all FIFA events and competitions while the proposal was active.

Now lawyers for UEFA have informed FIFA that the European body is "actively considering legal action, arbitration, and/or regulatory complaints ... arising out of and in connection with the FFE (FIFA Forward Enterprise) plan proposed by FIFA and all related matters."

The letter dated Friday from the legal firm Dechert in New York was seen Monday by The Associated Press.

The letter named 18 FIFA executives who it said should retain data, documents and electronic messages as potential evidence.

"UEFA puts you on formal notice that any destruction, deletion, alteration, concealment, or loss of relevant materials following receipt of this notice - or following any earlier date on which you were, or reasonably should have been, aware that proceedings were anticipated - may constitute spoliation of evidence," the letter said. (AP)

Skinner quits as Manchester United women's coach



Manchester United women's team has one month to find a new coach before the Women's Super League season begins after Marc Skinner stepped down by mutual consent on Monday.

Skinner departed the club after five years in the role, despite having another season to go on the contract extension he signed in 2025.

United begins its season against London City Lionesses on September 4. "Marc leaves having made a significant contribution to the continued progress of Manchester United Women," United said in a statement.

"The club places on record its sincere thanks for his professionalism, commitment and dedication throughout his time at United, and wishes him every success in the future." Under Skinner, who succeeded Casey Stoney in July 2021, United reached four domestic cup finals in four seasons and won the FA Cup in 2024 for its first major honour in women's soccer.

United also finished runner-up in the WSL in 2023 to qualify for the Women's Champions League for the first time. Last season, United lost to Bayern Munich in the Champions League quarterfinals. It failed to again qualify for Europe's premier club competition after finishing fourth in the WSL, 15 points behind crosstown rival Manchester City, which won the title. (AP)

Japan celebrates back-to-back Women's Open as Kuwaki triumphs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Royal Lytham & St Annes

Japan continued its growing dominance in women's golf as Shiko Kuwaki defeated Germany's Esther Henseleit in a two-hole playoff to win the 2026 AIG Women's Open, becoming the second successive Japanese champion after Miyu Yamashita's triumph in 2025. For India, however, the championship ended in disappointment with Hero-backed Diksha Dagar and Aditi Ashok bowing out after missing the cut on Friday.

Kuwaki, who had been among the leaders throughout the week, closed with a steady 1-under 70 to finish regulation at 5-under-par. Her victory capped an impressive week of 66-70-73-70. Her final round 70 was highlighted by three birdies and just two bogeys in the final round.

The 23-year-old held the clubhouse lead before Henseleit, playing in the final group, matched her total with a closing birdie on the 18th to force a playoff. The pair halved the first extra hole with pars before the championship was decided on the second playoff hole. Kuwaki found both the fairway and the green in regulation, while Henseleit's tee shot finished in the thick gorse.

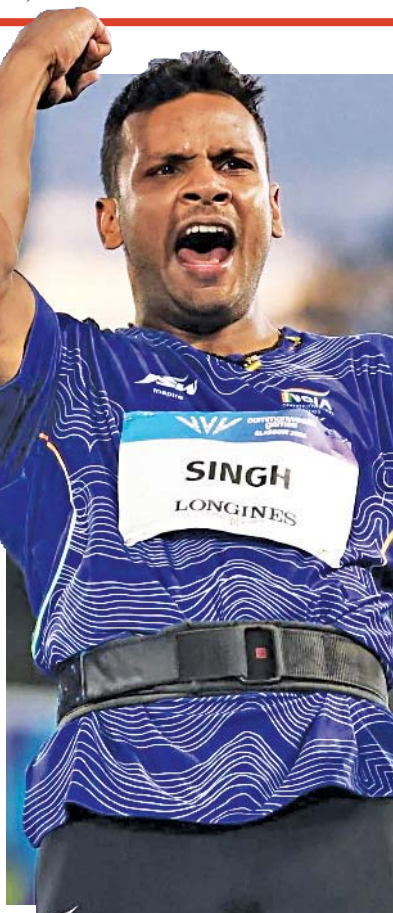
Although the German recovered



admirably, she could only make bogey, allowing Kuwaki to calmly hole her par putt and claim her maiden Major title.

"It feels amazing," said Kuwaki. "After Yamashita's win last year, to win again as a Japanese player is very special. I hope Team Japan can continue to shine on the world stage and that everyone enjoys watching us."

Henseleit (66) produced one of the rounds of the day to force the playoff. The two-time Ladies European Tour winner endured a roller-coaster front nine, mixing a birdie with three bogeys, before staging a superb comeback after the turn.



Keep the spear in one line: Neeraj's last-second advice to Yashvir Singh

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Yashvir Singh credited a simple piece of last-second advice from Olympic champion Neeraj Chopra for producing the throw of his life, as Indian javelin thrower surged from seventh place to clinch a bronze medal at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games.

After the penultimate round, Yashvir was in seventh place with a best throw of 81.33m, while South Africa's Douw Smit occupied third spot with an effort of 82.88m.

"I had to overcome the adverse conditions. Neeraj motivated me before my final throw and supported me. He told me to keep



the javelin in one line, and it paid off," Yashvir told PTI on Monday after receiving a hero's welcome on his return at Delhi's IGI Airport.

"This was one of the biggest tournaments of my life, so my only aim was to give my 100 per cent effort and leave nothing behind. I wanted to produce my personal best there. I am happy

that I achieved a personal best of 85.41 metres and also won the bronze medal with that performance," he said.

While hurling the javelin, keeping the spear in one line (or aligned with the shoulder) is an important technique as it helps maximise distance while reducing strain on the throwing arm.

When PTI asked what exactly he did to follow Neeraj's advice, Yashvir explained that it meant holding the javelin near ear level, keeping his shoulders aligned in the direction of the throw, drawing back his arm and the javelin in a straight line, and releasing it over his shoulder along that same line.

Yashvir admitted he competed without any pressure as the spotlight was on Neeraj and his rivals, including Olympic and defending champion Arshad Nadeem, Sri Lanka's Rumesh Pathirage and Grenada's Anderson Peters.

"I had no pressure as the focus was on Neeraj, Nadeem and Rumesh. I just had to give my 100 per cent effort. I kept telling myself to achieve my personal best. God was kind and it happened," he signed off. (PTI)

Food poisoning cost me Commonwealth Games gold: Bronze medallist Prabhu

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Commonwealth Games bronze medallist Selva Prabhu believes food poisoning denied him a shot at the gold medal in Glasgow, saying a performance close to his personal best would have been enough to top the podium. Selva won bronze in the men's triple jump with an effort of 16.52m, finishing behind compatriot Praveen Chithravel (16.58m) and Scotland's Jordan Scott (16.72m).

"I wish I should have gotten that gold. I was really hoping for gold but what can be done when the competition begins, there is illness and food poisoning. I feel that in the end, there is always a cost to yourself. I am mentally tough so I decided, whatever happens, I will do it. Keep pushing myself," Selva told PTI after returning from Glasgow on Monday.

The Tamil Nadu athlete said the illness affected his performance and rued missing a golden opportunity, as a jump close to his personal best of 17.05m would have comfortably secured the title.

"I should have stayed healthy, but it's for the next time I'm



always ready. I can compete more, stay healthy. It's about the stage. I have the consistency. It's all about that particular day. I just always want to stay healthy. Now, I want to work on my approach. Once I get the hang of it, I can do it," he said. Asked about Asian Games, Selva said he was not looking too far ahead.

"I live each day. Each day requires a new performance. You just cannot target a gold like that. Yes, I am now looking forward to qualifying for the Asian Games first and then taking it from there," he said. The Athletics Federation of India (AFI) is yet to announce the team for the Asian Games in Japan. (PTI)



2030 CWG will set new benchmarks: Harsh Sanghavi

APARAJITA UPADHYAY
■ Glasgow

Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi said the 2030 Commonwealth Games in Ahmedabad will set new benchmarks in accessibility and sustainability, while insisting that the city already possesses enough infrastructure to stage the centenary edition of the multi-sport event.

Ahmedabad will host the Commonwealth Games in 2030, marking the event's return to India after two decades. India last staged the Games in New Delhi in 2010.

Sanghavi, who also holds the sports portfolio in the state, said Ahmedabad's biggest focus would be on ensuring the Games are fully inclusive for para athletes. "For para athletes, Ahmedabad will set a new example. We are already making all hotels accessible for para athletes. Our aim is to make it the most para athlete-friendly Commonwealth Games," he said on Sunday.

He also highlighted Gujarat's push towards green energy and sustainable urban transport, saying the Games would be built around environment-friendly infrastructure.



"Gujarat is India's largest producer of green energy. Ahmedabad will set the best standards in sustainability," he said. "All local transportation, including the BRT system, will be electric. Right now it is around 90 per cent electric, but by 2030 it will be 100 per cent." He asserted that the city already has the necessary infrastructure to host the Games, with only limited upgrades required.

"We already have enough infrastructure to conduct Commonwealth Games even today. If we refurbish around 20 per cent of the existing infrastructure, we will be able to conduct it," Sanghavi said. (PTI)

In-form Tanvi, fit-again Srikanth headline Indian challenge in Korea

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Asan (Korea)

Newly-crowned Taipei Open champion Tanvi Sharma and a fit-again Kidambi Srikanth will look to continue India's impressive run on the international circuit when they spearhead the country's challenge at the Korea Masters Super 300 badminton tournament, beginning here on Tuesday.

Tanvi, the 17-year-old from Punjab, produced a sensational performance to clinch her maiden BWF World Tour title after defeating Vietnam's sixth seed Thuy Linh Nguyen in the final of the Taipei Open on Sunday.

The historic triumph made her only the second Indian women's singles player to win the Taipei Open, joining Saina Nehwal (2008).



She also became only the fourth Indian women's singles shuttler to secure a Super 300 or higher-level title, joining an elite club comprising Saina, PV Sindhu and Devika Sihag.

The feat has put her in the spot-



light and expectations will be high from the Indian this week as she opens her campaign against a qualifier.

India has six players in the men's singles and 10 in the women's singles main draws of the

USD 250,000 event.

In the men's singles, third seed Srikanth, a 2021 World Championships silver medallist, looked in good rhythm as he reached the final of the US Open but was forced to withdraw from the

Canada Open the following week due to a fitness issue.

Now back to full fitness, the former world No. 1 will begin his campaign against Israel's Daniil Dubovenko.

Kiran George has drawn a qualifier in the opening round and could face eighth seed Wang Po-Wei of Chinese Taipei in the pre-quarterfinals.

Saneeth Dayanand faces a daunting opener against top seed Yudai Okimoto of Japan, while Rounak Chouhan takes on fourth seed Jeon Hyeok Jin of South Korea.

Tharun Manneppalli will face South Korea's Yoo Tae Bin, while Mithun Manjunath meets China's Zhu Xuan Chen. Should both Indians win their opening matches, Srikanth and Mithun will square off in an all-Indian second-round clash.

Thorbjornsen captures PGA Tour title, secures FedExCup playoff berth

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Detroit (US)

Michael Thorbjornsen capped a remarkable week by claiming his maiden PGA TOUR title at the Rocket Classic, confirming his place in the FedExCup Playoffs with a brilliant final-round 7-under 63 at Detroit Golf Club.

The 24-year-old American, who arrived in Detroit on 69th position in the FedExCup standings and on the playoff bubble, finished at 18-under-par, two shots clear of Xander Schauffele to secure the biggest victory of his young career.

The Rocket Classic was the penultimate event of the PGA TOUR regular season, with only next week's Wyndham Championship remaining before the top 70 in the FedExCup standings advance to the playoffs. Thorbjornsen's victory guarantees his place in postseason.

The Indian-origin contingent also has plenty to celebrate Hero-backed Sahithi Theegala, Aaron Rai and Sudarshan Yellamaraju, along with Akshay Bhatia, who will feature in the FedExCup playoffs despite Bhatia missing the cut in Detroit.

Thorbjornsen's triumph added another milestone to a career that



has long promised success. In 2018, he won the U.S. Junior Amateur Championship by defeating Akshay Bhatia in the final, and after topping the PGA TOUR University rankings in 2024, he earned direct PGA TOUR membership.

Starting the day three shots behind overnight leader Davis Riley, Thorbjornsen steadily worked his way into contention with a flawless, bogey-free round. His decisive charge came with four birdies over a six-hole stretch, including a spectacular 35-foot chip-in for birdie at the 12th before another birdie at the 14th moved him into the outright

lead. He finished in memorable fashion, rolling in a 26-foot birdie putt on the 18th green to reach 18-under and effectively seal victory. Schauffele briefly held the lead during the final round after carding a 5-under 65 but ultimately settled for second place at 16-under.

Riley, who began Sunday with a one-shot advantage, endured a difficult start that derailed his title hopes. He bogeyed three of his first six holes, including a costly mistake at the fourth where he was unable to find his ball in the fescue despite an extensive search involving numerous spectators and officials.

Wadhawan to captain North Zone, Arshdeep named in squad



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's left-arm seamer Arshdeep Singh was on Monday named in the North Zone squad for the upcoming Duleep Trophy with Jammu and Kashmir's wicketkeeper-batter Kanhaiya Wadhawan appointed captain of the 15-member side. Arshdeep, a white ball specialist for Team India, was included in the Test squad during the 2025 tour of England but injury and combination related issues didn't allow him to make his red ball debut.

Haryana's Anshul Kamboj, was also included in North Zone squad for the tournament starting August 23.

Fresh from Jammu and Kashmir's historic Ranji Trophy

triumph, the selectors rewarded the champion side with six players in the squad. Besides Wadhawan, opener Qamran Iqbal, all-rounder Abdul Samad, left-arm spinner Abid Mushtaq, pacer Sunil Kumar and fast bowler Yudhvir Singh were included.

Delhi's Ayush Badoni was named vice-captain, while veteran Jammu and Kashmir skipper Paras Dogra, 41, was not considered for the tournament as Duleep Trophy is more about players trying to make a mark at national level.

Delhi has the next highest representation after Jammu and Kashmir with opener Sanat Sangwan, former skipper Yash Dhull, stocky middle-order batter Ayush Doseja and Badoni making the squad.

Glasgow 2026 strengthens India’s case in hosting the 2030 CWG



SHAKYA MITRA

A late surge over the final three days left a strong imprint on India's campaign at the 2026 Commonwealth Games, as they secured a fourth-place finish with 13 gold medals and 39 overall. Glasgow hosted an emergency, scaled-down edition comprising just ten sports, almost half the programme seen in Birmingham four years earlier. Several of India's traditional medal-winning disciplines, including Wrestling, Badminton and Table Tennis, were absent, while Shooting had already been dropped in 2022.

The reduced programme made India's eventual performance more credible than it initially appears. Birmingham 2022 had already shown India could remain among the leading nations despite the exclusion of Shooting, one of its strongest disciplines. Glasgow posed an even tougher challenge, stripping away several additional sports that have traditionally contributed substantially to India's medal tally. That India remained competitive suggests the country's sporting base is becoming broader rather than dependent on a handful of events.

Equally significant was the expanded presence of Para-sports at the Commonwealth Games. India has emerged as one of the world's fastest-rising para-sporting nations, with its performances at recent Paralympic Games often exceeding expectations compared with the Olympics.

However, Glasgow also exposed the increasingly fragile state of the Commonwealth Games. The event has struggled to find stable hosts for over a decade. Durban lost the 2022 Games because of financial concerns before Birmingham stepped in. The Australian state of Victoria was awarded the 2026 edition but withdrew after projected costs escalated dramatically, forcing Glasgow to rescue the event with a significantly reduced programme.

These repeated disruptions have inevitably prompted questions about whether the Commonwealth Games, which began as the British Empire Games, still have a meaningful place in an increasingly crowded international sporting calendar. For India, however, the answer is likely to be yes.

Unlike most Commonwealth nations, India occupies a unique position by competing at both the Commonwealth Games and the Asian Games. While the Commonwealth Games have traditionally offered greater medal opportunities in many sports, the Asian Games remain a stronger measure of sporting excellence because of competition from powerhouses such as China, Japan and South Korea

in India's stronger disciplines. That distinction has become particularly relevant because India is actively pursuing the 2036 Olympic Games in Ahmedabad. Ideally, any aspiring Olympic host would stage a major multi-sport event beforehand to demonstrate organisational capability, operational readiness and public engagement. The obvious choice would have been the Asian Games, but the hosting rights for both 2030 and 2034 had already been allocated in 2020, the former to Doha, also a rival bidder for the 2036 Olympics. That effective-

ly left the 2030 Commonwealth Games also in Ahmedabad, as India's only realistic opportunity to organise a major international multi-sport event before 2036.

Countries that successfully host major sporting events tend to build institutional expertise that strengthens future bids. South Korea, Brazil, West Germany and the United States have all staged the FIFA World Cup and Olympic Games within relatively short periods. Such events create experienced organising teams, tested venues, volunteer networks and confidence among international sporting bodies. India cannot replicate those examples exactly, but hosting the 2030 Commonwealth Games would allow it to demonstrate many of the same capabilities.

There is, admittedly, one important caveat. The International Olympic Committee is expected to decide the host of the 2036 Olympics in 2029, before the 2030 Commonwealth Games are held. It would therefore be inaccurate to argue that the Commonwealth Games will directly determine India's Olympic bid.

That, however, should not diminish their strategic importance. If India secures the Olympics, the Commonwealth Games would provide valuable operational preparation immediately beforehand. If the Olympic bid is unsuccessful, a well-

executed Commonwealth Games would substantially strengthen India's credentials for hosting a future edition.

There is also a less tangible but equally important benefit. Major sporting events can change public behaviour, even if only temporarily. The 2010 Commonwealth Games in Delhi arrived amid widespread criticism over multiple delays and financial controversies. Yet once competition began, public attention shifted decisively towards the athletes. India crossed the 100-medal mark for the first time, finished second overall and carried that momentum into its then-best-ever Asian Games performance later that year. With the 2030 Commonwealth Games expected to revert to a full-scale event, alongside home advantage, India could again finish among the leading nations.

Glasgow 2026 may ultimately be remembered as the stopgap edition that kept the Commonwealth Games alive. For India, however, it served another purpose. It underlined why 2030 should be viewed not simply as another Commonwealth Games, but as an opportunity to strengthen sporting institutions, build international credibility and accelerate its long-term ambition of becoming a genuine global sporting nation.

The writer is a sports management consultant with over a decade of experience in sports promotion and development. His work across both the private and government sectors gives him a well-rounded view of India's sports ecosystem

India’s cultural tapestry takes centre stage at CWG closing ceremony

APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ Glasgow

As the curtain came down on the Glasgow Commonwealth Games, India offered the world a vibrant invitation to Ahmedabad, blending ancient philosophy, contemporary artistry and cultural grandeur in a handover presentation that officially launched the journey towards the centenary edition of the Games in 2030.

The emotional centrepiece of Sunday's closing ceremony at the OVO Hydro saw Glasgow formally pass the Commonwealth Games baton to India before a spectacular showcase of music, dance and storytelling projected India's identity as a nation where tradition and modernity coexist.

Prince Edward, Duke of Edinburgh, representing King Charles III, formally declared the Games closed.

"Thanks for the manner in which you have competed, officiated, supported, organised the Games. You have once again brought the spirit and value of Commonwealth tonight. Thank You Glasgow," he said.

"I call up on athletes of all countries



and territories to come to Ahmedabad, India in four years time to celebrate the 24th Commonwealth Games in what will be the centenary of the Games," he added. Jaismine Lamboria carried India's flag at the closing ceremony after winning gold in the women's 57kg category boxing competition.

The formal handover began with its symbolic journey across the arena.

Led by bearers holding the Scottish and Indian flags, the procession lowered the folded Games flag. Glasgow's Lord Provost Jacqueline McLaren then passed it to Commonwealth Games Scotland vice-chair Susan Jackson, Scottish netball player Emily Nicholl, Commonwealth Sport president Dr Donald Rukare, two-time Olympic medallist Neeraj Chopra, Indian Olympic Association

president PT Usha, and finally Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi. This marked the official transfer of hosting responsibilities from Scotland to India.

From that solemn moment, the atmosphere transformed into a celebration of India's civilisational ethos. The Indian presentation unfolded over three acts, taking the audience on what organisers described as a journey celebrating shared values, culture and connection. The overarching message was rooted in the ancient Indian philosophy of Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam — "The World is One Family" — a theme that resonated strongly with the Commonwealth's ideals of unity and friendship.

The opening act also commemorated 150 years of Vande Mataram, India's national song, with a sweeping choreography led by actor Manushi Chhillar.

Set against immersive digital visuals, hundreds of dancers painted a vivid portrait of India's diversity while maestro Shankar Mahadevan's stirring score fused orchestral grandeur with Indian musical traditions. (PTI)

FC1 come from behind to prevail over Karbi Anglong Morning Star



TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

FC1 marked their Durand Cup debut with a spirited 2-1 comeback victory against Karbi Anglong Morning Star FC in a Group F fixture of the 135th IndianOil Durand Cup played here at the Indira Gandhi Athletic Stadium on Monday. Joseph Mayowa Olaleye handed the Assam-based outfit the lead in the 27th minute before FC1 responded through Shakir Ahmad Sheikh, who restored parity five minutes before the interval. Hayat Bashir completed the comeback with a well-taken header in the 53rd minute to seal victory for the side representing Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh. FC1 played the final half hour with ten men after Ivorian defender Tetty Armando Yoko was shown a straight red card just after the hour mark.

Karbi Anglong Morning Star head coach C A Laldinsang Pudaite named a youthful starting XI featuring three foreign recruits, Cameroonian midfielder Junior Onguene Nkengue, Niger forward Joseph Mayowa Olaleye and Nigerian defender Victor Oghenechuko Jackson. Meanwhile, FC1 head coach Khalid Qayoom fielded a side predominantly made up of players from Jammu and Kashmir, with Ivorian defender Tetty Armando Yoko the only overseas player in the starting lineup. FC1 created the first chance of the match when midfielder Mousa Ahmed Qureshi tried his luck from edge of penalty area. His powerful long-range effort forced Karbi Anglong Morning Star goalkeeper Jaspreet Singh into a sharp save, with the custodian tipping the ball safely over the crossbar.

The opening exchanges were played at a lively tempo, with both sides looking to move the ball forward quickly and attack whenever the opportunity arose, making for an entertaining end-to-end contest. Moments later Jaskaran was once again called into action, this time making a save from an effort from Aafreen Basharat

Parray while on the other hand Joseph Olaleye had an attempt on goal from a tight angle which went out without troubling the goalkeeper Aftab Ashraf.

Karbi Anglong Morning Star winger Lalpekhlua was a constant threat down the left flank and played a key role in his side's opening goal just before the first hydration break. FC1 failed to deal with a corner kick, allowing Lalpekhlua to seize on the loose ball and whip a low cross across the six-yard area. Joseph Olaleye reacted quickest, getting in front of his marker to apply a simple finish into an empty net and hand the Diphu-based side the lead.

FC1 responded well after falling behind, enjoying sustained spells of possession in midfield as they looked to exploit the high defensive line employed by Karbi Anglong. Their persistence paid off when Farhan Fayaz produced a perfectly weighted pass over the top for Hayat Bashir, who had broken into acres of space down the right flank. The winger then delivered a low cross across the face of goal, where Shakir Ahmad Sheikh arrived at the perfect moment to slot home and restore parity. The scores remained 1-1 at halftime.

FC1 completed the turnaround eight minutes into the second half with Hayat Bashir finding the back of the net at the end of a well-worked move. This time, first-half goalscorer Shakir Ahmad Sheikh turned provider, delicately chipping an inviting cross into the penalty area. Hayat peeled away from his marker before rising highest to plant a firm header into the net, leaving goalkeeper Jaspreet Singh rooted to the spot as FC1 took the lead. FC1 were reduced to ten men at the hour mark when Ivorian defender Tetty Armando Yoko was shown a straight red card. The centre-back was dismissed for raising his left arm into the face of Karbi Anglong Morning Star winger Lalpekhlua while making a 50-50 challenge, leaving his side to play remainder of match with a numerical disadvantage.

Egyptians are like any other opponent: Anahat Singh

HIMANK NEGI ■ New Delhi

Fresh from becoming the first Indian to win the World Junior Squash Championships title, Anahat Singh has dismissed suggestions that Egyptian players enjoy a psychological edge, saying she has grown up competing against them and treats them like any other opponent. The 17-year-old scripted history by defeating Egypt's Amina Orfi in the final in Ontario, Canada, ending the country's long wait for a world junior singles crown.

"I've grown up playing Egyptians since I've started playing the sport. It doesn't really affect me when I go on court. It's just like playing another opponent, no matter what the nationality is," Anahat told after returning.



The title was particularly satisfying for Anahat after several near misses in the tournament over the last four years.

"This tournament hasn't always been the best for me for the last four years. I've always come really close but failed to overcome it. So I'm really glad that I was able to do it this year," she said.

Anahat is happy about emulating former India No. 1 Joshna Chinappa, the country's previous best performer at the junior worlds.

"I've grown up watching Joshna play and have really been inspired by her. So getting to do it after her is something that I'm really happy about," she said.

Having now graduated from the junior circuit, Anahat said she will shift her attention to senior competitions before targeting Asian Games. (PTI)

Mandaviya lauds CWG weightlifting contingent during felicitation event

HARDIK SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on Monday lauded the strong performance of the Indian weightlifters in the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, saying every medal they won has brought immense joy to the country.

The Indian weightlifting team won one gold, six silver and one bronze in the Games. Olympic medallist Mirabai Chanu was the lone gold winner. The weightlifters were felicitated by Mandaviya after their return to India.

Mirabai was handed a cheque of ₹30 lakh, while the silver and bronze medallists received ₹20 lakh and ₹10 lakh respectively.

"You may not realise it, but every medal you win brings immense joy to the country. Whenever one of you won a medal, the news was announced in Parliament before proceedings began. To those athletes who could not win a medal this time, remember that a sports person never loses. They either win or learn to win again," Mandaviya said during the felicitation event.

"Three of our athletes could not secure medals this time, but I am con-



fident that with the blessings of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the good wishes of 140 crore Indians, they too will return with medals in the future," he added.

For Mirabai, it was her third CWG gold medal on the trot, having also won the yellow metal in 2018 and 2022 editions. "I am extremely happy. I have received so much love. Today, all of us were felicitated, and that is a very big moment for us as athletes. I am happy that I have been able to do something for India," Mirabai said after the felicitation. (PTI)

J&K fast bowler Auqib Nabi earns maiden India call-up in Test squad for Sri Lanka tour

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

After scripting a spectacular victory in the Ranji Trophy finals against Karnataka this year, Jammu and Kashmir fast bowler Auqib Nabi, affectionately nicknamed the "Baramulla Express", has finally earned his maiden national team call-up to the India Test squad for the upcoming two-match series in Sri Lanka, replacing the injured Jasprit Bumrah.

The 29-year-old right-arm medium-pacer from Sheeri village in Baramulla becomes only the third cricketer from Jammu and Kashmir to receive a senior India call-up after Parvez Rasool and Umran Malik, but the first from the region to be selected in India's Test squad.

The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) picked an in-form pacer after

THE 29-YEAR-OLD RIGHT-ARM MEDIUM-PACER FROM SHEERI VILLAGE IN BARAMULLA BECOMES THE THIRD CRICKETER FROM JAMMU AND KASHMIR TO RECEIVE SENIOR INDIA CALL-UP

Bumrah could not fully recover from a left knee injury sustained during the recent ODI series against England. The Men's Selection Committee has named Auqib Nabi as Bumrah's replacement.

Nabi, known for accurate swing and seam bowling, is expected to sharpen India's pace attack during the Test series in Sri Lanka, beginning August 15.

Tears of joy and pure elation filled Nabi's home in Baramulla as news broke that the



Jammu and Kashmir pacer had been named in India's Test squad for the Sri Lanka series. At the centre of the celebration stood his father, voice thick with emotion, describing the moment as the long-awaited fulfilment of a cherished family dream. Years of quiet sacrifice, relentless hard work, unwavering patience and countless prayers had finally found their reward as the "Baramulla Express" earned his maiden call-up to the Indian Test team. "It is difficult to explain my feelings today," said Gulam Nabi Dar, overwhelmed and smiling through tears shortly after the BCCI confirmed Nabi's inclusion as a replacement for the injured Jasprit Bumrah. "This was our dream... and today, it is fulfilled."

Nabi has earned his place in the Team

India with his stellar performance in domestic cricket. He is fast emerging as one of India's most reliable red-ball fast bowlers and also offers useful lower-order runs. His childhood friends also celebrated his selection in TEAM INDIA in Sheeri, Baramulla. Replacing a bowler like Jasprit Bumrah is no small achievement. It shows how far Auqib has come through his hard work and performances," said one of his friends.

Across the last two Ranji Trophy seasons, he claimed 104 wickets. In the 2025-26 campaign, he finished as the tournament's leading wicket-taker with 60 scalps at an average of approximately 12.5-12.6, playing a central role as Jammu and Kashmir lifted the Ranji Trophy for the first time in their history. He was named Player of the Tournament.